
avant-garde videogames
playing with technoculture
brian schrank
foreword by jay david bolter

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Foreword

Jay David Bolter

Among the growing number of books offering to explain the importance of videogames, Brian Schrank's *Avant-garde Videogames* stands out. It is perhaps the only one that engages the history of twentieth-century art in a serious way. The author's knowledge of videogames is broad and deep; he always finds the appropriate example to illustrate his points about the formal, political, or narrative structures of games. At the same time, his understanding of major figures and movements in the twentieth-century avant-garde allows him to argue for videogames as an avant-garde (or rather a set of avant-gardes) with a sense of history that is rare, if not unique, in the area of games studies.

This book belongs to games studies, and it will be read and debated largely in that community as well as by the larger world of digital media and design. I imagine that few students of traditional art and art history will pick up *Avant-garde Videogames*. That is unfortunate, because this book is evidence of an important change in the status of art in our media culture today—a change that the art world has still not addressed. From the end of the eighteenth century to the middle of the twentieth, art occupied a special place in the culture of Europe and North America: it was assigned the task of elevating both the individual and the culture as a whole. Various theorists called attention to this belief in the "autonomy" of art. In its extreme form—for example, in the writings of Matthew Arnold—art replaced religion. The historical avant-garde, such as the Futurists, Dadaists, and surrealists, who Schrank describes briefly and effectively in the chapters that follow, thought that they were challenging such "bourgeois" notions. They believed that their absurd performances as well as strange paintings and assemblages would help to destroy the institution of Art with a capital A, and replace it with practices that could integrate art into

everyday life. The goal of deinstitutionalizing art also motivated the second wave of the avant-garde in the 1950s and beyond: the Situationists, Fluxus, at least some performance and installation art, and so on. In fact, the institutions of art (the gallery and museum system) addressed these avant-garde assaults with the oldest strategy in the world: taking the most compelling avant-garde artists into the galleries and museums, and making them part of the mainstream.

The avant-garde therefore influenced the practice of art throughout the twentieth century, but did not succeed in changing its cultural status. The diminishing status of elite art beginning after the Second World War and accelerating in the 1960s was the result of a complex of economic and social forces. The elite arts of painting and sculpture, literature, and classical music were challenged by the truly popular forms of film, rock music, and television. In any case, the elite arts lost their capital A, as the avant-garde had hoped. Many people continued to go to art museums, read canonical literature (especially in school), and listen to classical music. But it became hard to sustain the notion that one *had* to do these things in order to live a rich cultural life, and hard to believe that our culture as a whole needed painting, classical music, and canonical literature in order to thrive. The change did not happen all at once, and within their own community, artists and critics have often continued to assert their belief in the centrality of art. In order to see that elite art has lost its status, though, we need only look at how the terms *art* and *artist* are used today throughout our media culture. Rock musicians are now routinely interviewed about their art; in fact, artist has long been the term for the performer in popular music. In the iTunes interface, for example, there is no real provision for classical music, in which the composer and performers are both artists. The term *popular culture* itself seems obsolescent, because it has lost its counterpart. In general discourse, *elite* now refers to the best in any field, especially sports, such as elite quarterbacks in football, elite swimmers, or elite golfers. The phrase *cultural elites* is reserved for the disciplines of economics and sociology.

Between 2005 and 2010, film critic Robert Ebert enraged the game community by claiming that videogames could not be "art or at least not high art." Until his death, Ebert continued to assume that high art was still possible. For him, although most movies were popular entertainment, film could itself attain the level of high art, but videogames could not. The

irony is that what was obvious to Ebert (that, say, filmmaker Ingmar Bergman is a great artist) was itself the result of the breakdown of cultural hierarchies in the 1950s and 1960s. For those who still believe in elite culture, film has joined literature and traditional classical music "above the line." When Ebert denied that status to videogames, he himself played a familiar game: the latest members of the club are the most vigilant about upholding its exclusive standards. When, in turn, game designer Clive Barker took on Ebert and defended videogames, he did so not by acknowledging that the terms *art* and *entertainment* are now more or less interchangeable but rather by insisting that videogames can indeed be art. Barker wanted access to the club for videogames.

Although Ebert and Barker did not realize it, the area of agreement between them was more important than their disagreement. Both of them believed (and Barker continues to do so) in the cultural significance, the specialness, of art. Both of them inherited, in other words, the key assumptions of an elite culture, which sixty years ago would have regarded both of their arts as mere entertainment. When elite culture began losing its status in North America (and more slowly in Europe) in the 1960s, the assumptions and rhetoric of elite art did not disappear. Instead, they filtered "down" to the producers and critics of popular entertainment. What filtered down were in fact the assumptions of the then dominant movement in art: modernism. By the 1970s, most of those in the professional art community generally had a more modest view of their own art. For many (perhaps most) in that community, art was no longer universal in its claims to relevance and value. Postmodern art was frequently eclectic and particular. Art did not save culture in general, although art, such as feminist performance art, could still perform a critical cultural function. It was writers on popular media who took up the principles of modernism as self-evident. Popular writers did not—and still do not—always know where these principles came from. They tended to state them as if they had been valid in all times and places, and they combined them arbitrarily with clichés from the nineteenth century about the inspiration of the artist and his or her status as a kind of secular prophet. This variety of popular modernism has survived high modernism by several decades.

The rhetoric of popular modernism is therefore ironic in ways that its exponents do not comprehend. The contemporary art community has abandoned modernism, but that community is no longer the arbiter of art

for our culture. It is an unfortunate fact that writers on digital media do not pay much attention to the rich literature of art history and theory. In particular, their popular modernism has appropriated a simplified notion of the avant-garde from some strands of modernism. The assumption is that the best art must be avant-garde, disruptive of tradition. If the digital medium is to provide a space for great art, then the best digital art must also be avant-garde. Yet at the same time, the term *avant-garde* is now used so widely and casually that it often means little more than "new" or "cool."

What makes Schrank's book unusually valuable is that it rejects the ahistorical formulas of popular modernism. Unlike many in the contemporary art community, Schrank continues to believe in the possibility of the avant-garde today, but he insists on historical contexts. Schrank's book ranges widely and knowledgeably across the avant-garde movements of the twentieth century, looking for parallels and contrasts with the practices of videogame designers. His categories for videogames offer the reader a broad yet sophisticated overview of positions that the historical avant-garde has occupied. These categories set up dichotomies: between formal innovation and political action, and between the radical separation of the artist from the mainstream culture and the artist's complicity with the mainstream. These dichotomies provide a framework that explains much of the creativity of contemporary videogames. At the same time, Schrank realizes that dichotomies such as these are valuable precisely because they help us identify the exceptions: hybrid videogames that are both formal and political, both radically separate from culture and complicit with it. Schrank acknowledges that we living in an era in which the original target of the historical avant-garde has long vanished. He cannily suggests that the videogame avant-garde aims at dismantling not Art with a capital A but rather the seamless flow of technoculture. This notion allows him to avoid the cliché of popular modernism that the way to "validate" digital media in general or videogames in particular is to insist that these new media forms deserve to be honored as Art.

Schrank seeks to honor the legacy of modernism while simultaneously appreciating the diversity of both videogames and our current media culture. His *Avant-garde Videogames* delivers a message that needs to be heard by the videogame community itself, the contemporary art community, and our whole media culture.

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1 Videogames as Avant-garde Art

Videogames are art. In order to value videogames as art, or a cultural force, we need to understand how the videogame avant-garde works. The avant-garde challenges or leads culture. The avant-garde opens up and redefines art mediums. The purpose of this book is to illuminate how the avant-garde emerges through videogames. Videogames shape the avant-garde, while the avant-garde shapes videogames. How does the videogame avant-garde diverge from contemporary and historical avant-garde movements such as tactical media, the Critical Art Ensemble, Net art of the 1990s, video art of the 1960s, Fluxus, the Situationists, Dada, and the impressionists? The contemporary avant-garde faces constraints and opportunities, both cultural and technological in nature, which historical avant-gardes did not face. Videogames were born of a marriage between the military-industrial complex and midway arcade games. The social anxieties and economic outlays of the Cold War were formative for many of the metaphors of power and domination that still frame videogames today. Contemporary culture flows in an elaborate and networked form of digital capitalism—a context that precludes some avant-garde tactics and affords others. As a convergence of technology and cultural practice, videogames are uniquely situated. They are ruled from the bottom, through mass consumption, and from the top, via multinational corporate power. In response to the sheer complexity of the cultural and technological structure of videogames, the avant-garde deploys a host of strategies, ranging from radical to complicit in degree, formal to political in nature, and local to global in scope.

Julian Oliver's *Quilted Thought Organ* (1998–2001) is an avant-garde game. It was built with id Software's first-person shooter *Quake II* engine. The familiar tunnels and mutant enemies, however, are replaced with colorful lattices saturating the space. The environment is navigable, but acting

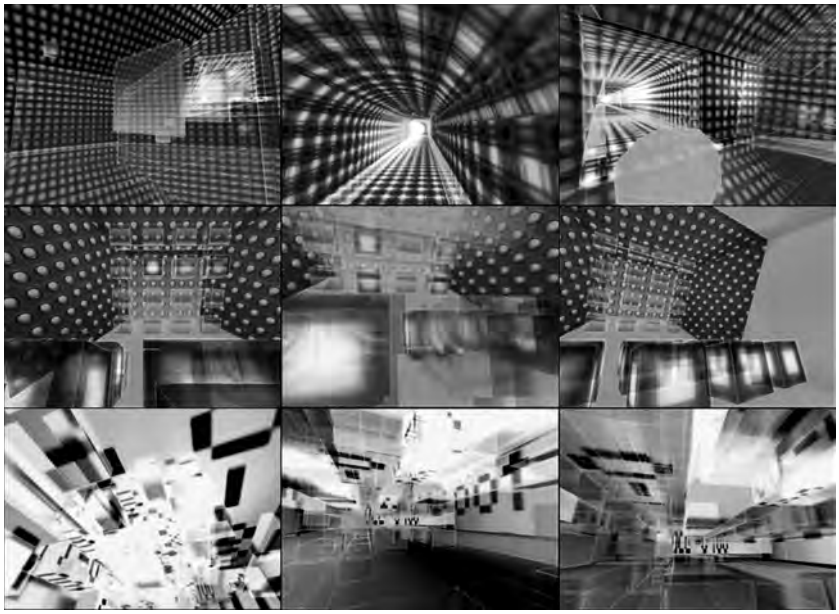


Figure 1.1
Quilted Thought Organ's unusual gameplay opens up new ways for players to perceive, feel, and perform movement through virtual space. Image courtesy of Julian Oliver.

in the world is a strange negotiation. You walk around and atonal music is spawned when you brush through the diaphanous lattices. Turn around to glimpse hypergeometries transforming in your wake; if you stop, so do they. *Quilted Thought Organ* is a "game-based performance environment," a playable version of the call-and-response scene from *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*. The allure of *Quilted Thought Organ* comes from trying to determine the nature and logic of this unusual experience. Reclaiming the experience as a game is its challenge.

Quilted Thought Organ is an avant-garde game in a similar way that modern, abstract paintings were historically avant-garde. In traditional painting, perspectival space (the illusion that an image is a virtual window on a scene) guides and controls the viewer in traditional painting. The rise of avant-garde painting techniques, such as impressionism and cubism, opened alternate ways of viewing and making paintings, calling into question how painting was defined as a medium. Games, like paintings, have their own patterns of perception, interpretation, and participation.

Whether they are 2D or 3D, games use standard regimes of spatial representation as well as entrenched formulas that guide and control players. Games reward certain behaviors, and in doing so, encourage specific actions in the pursuit of particular goals such as progression, dominance, or a high score. Avant-garde games are distinguished from mainstream ones because they show how the medium can manifest a greater diversity of gameplay and be creatively engaged in more kinds of ways by more kinds of people. They redefine the medium, breaking apart and expanding how we make, think, and play with games. The avant-garde democratizes games, and makes the medium more plastic and liquid.

Although it may seem surprising to suggest that the avant-garde is relevant to any contemporary creative practice, this is not a novel claim. Author and new media artist Mark Amerika (2007, 24) writes that "artists who are immersed in digital processes are contemporary versions of what in the twentieth century we used to call the *avant-garde*. Thankfully, they no longer have to pretend to be ahead of their time." The avant-garde has never been about newness or innovation; that is how the avant-garde has been co-opted by institutions and markets. For videogames, the avant-garde is the force that opens up the experience of playing a game or expands the ways in which games shape culture. And since culture is continually changing, the avant-garde must change as well. For example, in the 1990s, the Critical Art Ensemble (1994, 3) recognized that the avant-garde had evolved with the times:

> For many decades, a cultural practice has existed that has avoided being named or fully categorized. Its roots are in the modern avant-garde, to the extent that participants place a high value on experimentation and on engaging the unbreakable link between representation and politics. Perhaps this is a clue as to why this practice has remained unnamed for so long. Since the avant-garde was declared dead, its progeny must be dead too. Perhaps this brood is simply unrecognizable because so many of the avant-garde's methods and narratives have been reconstructed and reconfigured to such an extent that any family resemblance has disappeared.

Videogames too have employed methods that have been "reconstructed and reconfigured" but are still avant-garde. What makes videogames interesting is how their relation to culture and technology is distinct from mediums used by the historical avant-garde. They are also distinct from the cultural materials in use by contemporary avant-garde figures like Orlan, who has undergone plastic surgery as theatrical performance, contending

that the "avant-garde is no longer in art, it is in genetics" (quoted in Ziarek 2004, 89). The avant-garde uses materials that resonate with the time. Because videogames are both caused by and result from change within technoculture, they are especially relevant to contemporary avant-garde practice.

The term *technoculture* is used in media studies to describe the growing interdependence between technology and culture. Of course, technology and culture have always been interdependent, but the level of granularity at which they commingle rapidly grew in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. Marshall McLuhan (1964, 3–4) describes this trend in his book *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man*:

> After three thousand years of explosion, by means of fragmentary and mechanical technologies, the Western world is imploding. During the mechanical ages we had extended our bodies in space. Today, after more than a century of electronic technology, we have extended our central nervous system itself in a global embrace, abolishing both space and time as far as our planet is concerned.

This convergence of human and machine should be viewed as neither positive nor negative. It is simply the material and social reality that the contemporary avant-garde must face if it is to be relevant and effective. Our interaction with the world is increasingly mediated by computer technologies.[1] We experience ever more frequent interactions with machines. In technoculture, the contrasts between public and private, local and global, and human and nonhuman are breaking down. Not only are videogames an advanced product of technoculture, they are also a major site on which culture naturalizes the ways in which we think and play with technology. In this way, each game becomes a microcosm of technoculture itself. Games teach players how to engage and optimize systems as well as how to manage their desire in a contemporary world. This makes the world of games a principal site to expose, unwork, and rethink the protocols and rituals that rule technoculture.

Mainstream and Avant-garde

If we compare two ostensibly similar games, we can generalize some differences between the mainstream and avant-garde. A mainstream title that follows the familiar flow of games is *Heavy Weapon: Atomic Tank* (2005), a commercially successful casual shooter.[2] An avant-garde game that does



Figure 1.2
Players frenetically eliminate all that moves in a tight cycle of flowing action in *Heavy Weapon*. Image courtesy of PopCap.

not serve the familiar flow is *September 12th* (2003), a shooter that makes the requisite skills reflexive and awkward. Although both games are 2D, browser-based Flash games that use the mouse to point and shoot, they manifest remarkably different experiences.

In *Heavy Weapon*, a 1984 backstory lampooning America's mood in the Cold War collides with pre-9/11 war references. The player guides a tiny "atomic" US tank, the last line of defense against the invading Red Star army. The game opens with a cutscene, featuring a US official advising the president to surrender. The secretary of defense retorts, "I've heard enough liberal whining! This is freedom's last stand. . . . Send in . . . ATOMIC TANK!" The kitsch irony sets the perfect mood. The abundant references in *Heavy Weapon* (including atomic weapons, Cold War history, cartoon violence, etc.) jibe together in a jaunty postmodern style that cancels out the need to associate anything at all with the experience. The ensuing gameplay lights up the center of the brain with eye-fluttering finger clicks. According to PopCap, *Heavy Weapon* "brings classic shooter action to the casual gamer." It is a cartoonlike, side-scrolling shoot 'em up with "easy-to-learn mechanics." The real appeal of *Heavy Weapon* is the contrast between



Figure 1.3
September 12th simulates the ideology of the war on terror as a positive feedback loop of escalating violence. Image courtesy of Gonzalo Frasca.

its two core modes of fight and flight requiring the player to employ offensive and defensive skills simultaneously. The player tracks objects with the mouse to shoot at everything that moves while steering a vehicle to dodge a storm of bullets. Unexpected complications arise to keep the player off guard; an aid helicopter, for example, flies into the heat of battle to drop power-ups, nukes, shields, and upgrades. The entire experience collapses into a typical twitch reflex cocoon that is apolitical and ahistorical.

Developed by Newsgaming and designed by Gonzalo Frasca, *September 12th* immediately positions the player as a political subject. On launching the game, the screen reads, "The rules are deadly simple. You can shoot. Or not. This is a simple model you can use to explore some aspects of the war on terror."[3] When the player hits play, they gaze on an isometric Arab town where residents circulate peacefully down narrow streets and a few terrorists, wearing kaffiyehs or white headdresses, mix in. The player might be inclined to aim and fire a missile at one of them. A short delay prior

to launch makes clean, accurate kills nearly impossible. Bystanders die. Onlookers grieve, and a few become enraged. Flashing and bleeping, the mourners morph into a new generation of terrorists. As more terrorists are targeted for destruction, more are created and the euphemism of "surgical strikes" unravels along with the flow of the game.

Heavy Weapon and *September 12th* deliver two opposing experiences. *Heavy Weapon* channels players into a tightly closed circuit of play; *September 12th* opens up that circuit, revealing and reveling in its own nature as a game. Instead of training players to aim clicks quickly, *September 12th* makes it obvious just how entrained and established these skills as well as expectations have become. A microcosm of twitch reflexes spirals out into a macrocosm of geopolitics. *Heavy Weapon* has the opposite effect. An expansive set of geopolitical references flush players into a singular flow of familiar experience. Mainstream games strengthen the prevailing paradigm of flow, while avant-garde games weaken it, opening play to alternate paradigms.

Opening Up the Definition of *Videogame*

One of the difficulties with studying games is that definitions are often design documents in disguise. In this book, we will need the broadest workable definition of videogame possible, or the subject we set out to explore will be blinkered from view from the start.

The problem of prescriptive definitions is certainly not unique to games. The Renaissance definition of *painting* was a design document of sorts. It described what painting was, while elaborating on best practices to maximize its unique illusory power. In his 1435 treatise *De Pictura*, Leon Battista Alberti defined paintings as a virtual "window" and expounded on pivotal mechanics, such as establishing a vanishing point to achieve a convincing illusion of depth. The avant-garde ultimately challenged that definition at the turn of the twentieth century, and began folding, warping, cutting up, and reassembling the window. In "Definition of Neotradition," published in 1890, artist and critic Maurice Denis advised the salon public, "It is well to remember that a picture—before being a battle horse, a nude woman, or some anecdote—is essentially a plane surface covered with colours assembled in a certain order." According to Denis, then, painting was no longer to be defined as a virtual window but instead as pigment on

a surface—which Jackson Pollock's drip paintings potently embodied a few generations later.

As expected, subsequent avant-gardes challenged Denis's definition. Mediums are always in flux, most of all for the avant-garde. Conceptual artist Sol LeWitt conceived of painting as an idea rather than a material construct. For LeWitt, the defining element of a painting was in the series of choices made in its construction, not the presence of fibers and pigment. Thus, anyone can produce a LeWitt painting, which called for bright acrylic paint or India ink washes, and read like a series of instructions: *Wall Drawing #46* (1970), for example, is "vertical lines, not straight, not touching, covering the wall evenly."

Who is right: Alberti, Denis, or LeWitt? Are paintings illusions, materials, concepts, or something else still? Each definition presents a viable approach to understanding or making a painting, and suggests that painting is not advancing toward a specific predestined purpose or goal. In fact, the medium of painting is increasingly open, plastic, and malleable in the hands of each succeeding avant-garde.

Like many writers, I have been using the terms game and videogame interchangeably, but only for the sake of brevity. How have others used the terms? In *Half-Real: A Dictionary of Video Game Theory*, Jesper Juul defines videogame as "a game played using computer power and a video display." Most accept the tautology that videogames are defined by their gameness. Juul (2005, 36) elaborates:

> A game is a rule-based system with a variable and quantifiable outcome, where different outcomes are assigned different values, the player exerts effort in order to influence the outcome, the player feels emotionally attached to the outcome, and the consequences of the activity are negotiable.

In this definition, the dance of visual phenomena on-screen serves almost exclusively as evidence to direct the player into certain courses of action. Such features are given attention, but only according to how they inform the subject as a game in the most conservative sense. Juul (2005, 1) does discuss the role of fiction, however, noting that to "play a video game is therefore to interact with real rules *while* imagining a fictional world." Although Juul's definition is useful, it omits from view forces that are material or sensual, so we must expand his conception.

In contrast to Juul, who targets games (again, in the most conservative sense) as the core of the medium, game industry pioneer Chris Crawford

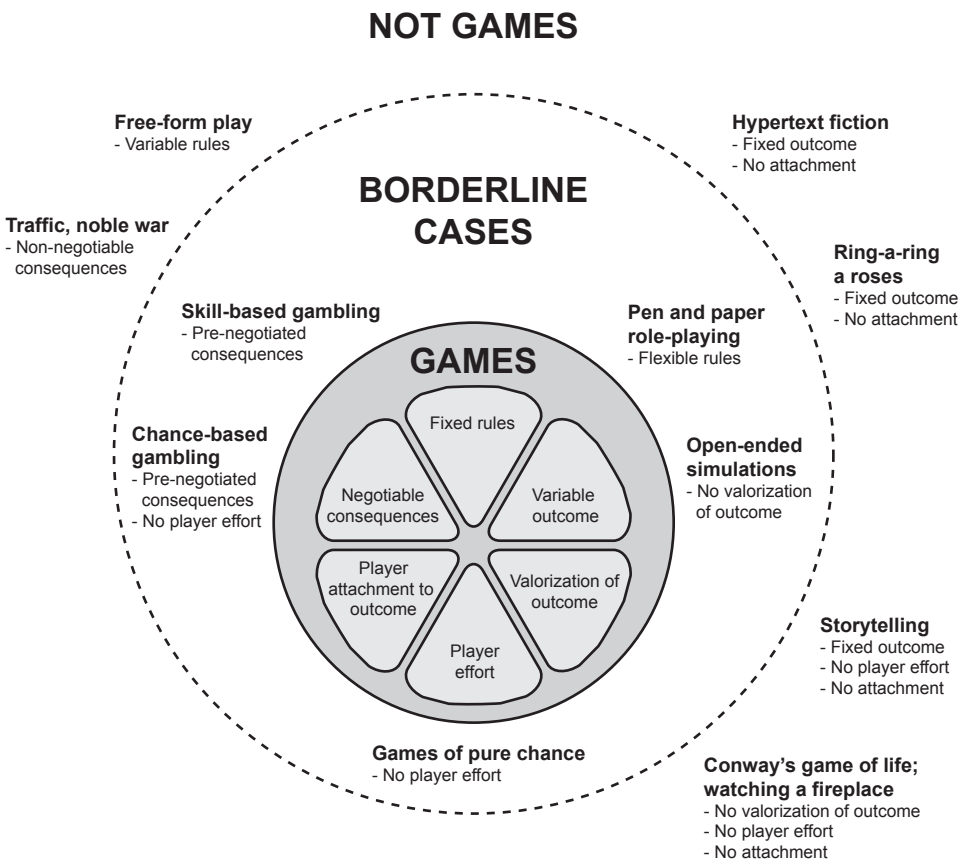


Figure 1.4
Jesper Juul targets a fictional center "gameness" in the medium of videogames. Image courtesy of Jesper Juul.

targets something else. Crawford acknowledged in the 1980s that videogames, by definition, have a core material component. In fact, that core material affordance must be fully exploited by game designers if the medium is to reach its full potential:

> Interactiveness is a central element of game enjoyment. . . . [T]he computer's plasticity makes it an intrinsically interactive device. Yet, the potential inherent in the computer can easily go unrealized if it is programmed poorly. A program emphasizing static data is not very dynamic. It is not plastic, hence not responsive, hence not interactive. A process-intensive program, by contrast, is dynamic, plastic, responsive, and interactive. Therefore, store less and process more. (Crawford 1984)

Although Crawford goes further than Juul by grounding his formulation of the medium in the physical properties of the computer, he cannot leave these open to play. There is just one path to follow: maximize procedural power above all else. He leaves no room for a diversity of play in games—say, for an artwork that stores more and processes less.

The technological affordances of specific hardware, software, and their contingent sensual signatures also comprise the formal nature of videogames. The commercial industry doesn't ignore these, so why should artists, designers, or academics? One of the lowest common denominators in recent decades has been the drive toward convincing photorealism and beyond. If we are to cultivate the potential of the medium, we cannot afford to overlook critical characteristics that don't fit our definition or narrative of what videogames are supposed to be. We cannot ignore what is happening right now with games. Indeed, a key strategy of the avant-garde is to engage videogames as they are, not just as we wish them to be. Sensuality, materiality, economics, commercial trends, and popular conventions are as definitive as well as integral to videogames as a platonic ideal of gameness. The avant-garde is not afraid to explore and exaggerate these affordances as it makes games more open, plastic, and liquid. This is how the avant-garde unravels and outstrips mainstream games and game culture.

For game culture, the idea that "videogames are games" is irrefutable. But turn this around. Why not also examine the idea that "videogames are videos"? Videogames are played on LCD, LED, and plasma screens, so video in the traditional sense does not describe the hardware. Nevertheless, it does stand in for all the support technologies that constrain and allow games to function. The avant-garde is able to see unique artistic potential in the *video* of videogames.

The Night Journey is a game collaboration by Bill Viola, a renowned video artist, and the Game Innovation Lab at the University of Southern California. *Night Journey* is a videogame-enabled dream, one part *Dragon's Lair*, one part uncanny video art, and one part virtual camera controlled in 3D space. The artists call it "explorable video" (Fullerton 2009). Intensity in games normally comes from rising challenges that demand an increase in skill or effort. In *Night Journey*, though, intensity comes from the visual slurring of a living environment and the player's warped presence within it. It does not feel like the player is traversing the environment, although that is what is happening. It feels more like the player is a ghost melting through



Figure 1.5
Looking up through the trees in *The Night Journey*, a collaboration of Bill Viola Studios and the University of Southern California's Game Innovation Lab. The work foregrounds the video in *video*game by bridging laserdisc games like *Dragon's Lair* and video art. Image courtesy of Bill Viola Studios and the USC Game Innovation Lab.

a black-and-white dreamscape. There is a lugubrious sensual logic that the creatures and slow-dancing plants emanate. When a fish or bird hauntingly appears, for instance, it hovers there like some endearing bug-eyed hallucination. It is trying to communicate something that is just beyond the edge of making sense, and in order for the player to "get it," their sanity must slip a bit into that dreamworld. Once the player has slipped, it takes a moment to realize that they are already moving on in that undulating dreamtime.

Night Journey explores videogames both as they are and as they could be. Instead of rendering the visual spectacle as subservient to the gameplay, a popular practice among game enthusiasts, *Night Journey* accepts the game industry's quest for greater graphic intensity and doubles down. The artists leverage this feature as an affordance to focus on and exaggerate. In

looking at videogames as they could be, *Night Journey* goes beyond photorealism, dynamically connecting the spectacle to player action. The conventional qualities of immersive space fold inward, oozing through the dreamy wrinkles of zoned-out gameplay.

Game designer Will Wright has asserted that *The Sims* and *SimCity* are software toys rather than games. That is unfortunate. Mainstream culture refers to them as games. If we accept *The Sims* and *SimCity* as games, the challenge they present to our academic definitions becomes an opportunity to cultivate a richer appreciation of the medium. If we hold to the idea that not only *The Sims* but also *September 12th*, *Night Journey*, and *Quilted Thought Organ* are in fact videogames, then the cultural frame that holds them fractures, diversifies, and expands. If we can allow many definitions of videogame to aggregate into a composite, fractured image, we have an avant-garde perspective. It is a vision as uncomfortable as it is lively, challenging, and historically grounded.

Rather than carving out a perfect definition of videogames and holding each game up to that ideal, we can reverse the process. Each avant-garde game presents its own definition of the medium that challenges the status quo. If avant-garde games were to compose a collective definition of the medium, that portrayal would hang awkwardly open: *videogames are playing with technoculture*. Avant-garde games crack open the patterns of the world in games and beyond so we may reengage in a radical kind of play with them.

Avant-garde Is a Diverse Field of Formal and Political Strategies

Historically, multiple avant-gardes have existed simultaneously, sometimes in direct opposition to one another and clearly contradicting the popular myth of a single avant-garde ideal. This is a feature as opposed to a bug. In 1914, Beatrice Forbes-Robertson Hale, a British émigré to the United States, surveyed modern feminism in a way that emphasized this quality of diversity in the avant-garde. Hale described feminism using avant-garde rhetoric: "The metaphor of an army to delineate the main body of parliamentary suffragists, the rear of municipal suffragists, a vanguard of 'advanced feminists,' and an ultra-radical group of 'skirmishers'" (quoted in Delap 2007, 1). According to Hale, certain kinds of feminist work could only be accomplished from certain positions of power. She recognized that radical,

anarchistic actions could subvert government power and threaten social stability. On the other hand, complicit feminist forces within government could leverage those radicals in order to gain progressive concessions. This need not be seen as a leader-driven conspiratorial plot, however, nor is it limited to the suffragist movement. A similar dynamic was reflected in the 1960s in the tensions between Martin Luther King Jr. and the early Malcolm X: they opposed each other's strategies. From a position of peace and a position of violence, they flanked the white middle class from both sides, like a vise, creating an emergent, collective effort to seize equal rights. As an expansive, chaotic system, the avant-garde thus develops and distributes its efforts without a single coordinator (who would not likely be obeyed in any case).

Hal Foster (1996, 8), an art historian and theorist of the "contemporary avant-garde," similarly disputes the assumption that "*one* theory can comprehend *the* avant-garde." This realization is growing among academics. Regarding contemporary avant-garde theater, James Harding (2010, 12) criticizes the "notion that there is 'the avant-garde' rather than a variety of avant-garde communities, trajectories, or traditions."

Another popular myth is that the avant-garde is about negation, and presumably, the more critical or offensive it is, the better, or at least the more avant-garde. That story is not true either. Visual theorist and cultural critic Johanna Drucker (2005, 251) argues that the avant-garde "is not what the academy has made of it. Every instance of playful engagement, of serious exchange, of complex attraction and adoration and longing" has been overwritten. Drucker (ibid., 251–252) summarizes the problem: "The legacy of oppositional criticism, of a negative position claiming moral superiority and distance from those ideologies, . . . can't be sustained any more. Mythic though they were, these belief systems do not accurately describe either our current condition or our past history." The historical avant-garde has been mischaracterized, which has perpetuated a popular misunderstanding regarding the contemporary avant-garde among many theorists and academics. We must broaden and diversify our framing of the avant-garde if we are to understand it.

We can begin by distinguishing two broad avant-garde strategies, a *formal* avant-garde and a *political* avant-garde, thus opening up and supporting difference across communities of practice. The avant-garde described by the iconic modern art critic Clement Greenberg in "Avant-garde and

Kitsch" advances the formal view. The avant-garde depicted by Peter Bürger in *Theory of the Avant-garde* presents the political view. The formal avant-garde is realized in individual experience, letting art advance itself without regard for social concerns; the political avant-garde is realized in collective experiences, politicizing art or using art to change society. The formal avant-garde champions the old adage "art for art's sake."

The formal avant-garde investigates the properties of a given artistic medium. Each medium has unique affordances, sensual capacities, and a cultural history from which to construct work. The task of the formal avant-garde artist is to expose, challenge, or redefine these features. Greenberg (1939) portrays avant-garde painting in medium-specific terms:

> Picasso, Braque, Mondrian, Miró, Kandinsky, Brancusi, even Klee, Matisse and Cézanne derive their chief inspiration from the medium they work in. The excitement of their art seems to lie most of all in its pure preoccupation with the invention and arrangement of spaces, surfaces, shapes, colors, etc., to the exclusion of whatever is not necessarily implicated in these factors.

Greenberg's formalist category of avant-garde art is synonymous with modern art of the last half of the nineteenth century and first half of the twentieth century. According to formal theory, mediums should seek to be reflexive and reveal their own form. Abstract splatter paintings revel in their own flat surface rather than trying to create illusions of receding space and dimension. Likewise in music, arrangements of the twelve tones need not sink us into reverie, evoke a preset series of emotions, or convey a story; dissonant tensions and collisions among tones can shape the experience instead. Avant-garde filmmaker Stan Brakhage glued grass and insects directly onto celluloid. As the film clacked and flickered through the projector, the actual apparatus of film—the projector, celluloid, light, faculties of perception and cognition, the darkened roomful of people, and so on—was foregrounded and illuminated. In this way, Brakhage explored what the experience of film might be, beyond its established eventful, narrative structures.

Employing similar strategies, formal avant-garde games manifest the irreducibility of play that lives beyond the familiar flow. *Quilted Thought Organ* is a good example. Oliver's work offers a novel mechanic of movement as sound, emphasizing one of the core features of first-person shooter engines: the moment-to-moment act of navigating Cartesian space. Trying to make sense of that distorted gamespace presents a meta-challenge that

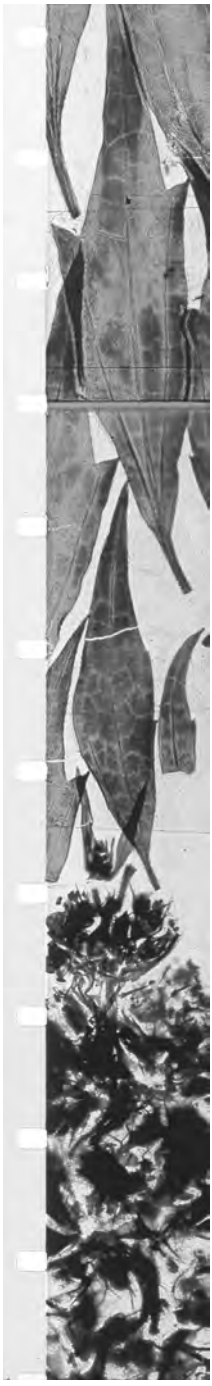


Figure 1.6
Stan Brakhage glued moth wings and grass onto celluloid in the film *Mothlight* (1963), so we might "imagine an eye unruled by man-made laws of perspective," and see images without perceiving them as narratives, symbols, and spaces. Image courtesy of the Estate of Stan Brakhage and Fred Camper (http://www.fredcamper.com).

compounds the usual challenges. The conventional challenges of games are displaced, leaving a rawer, more essential experience to play with. Game art enthusiasts often get snagged on the demand that the player must read the artist's intent or expression in the work. Perhaps, but the more that formal games are able to "speak" for themselves, the more provocative the experiences of playing them can be.

Historically, political avant-garde artists played with the category of art itself, frequently denying that the work they were making could even be categorized as art. This is similar to contemporary game artists who deny that what they make are games—an assertion so common that leading mainstream figures, such as Wright, as mentioned earlier, make this claim. The Dadaists provide examples of the historical political avant-garde. Responding to the upheavals of World War I, Dada created shocking theatrical events as a means of provoking and transforming culture. Richard Huelsenbeck, a Dadaist, asks: "What is German culture? Answer: Shit!" Opposing the formal avant-garde, Dadaists mocked Édouard Manet and Paul Cézanne, two prominent painters of the nineteenth century.

In *The Return of the Real: The Avant-garde at the End of the Century*, however, Foster argues that we must adopt a more nuanced perspective and less dualistic perspective on the historical avant-garde if we are to understand the contemporary avant-garde and all that has changed in the past century. Foster (1996, 16) begins with Duchamp, whose "aim is neither an abstract negation of art nor a romantic reconciliation of art and life but a perpetual testing of the conventions of both. Thus rather than false, circular, and otherwise affirmative, avant-garde practice is at its best contradictory, mobile, and otherwise diabolical." Duchamp placed a rotated urinal on a pedestal, signed it with a pseudonym, titled it *Fountain*, and submitted it to the Society of Independent Artists, of which Duchamp was a member. The society agreed that they would accept all submissions in alphabetical order—a transgressive move in its own right. But they rejected *Fountain*, a piece of art that toyed with the institution of art, its arbitrary assignments of value, and its adherence to entrenched definitions. *Fountain* makes another move in plain sight, though, and one that is often missed. It foregrounds and aestheticizes the ways in which we normally sense—or more accurately, fail to sense—technology. As the institution of art is brought down, an industrial object that we routinely interact with in private is lifted up from its conventional use. It becomes a heavy object in pristine gloss, a familiar thing

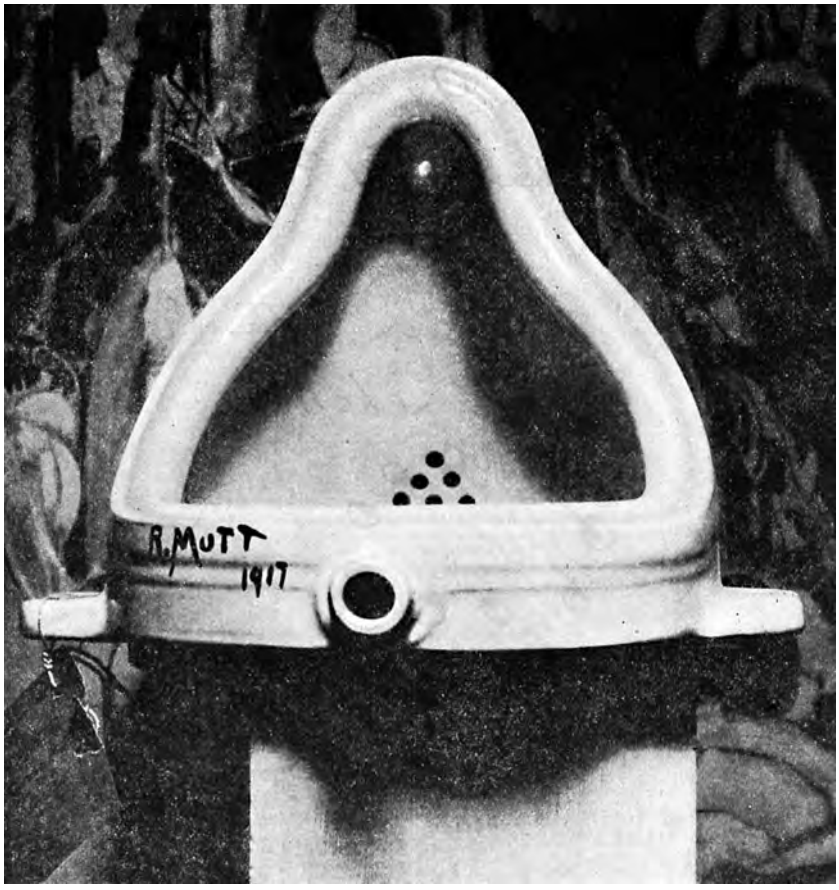


Figure 1.7
Marcel Duchamp's *Fountain* (1917) played *with* the rules of art, reworking its definition, rather than playing *in* the established rules of art. Photograph by Alfred Stieglitz. Reproduced with permission from Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York.

that gazes back, asserting its presence and mass in an unfamiliar way. *Fountain* is surreal, sitting useless, glistening and gaping. Like other readymades, it manages to flout artistic convention while still evoking the irreducibility of artistic experience. This is how the political avant-garde creates and destroys art. Art is made impossible and possible again. Failure and success lose much of their meaning in avant-garde art.

So what of the contemporary political avant-garde? Each avant-garde emerges from and contends with its own cultural moment. Today, it engages the category of technocultural entertainment rather than art in the traditional sense, because that is where the action is. Foster (ibid., 21) summarizes it best, stating that a "reconnection of art and life *has* occurred, but under the terms of the culture industry," and rather "than render the avant-garde null and void, these developments have produced new spaces of critical play and prompted new modes of institutional analysis." Culture increasingly mobilizes its values through entertainment and technology instead of though the church, museum, or academy. That is where routines of control, violence, and desire are normalized as well as propagated.

Politically avant-garde gameplay targets social institutions, as games are destroyed and reborn in public. Griefers provide a good illustration of this. They are players who challenge other players beyond the established scope of a given game. Griefers question and manipulate the rituals as well as protocols of massively multiplayer online (MMO) games like *World of Warcraft* and virtual worlds like *Second Life*. One griefer tactic is to deploy "grey goo," self-replicating objects that multiply beyond the system's ability to model and present them. In *Second Life*, grey goo can take any form, ranging from the golden rings in *Sonic the Hedgehog* to severed heads. It can begin with a single ring falling from the sky. It spawns two more rings, which then spawn four. Growing exponentially, the rings outpace the capacity of the server at Linden Lab running that section of the world. If a server crashes or slows, everyone logged on is affected; hence the term *grid attack*. Grey goo is a visual-spatial analog of a distributed denial of service (DDoS) attack that floods websites with spoofed data requests until the server is crippled.

Griefers break down games and rebuild new kinds of games with the pieces. They open up alterior play patterns that restructure the very systems that make the games possible. The presence of computer protocols—normally veiled and subservient to the flow of consumption—erupts as grey

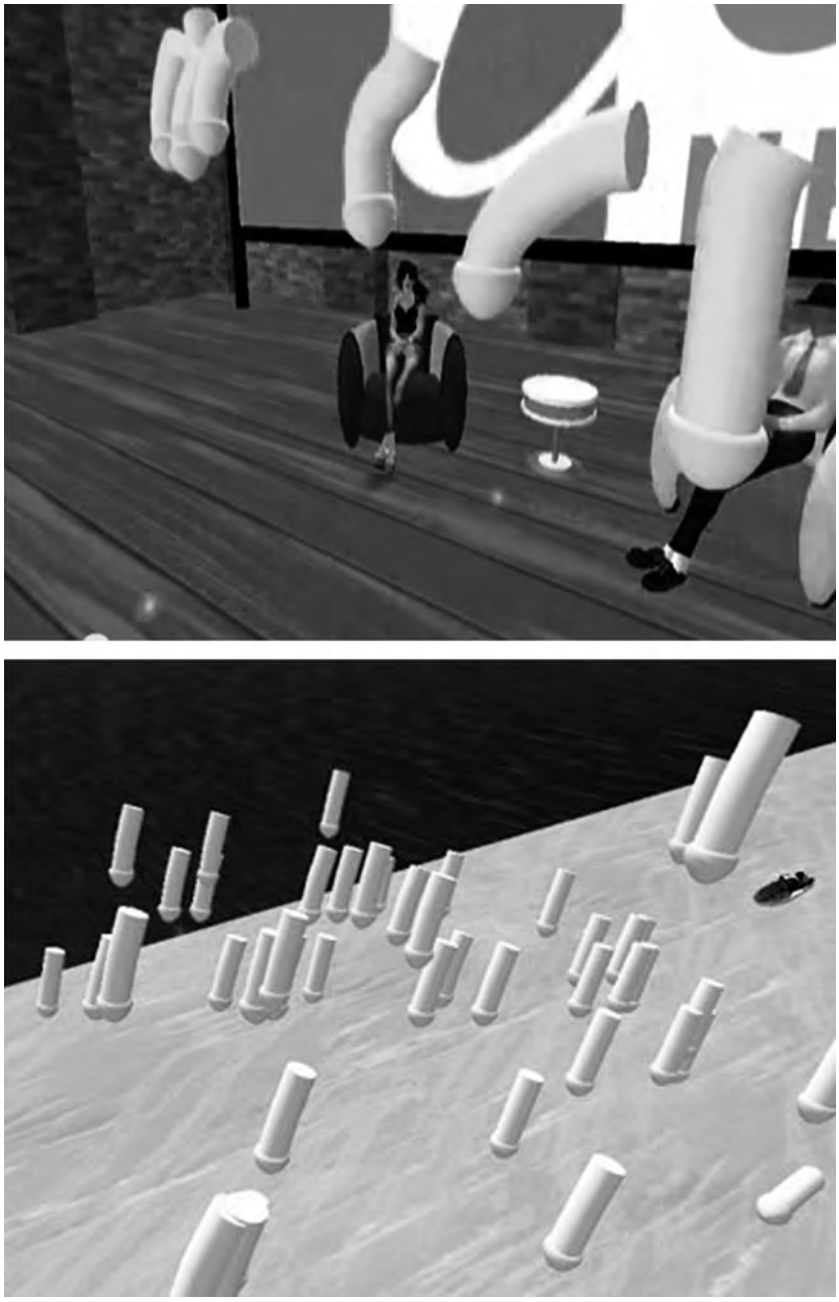


Figure 1.8
A griefer attack at a CNET conference in *Second Life* spawns grey goo objects that self-replicate beyond control. Images courtesy of Richard "Lowtax" Kyanka.

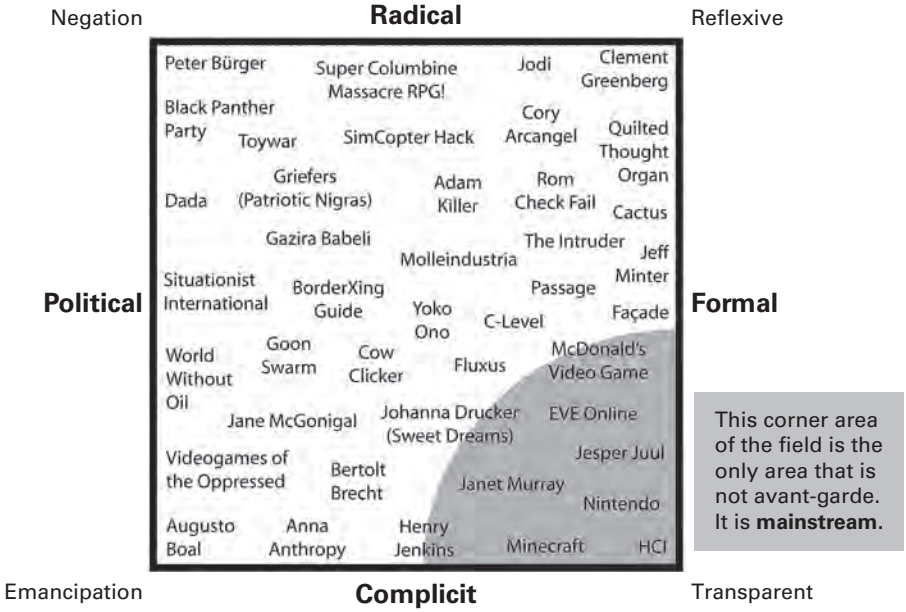


Figure 1.9
The avant-garde is comprised of a diverse field of figures. The only area that is not avant-garde is the lower-right one, because it is both complicit and depoliticized.

goo that pushes back. Griefers reframe the gamespace as a contested public space. They demonstrate that virtual worlds have diverse and previously unrealized aesthetic properties with which to play. Scripting, social engineering, and hacking the collective flow become core gameplay mechanics. Academics once wrongly assumed that the avant-garde of the early twentieth century brought about the end of art, only to realize decades later that the avant-garde had actually redefined art itself. Although it may seem that today's radical political avant-garde is merely breaking games, it is actually opening up the definition of games in the twenty-first century.

The avant-garde varies in intensity from radical to complicit as it ranges in purpose from enacting politics to crafting formal works. To comprehend its diversity, we might imagine its members spread out across a field, organized around two intersecting continua: a radical-to-complicit axis and a political-to-formal axis. For example, most political figures are not as radical as Dada or griefers. Bertolt Brecht, a prominent playwright after

World War I, used theater as a way to propagate political thought through popular culture. He valued theater as popular entertainment, curving its force toward political ends rather than overtly challenging it. We can think of Frasca's *September 12th* in the same vein. Frasca and Brecht are not griefers. *September 12th* challenges the medium, of course, but not in an extremely radical or difficult way. The game implicates the player in an argument on the futility of the war on terror, while also being a fun game. Frasca and Brecht belong to the more complicit or accessible political avant-garde. The relative ease with which we engage their work is evident when compared to the incendiary Dada and griefers. The latter could be seen as a radical or hard political avant-garde. To play through a griefer attack is difficult, if not impossible, for most people. Complicit works or political events are less mind bending, sense assaulting, or code demanding to play than radical works. Players are given greater opportunity to find their bearings, give their senses and computer a break, and lean more heavily on conventions.

We can evaluate the avant-garde according to how it opens up the experience of games (formal art) or the experience of being in the world (political art). The common feature of the formal and political avant-garde is how it deviates from our own adaptations, such as our training in the efficient use of computer interfaces and networks to enact our desire and extend our control. The avant-garde helps us to unwork the flow of power as well as act according to alternate logics that are neither agonistic and dominating nor submissive and instrumental. The constituent parts of technoculture are given room to drift, giving us slack to appreciate a blended and open way of being. The goal is neither a better synthesis with technology nor a decoupling from technology via some idealized return to nature. The aim of the avant-garde is to open up games and the world to what is unfamiliar to each. Different artists use different strategies to achieve an avant-garde perspective. Some fixate on form, and others on politics; some take radical positions, using extreme measures, while others take more complicit positions. In chapters 2 through 5, I examine those strategies and the artists who take them up. I look closely at four families of the avant-garde—radical formal, radical political, complicit formal, and complicit political—while noting that there are yet other avant-gardes to be explored and other ways to slice through the field.

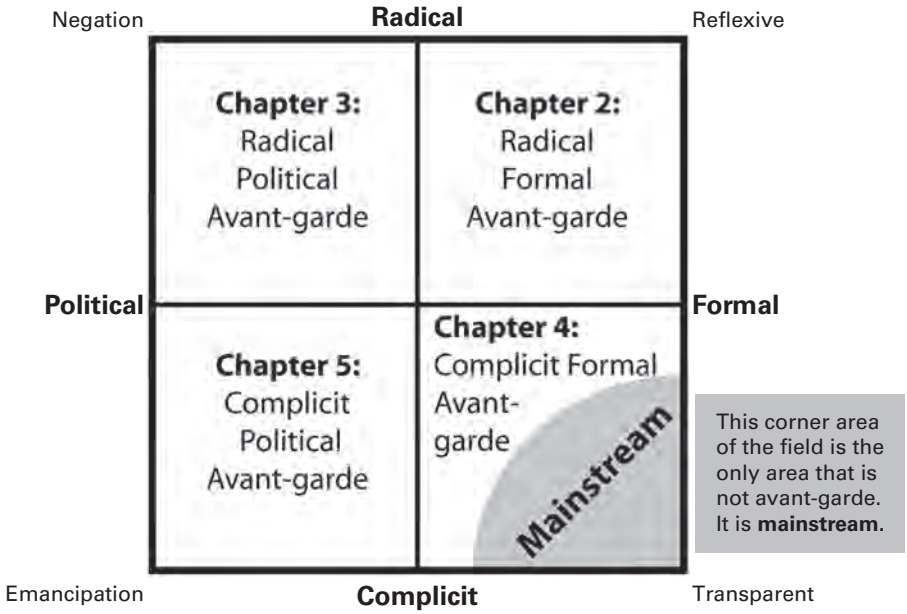


Figure 1.10
Each of the four following chapters examines a category of avant-garde strategies. Every chapter touches on mainstream games, which occupy the lower-right area.

Chapter Summaries

Chapter 2: Radical Formal

It is standard in the game community to desire gameplay that puts players into the zone or flow.[4] Flow is the "sense that one's skills are adequate to cope with the challenges at hand in a goal directed, rule bound action system that provides clear clues as to how one is performing" (Csíkszentmihályi 1991, 71). Although most games do not consistently offer a sense of flow to all players, most designers strive for it. The contemporary radical formal videogame avant-garde opens up alternate ways of engaging and playing videogames, calling into question what defines them as a medium. Formal games break up the flow in richly reflexive ways. They set up situations in which we can play more explicitly with the materiality, sensuality, and conventionality of videogames as an artistic medium.

The use of linear perspective in naturalistic painting is analogous to the creation of optimal gameplay flow. Just as perspective both guides and

controls the viewer in traditional painting, common formulas guide players toward flow in videogames. Perspectival space guides and controls the viewer in traditional painting. The rise of such formal avant-garde painting movements as impressionism and cubism rejected perspectival space, and revealed alternate ways of looking at and making paintings. These changes called into question how painting was defined as a medium.

Chapter 3: Radical Political

The radical political avant-garde challenges the definitions of play established in the mid-twentieth century by recalling the premodern magic circle, which blends worlds rather than divides them. This avant-garde strategy reminds us that reality is in play and that play requires real risk. Political avant-garde works like *Toywar* play with art and politics as well as fictions and everyday life, blending and transforming these categories in the process. In 1999, billion-dollar toy retailer eToys.com threatened to sue the artist group etoy for trademark infringement. In response, etoy launched *Toywar*, an MMO in which players could drive down the actual price of eToys' stock on NASDAQ.

Similarly, the highly stylized marches and protests organized in the 1960s and 1970s by the original Black Panther Party were a form of avant-garde political theater, inspired by such Harlem street theater groups as the Black House (Reed 2005, 49–50). In spite of the internal violence that weakened the movement, the Black Panthers nevertheless helped redefine "black people" in US popular culture as self-assertive subjects of history rather than submissive objects of history.

Chapter 4: Complicit Formal

The complicit formal avant-garde does not advance specific mediums. On the contrary, it questions whether videogames or any other art medium (painting, film, video, and so on) are indeed unique mediums. Videogames are treated as a resource from popular culture that can be used to make fun and relevant contemporary art. Individual mediums may be illusory, but art as a cultural practice is not. Complicit formal artists still pursue art for art's sake, yet are mischievously liberal and humorous in what they consider to be art, because they have learned from the failures and successes of the historical avant-garde. For example, Nam June Paik, a Fluxus artist, humanized and demystified Cold War technology in the 1960s by assembling a

tottering robot that defecated beans while broadcasting a Kennedy speech. This avant-garde creates "art games" in the loosest possible sense, making use of diverse strategies such as putting games in traditional gallery spaces, constructing manic cyborgs, and affordance mining household materials for their hidden, play-enabling properties. In *Cockfight Arena*, a game by C-Level, for instance, players wear awkward, feathered costumes wired to control two fighting roosters on-screen.

Chapter 5: Complicit Political

The complicit political avant-garde uses the magic circle to blend life, art, play, and reality, in a manner similar to that of the radical political avant-garde. The difference is that the complicit political avant-garde blends worlds using more inviting, populist methods. We are asked to risk the stability of the world so that we may collectively generate ad hoc utopias and moments of collective, festive anarchy. The word *utopia* evokes a fantasy of perfect governance, thanks to writers such as Sir Thomas More, who coined it. The problem of utopia as a literary genre is that it is something already written—a dead law on a page. In contrast, avant-garde utopias can be continually rewritten in play. In the 1960s, the Situationists used new media in an attempt to reshape everyday life. They took the remix tactics of Dada and made them accessible to a broader public, reframing urban space as an open artwork and game. A contemporary example can be found in alternate reality games (ARGs), which bring Situationist strategies to a contemporary public. ARGs are collective, participatory narratives played by scalable, networked communities across new and old media platforms.

Chapter 6: Narrative Formal

The narrative formal avant-garde expands how narratives and language are structured as well as engaged in both radical and complicit ways. For new media theorist Janet Murray (1997, 142), a "game is a kind of abstract storytelling that resembles the world of common experience but compresses it in order to heighten interest." The narrative formal avant-garde does not merely resemble the world through games; it disturbs that resemblance to make it stand out in relief. The historical precedent for this avant-garde is Russian formalism, a progenitor of various modern literary and aesthetic

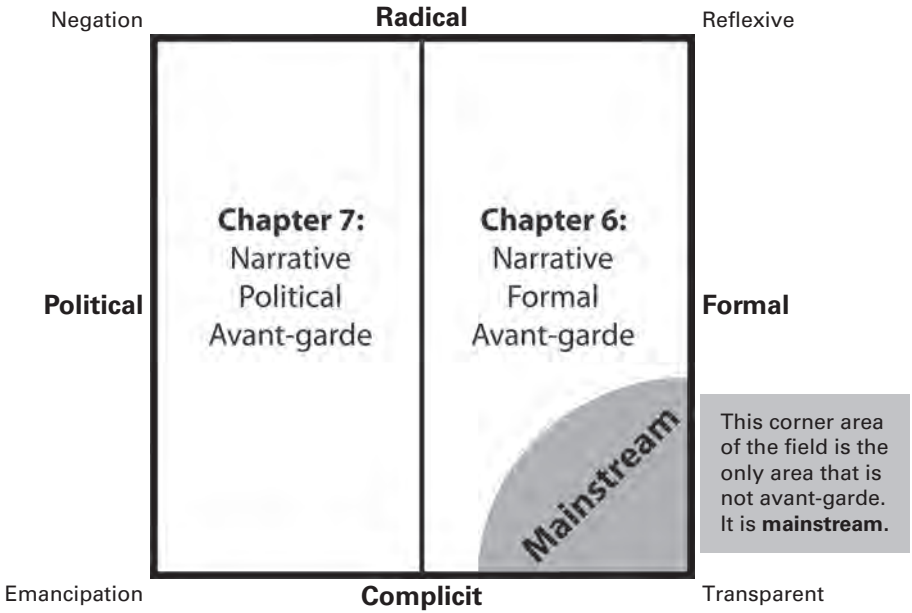


Figure 1.11
Chapters 6 and 7 examine the narrative avant-garde along formal and political perspectives.

philosophies in the twentieth century. The Russian formalists were the first avant-garde to formulate theories of medium specificity in general along with the autonomy of poetic language and literature in particular. Their goal was to pull "us into a dramatic awareness of language, [which] refreshes these habitual responses and renders objects more 'perceptible'" (Eagleton 1996, 3). The key tactics are to *defamiliarize* and *estrange*. Interactive fiction (IF) is a treasure trove of narrative formal avant-garde games. In classic text adventures, the player types commands to control their avatar, manipulate objects, and advance the story. Because of the parser's inability to accept the plasticity of everyday language, the effect of defamiliarization is often unintentionally realized.

Chapter 7: Narrative Political

The narrative political avant-garde uses popular entertainment to transform culture. Brecht, as noted earlier, was a prominent playwright after

World War I who bent the force of theater toward political ends instead of uncompromisingly challenging the status quo. *September 12th* is a Brechtian game in which players experience the causal structure of the war on terror. Augusto Boal, a contemporary activist, founded the Theater of the Oppressed movement, which builds on the Brechtian model of political art. In Brecht's theater, the audience is still passive. For Boal, spectators must breach the stage to tell their own stories. To distribute knowledge and power over the social "weapon of theater," Boal traveled to rural villages and urban ghettos throughout Latin America. In Boalian games, players become programmers, easily reworking games. The long-term goal of the narrative political avant-garde is to democratize or liquefy artistic mediums so anyone can reconfigure and use them. It will eventually be easy for the average person to make, remix, and share videogames, just as the average person can now make, remix, and share digital texts, photographs, videos, and music through social media.

Chapter 8: Conclusion

This volume is not an exhaustive account of the videogame avant-garde. It is instead a map of some of the territory that the avant-garde is currently exploring with games. Although critics commonly label examples of videogame art and the avant-garde as a single type (political, formal, radical, narrative, expressive, critical, etc.), that kind of reductionism is misleading, as each of those strategies represents just one perspective on a sprawling, disordered, changing, and complex movement. The strategies of the avant-garde can only be realized and understood in collective, counteradaptive, and ad hoc ways. We must recognize that many kinds of forces perpetuate the status quo in game culture. If we wish to counter these forces, we must develop a diversity of tactics ranging across technical, aesthetic, and cultural strategies in order to break open game culture and advance games as an artistic medium.

2 Radical Formal

Rise of Avant-garde Painting

The radical formal avant-garde both deconstructs and develops artistic mediums. Avant-garde painters historically revolutionized the medium of painting, just as formal avant-garde artists cultivate and redefine the medium of games today. Whether they work in paintings or videogames, avant-garde artists play with a medium beyond easily consumable formulas.

The term *medium* has a different meaning in the discipline of media studies than it does in avant-garde art history. According to media studies, medium refers to material and technical supports (e.g., the medium of painting is the paint and canvas). According to the avant-garde, an artistic medium has three formal dimensions: material supports, the social and cultural conventions at work, and the range of sensations and aesthetic experiences afforded.[1] Formal artists (a term synonymous with formal avant-garde artists) can manipulate mediums in such diverse ways because they grasp them in three dimensions, according to their materials, conventions, and aesthetics. Each dimension is in play, which is why formal art can seem incoherent to casual players or novice viewers. As avant-garde artists collectively advance a medium, what was shocking or incoherent for one generation of viewers or players becomes conventional for the next. If we trace the historical rise of formal painting, we will be able to draw parallels that can help us identify how the formal avant-garde is emerging in today's videogames.

As mentioned in chapter 1, Alberti defined painting as a virtual window and explained many pivotal mechanics, such as the implementation of a vanishing point in a picture to achieve a convincing illusion of depth.[2] Renaissance artists perfected such techniques to achieve a gravitational

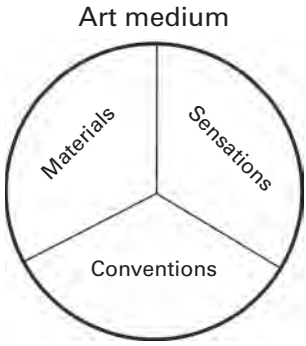


Figure 2.1
A graphic representation of an art medium's three formal dimensions: physical materials, social and cultural conventions, and sensations and aesthetic experiences.



Figure 2.2
Flagellation (1455–1460) by Piero della Francesca is conformed by grid lines ruling its construction of space similar to those of the holodeck. Alfredo Dagli Orti / The Art Archive at Art Resource, New York.

sense of receding space. *Flagellation* (1455–1460) by Piero della Francesca presents a strong representation of 3D space with grid lines organized to intersect at a central vanishing point. Human figures are rendered to be as strikingly naturalistic as possible—limbs and torsos are proportionally measured and fleshed out with chiaroscuro, highlights and shading, and the almost-magical effect of foreshortening.

Renaissance painting fixed the viewer in a single, optimal position before the canvas. According to Alberti, the illusory plane on which the painted figures stand should feel like an extension of the floor on which the viewer stands. The closer the viewer is standing to the optimal viewing position, the stronger their feeling of immersion in the scene.[3] The Renaissance conception of painting with its evenly ordered distribution of space represented the Creator's control over the world. God was reframed as the great celestial engineer, and it was as though "man was the eye for which reality had been made visible" (Berger and Spencer 1993, 172).



Figure 2.3
Olympia (1863) by Édouard Manet mixes historical and contemporary references by depicting a prostitute in a classical pose. © RMN-Grand Palais / Art Resource, New York.

Manet was the first artist to consistently and systematically break up and reconstruct Renaissance conceptions of space and representation in painting. *Olympia* (1863) depicts a recognizable subject—a young, strong-minded prostitute—gazing in an unimpressed manner at the viewer. Unblended pigment is piled up here and there, while large swaths remain barren, dressed only in underwash. Jean Ravenel, an art critic at the time, lambasted, "What on earth is this yellow-bellied odalisque, this wretched model picked up God knows where and pawned off as representing Olympia?" (quoted in Bataille 1955, 61). It was common to dismiss Manet as an unskilled dilettante because of his choice of subject matter and what appeared to be a lack of accomplished technique.

Thanks to maneuvering by his compatriot Claude Monet, Manet's work hung in the Louvre within a generation, ultimately garnering popular recognition. Manet gave no story, framework, or reason for why he painted *Olympia* the way he did. Surrealist writer and theorist Georges Bataille (1955, 67) explains:

> Her real nudity (not merely that of her body) is the silence that emanates from her, like that from a sunken ship. All we have is the "sacred horror" of her presence—presence whose sheer simplicity is tantamount to absence. Her harsh realism—which, for the Salon public, was no more than a gorilla-like ugliness—is inseparable from the concern Manet had to reduce *what he saw* to the mute and utter simplicity of *what was there*.

Bataille captures the beginning of an epistemic shift in modern art. Art did not need to persuade people or tell stories, whether these stories were biblical, beautiful, political, critical, or otherwise. In Manet's work, "the picture obliterates the text," and the force of "the picture is not in the text behind it but in the obliteration of that text" (ibid.). Painting had begun to defy the cultural conventions that had constrained it for hundreds of years.

It is important to situate the emergence of formal painting within the greater historical context of the last half of the nineteenth century. It coincided with the ascendance of modern science. Popular conceptions of the universe and humanity were exploding into a composite of theories in the modern age. Friedrich Nietzsche observed that "God was dead"—reality itself was in play, malleable to the superhuman will. This opening gave Manet and his contemporaries the cover as well as impetus to reject a godly order dictating the rules of space and representation in painting.

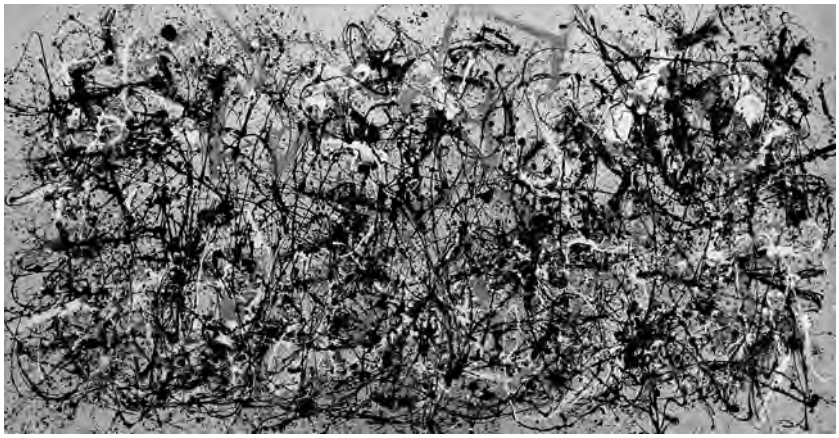


Figure 2.4
Autumn Rhythm (1950), an abstract expressionist work by Jackson Pollock, presents a raw aesthetic experience of painting. Image © The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Image source: Art Resource, New York.

Each artist, as a kind of microcosmic god, could now rewrite the rules of the medium of painting *within each painting*.

Tempting as it may be to imagine an art medium as a wild beast that needs to be tamed by a skilled artistic master, the history of modern art is more ambiguous. The idea of artist as hero was both celebrated and undermined. Some art critics, such as Greenberg (1940), cast the modern painter as submissive to the medium, not the other way around: "The history of avant-garde painting is that of a progressive surrender to the resistance of its medium; which resistance consists chiefly in the flat picture plane's denial of efforts to 'hole through' it for realistic perspectival space." Modern painting continued to experience many transformations in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, notably during the impressionist and cubist movements. By 1950, Pollock's *Autumn Rhythm* provided ample evidence of the dramatic nature of these transformations, foregrounding its own construction even more strongly than Manet's *Olympia*. The canvas is unprimed, exposing the naked weave of tan fabric. Black-and-white drips are pure and unmixed paint. As recorded traces of creative action, the bright streaks appear as they did when first striking the canvas, flung from Pollock's sweeping arm. Denied even abstract subject matter (such as the geometric forms of Paul Klee or Wassily Kandinsky), the viewer is left to

float in a noisy, dancing visual field. There is no obvious way to position or construct oneself as a viewer. The viewer grapples with a raw aesthetic experience of painting.

Monopoly of Flow

Renaissance perspective is analogous to optimal gameplay flow. Just as perspective guides and controls the viewer in traditional painting, common formulas guide and control the player in traditional videogames by rewarding and regulating behavior along certain paths and goals. In a videogame, perspective is mobilized in time as well as function, so that game experiences can flow. Flow is "optimal experience," according to psychologist Mihály Csíkszentmihályi. While feeling flow, a person has the

> sense that one's skills are adequate to cope with the challenges at hand in a goal directed, rule bound action system that provides clear clues as to how one is performing. Concentration is so intense that there is no attention left over to think about anything irrelevant or to worry about problems. Self-consciousness disappears, and the sense of time becomes distorted. An activity that produces such experiences is so gratifying that people are willing to do it for its own sake, with little concern for what they will get out of it, even when it is difficult or dangerous. (Csíkszentmihályi 1991, 71)

Csíkszentmihályi's examples of activities that afford flow are broad—playing chess, rock climbing, sculpting clay, and religious prayer. The degree and consistency of an experience's optimality depends on many factors, including the individual's motivation as well as the social framing and cultural purpose of the activity.

A dominant cultural convention of games is the expectation that they should flow. To encourage flow, players might be allowed to select their preferred level of difficulty before a game begins. To manage in-game flow, the system might use dynamic difficulty adjustment, periodically assessing whether a player is progressing too quickly or slowly. Based on those data, the game system can determine whether to increase or reduce enemy strength, add or remove contextual supports, and so on. Designers go to great lengths to develop systems with reliable flow. As game developer and theorist Jesse Schell (2008, 122–123) advises:

> Once you notice a player going into flow during your game, you need to watch them closely—they won't stay there forever. You must watch for that crucial moment—

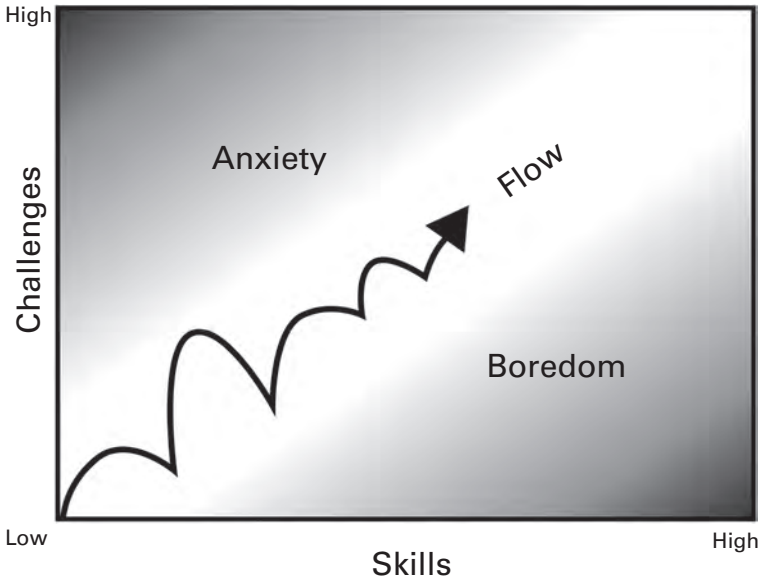


Figure 2.5
Author's reproduction of Mihály Csíkszentmihályi's diagram of flow integrated with the ideas of Noah Falstein. A videogame with flow constantly pushes the player's abilities just enough to keep them fully engaged.

the event that moves them out of the flow channel, so you can figure how to make sure that event doesn't happen in your next prototype of the game.

A host of playtest questions can be asked to determine if a game flows for its target demographic. Is the objective appealing and clear? Does the core mechanic feel juicy and pleasurable enough to continually perform? Are both positive and negative feedback as strong as they need to be? Is the difficulty curve surprising yet manageable? The upward arrow of flow (indicating that the game's challenge is increasing to match the player's increasing skill) must fluctuate, or the game will feel cold and calculated.[4] Schell argues that the arrow of flow has a fractal-like quality: the experience of an entire game is congruent with that of a single level, which in turn is congruent with many fleeting moments within a level. Despite the range of things to be considered when developing games that flow, the aim is always the same: players lose self-consciousness in the enveloping action.

Mainstream Games Are Formulaic Kitsch

If we situate mainstream videogames in relation to popular culture, we can appreciate and value the work of the videogame avant-garde in a more comprehensive way. In the twenty-first century, technoculture demands that we categorize ourselves according to computational productivity.[5] Game theorist McKenzie Wark asserts in *Gamer Theory* that "the game has not just colonized reality, it is also its sole remaining ideal." Mainstream games assimilate players into contemporary life and vice versa. Wark (2007, 1, 8) continues, "You are a gamer whether you like it or not," and "we all live in a gamespace that is everywhere and nowhere. As Microsoft says: *Where do you want to go today?* You can go anywhere you want in gamespace but you can never leave it."

Csíkszentmihályi (1991, 81) agrees; games that flow are models for successful, happy cultures:

> Games provide a compelling analogy to cultures. Both consist of more or less arbitrary goals and rules that allow people to become involved in a process and act with a minimum of doubts and distractions. . . . When a culture succeeds in evolving a set of goals and rules so compelling and so well matched to the skills of the population that its members are able to experience flow with unusual frequency and intensity, the analogy between games and cultures is even closer. In such a case we can say that the culture as a whole becomes a "great game."

Games or cultures that foster flow allow people to be perfectly subjugated within their systems. When a system is designed with optimal flow, people forget that they are being subjugated: their doubts and distractions are kept to a minimum, and all human labor is positively absorbed into the system. Subjugation without guilt or humiliation is a universal fantasy, according to Michel Foucault, a twentieth-century theorist of social power structures. We want stern and solid constraints, but we do not want them to feel like constraints (Foucault and Gordon 1980, 97). We want the illusion of freedom—freedom to question the rules, but not the actual freedom to break and rewrite the rules of the systems in which we live, love, work, and play.

According to Wright, the most distinguishing feature of games as an artistic medium is that they can stimulate, contain, and manage our desires (Chaplin and Ruby 2005, 153). Players are given the illusion that they may freely act. Yet they will increasingly perform the few behaviors that lead

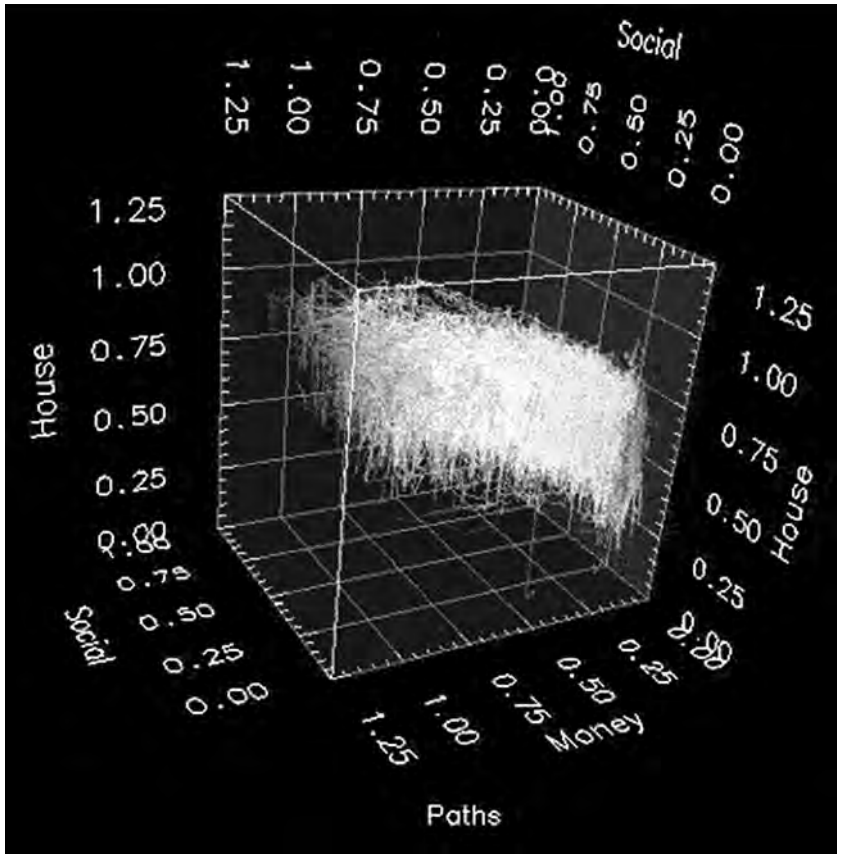


Figure 2.6
Will Wright's visualization of the "solution space" of *The Sims*. Image courtesy of Celia Pearce.

to the most powerful engagement with the system. A game may thus be understood as a psychological-procedural matrix.

Pondering a data cloud of player choices from *The Sims*, Wright notes that

> you're getting a sense of what the more mainstream play pattern is. But basically you can see that there's kind of this trajectory that's fairly close, there's not a lot of variance in it. You can see the area that represents the house. So typically people build up their house, . . . and then at some point they just kind of level out. And there's definitely some point they reach where they don't really care about the house anymore. (Quoted in Pearce 2001)

It is popular to assume that we can measure the progress of the evolution of games as an artistic medium by charting the expansion of their systemic complexity. From this perspective, Wright has perhaps singlehandedly developed the medium more than any other designer, because he abstracted a playable model of everyday urban life in his best-selling franchises *The Sims* and *SimCity*. Wright advises game designers:

> I try to keep focused on . . . enabling the creativity of the player. Giving them a pretty large solution space to solve the problem within the game. So the game represents this problem landscape. Most games have small solution landscapes, so there's one possible solution and one way to solve it. Other games, the games that tend to be more creative, have a much larger solution space. (Quoted in Pearce 2001)

Solution space is a way of quantifying the possibilities of play and rendering them tangible within a computational system. No matter how large or complex the system of a game is, if it is designed to transform the player into its ideal subject who can perform their part perfectly, then the game is a form of contemporary kitsch—the antithesis of formal avant-garde art.

Kitsch is the term used by Greenberg to describe easily consumable media. Greenberg (1939) defined the US version of kitsch as

> popular, commercial art and literature with their chromeotypes, magazine covers, illustrations, ads, slick and pulp fiction, comics, Tin Pan Alley music, tap dancing, Hollywood movies, etc., etc. . . . Kitsch is a product of the industrial revolution which urbanized the masses of Western Europe and America and established what is called universal literacy.

The achievement of universal literacy comes at great creative cost. The potential of a medium is constricted because a universal system of representation is only possible through drastic oversimplification. Kitsch "changes according to style, but remains always the same." It is harmful to popular culture because it is "mechanical and operates by formulas" (ibid.). Consumers of kitsch know exactly what to do and how to feel. Ironically, this is what some game enthusiasts say is necessary to make great games: the designer must orchestrate the emotions of the player in an intentional, predetermined way. That is precisely Roger Ebert's (2007) criterion for great art: a film love scene crescendos with matching music; rain drenches the lovers; and everyone is spent and satisfied, including the audience.

Kitsch rapidly proliferated from the 1960s to the 1980s. Literary critic Matei Călinescu sees the global spread of kitsch into emerging markets as one of the best indicators that rising economies around the world are on



Figure 2.7
The match three and hyperreal shooter genres show the breadth in theme as well as gameplay that videogame kitsch represents. Image of *Bejeweled 3* courtesy of PopCap; image of *Halo 4* © courtesy of Microsoft Corporation.

their way toward modernization. In wealthy economies, Nintendo and Apple have produced and disseminated the most powerful kitsch products in recent history, easing millions of new gamers into the medium. Multinational corporations spread game literacy by standardizing formulas. In postmodern cultures, kitsch permeates as the norm. It leaks into every circuit of life in technoculture, from social networks to casual videogames. As Călinescu (1987, 8, 228) explains, "In the postmodern age, kitsch represents the triumph of the principle of immediacy—immediacy of access, immediacy of effect, instant beauty. . . . [T]he essence of kitsch is probably its open-ended determinacy, its vague 'hallucinatory' power, its spurious dreaminess, its promise of an easy 'catharsis.'"

Following this trend, Steven Spielberg has famously said that videogames will have attained high art cultural status "when somebody confesses that they cried at level 17" (quoted in Breznican 2004). Spielberg is really talking about how videogames can become better formalized into kitsch products—how they may come to cause catharsis on cue. Formal avant-garde art performs the opposite function by reclaiming the diversity and richness that universal kitsch strips away. It deviates from established formulas and cues by definition, requiring additional effort and work to play.

Breaking Up Flow

Fascinated by the medium itself, the formal avant-garde is guided by a "games for games' sake" stance akin to that of the historical art for art's sake movement. Jeff Minter, founder of Llamasoft, is a formal avant-garde artist working in the game industry. While developing the classic *Tempest* games, Minter also created surrealist pieces such as *Attack of the Mutant Camels* (1983) for the Commodore 64 and Atari 2600. Llamasoft released a formal avant-garde game, *Space Giraffe*, in 2007, available on Xbox Live Arcade for about five dollars. In this game, players manipulate a "space giraffe" along a geometric surface in a shoot 'em up similar to *Tempest*. Fire flowers and "sparkling grunts" throng the player in a pulsating purple space. Like modernist painting, *Space Giraffe* breaks conventions in ways that encourage players to reflect on the medium and fixed-shooter genre as they play. The familiar mechanics of flying around, shooting, and powering up are present, but they are also warped and shifting. When a "feedback



Figure 2.8
Space Giraffe, an avant-garde game by Jeff Minter, offers sublime gameplay. Image courtesy of Jeff Minter.

monster" is killed, the structure of space itself appears to wrench in pain. "Rotors" are more surgical, disorienting the player by rotating the surface just underneath the giraffe. Odd combinations of attack/defend possibilities are in play—from steering bullets to psychedelic power-ups and off-the-grid jumps—and the function of each change according to context.

To normally achieve flow, players depend on adapting to challenges in games. *Space Giraffe* disrupts the player's ability to adapt, however, because it is meta-challenging and deconstructs gameplay in real time. Although reviewers have complained of "trouble getting to grips with the basics of playing the game," that is *Space Giraffe*'s best feature. The first press review of the game in *Xbox Magazine* rated it two out of ten: "You'll frequently die because you couldn't pick out the pulsating assassin from the warped playfield floating over the throbbing LSD nightmare that is the background, which makes this game uniquely aggravating" (Amrich 2007). The reviewers are trying too hard. Minter explains: "You'll always make progress in *Space Giraffe* . . . even as you die repeatedly" (Diamante 2007). *Space Giraffe*

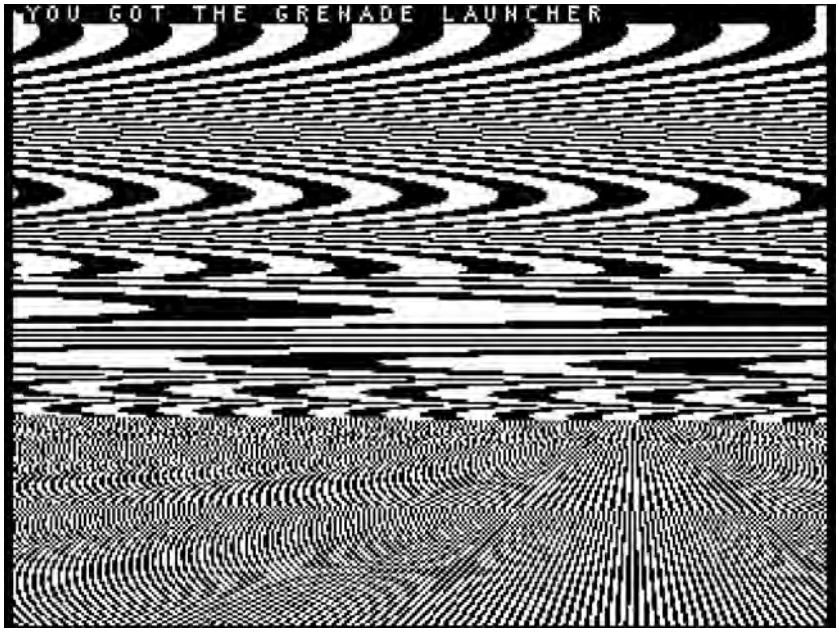


Figure 2.9
ctrl-F6, a level of *Untitled Game* by Jodi, presents gamespace in a way that radically breaks convention, wavering along on the edge of the discernible. Image courtesy of Jodi.

does not seek to produce flow; instead, the game creates a strange alchemy in which the play experience is simultaneously too hard and too easy. It is like playing a game in reverse. The game is riled up and raring to go with or without the player. You button mash, sit and watch the results for a second, swirl the analog stick around, and so forth—intermittently experimenting with and reflecting on gameplay as it progresses. It is easy to slip into a semi-disassociated state, and catch glimpses of yourself performing half outside and half inside the flow. Processing another pink Chernobyl or a throaty "mooOOOO!" becomes the core challenge. *Space Giraffe* frustrates the player who is seeking a traditional game experience, much as modernist painting frustrates viewers, past and present, who seek the traditional structures and dependable interpretations of traditional painting.

Untitled Game (1996–2001) is another example of a formal work that is even more unconventional than *Space Giraffe*. Created by the artist group Jodi (Joan Heemskerk and Dirk Paesmans), *Untitled Game* was featured in

the landmark game art exhibition Cracking the Maze: Game Plug-ins and Patches as Hacker Art, curated online in 1999 by Anne-Marie Schleiner. *Untitled Game* is a collection of unusual game mods using the *Quake* game engine (the first fully 3D engine). While the original *Quake* game was a first-person shooter in a dungeon maze teeming with demon offspring, with *Untitled Game*, Jodi attempted to

> erase the story and the figurative site of these games. The starting idea was to find very basic forms . . . [and get] a better view on how such a game is driven, what are the dynamics of the game. . . . On the one side, what we wanted to do was to undress *Quake* from all the skins, the graphics and on the other side we dress up the code a little bit. The code gets "something" so you—as the user—get some kind of idea of what the code is doing. (Hunger 2007, 152, 156)

Many kinds of "skin"—graphic, narrative, functional, and procedural—are peeled off the original game. Not only is the stuff that is contained in space peeled away, space itself is dissected. Jodi refers to game engines as "perspective engines," which promote a way of seeing and thinking about space as well as organize player behavior to dominate that space, all via Euclidean mathematics. In *Untitled Game*, Jodi cuts the medium apart by deconstructing its perspectival engine.

In the levels of *Untitled Game* titled *ctrl-space*, *ctrl-9*, and *ctrl-F6*, space is not presented in what we generally think of as 3D or even 2D. In *ctrl-F6*, spatial representation chaotically erupts all over the screen as you push the W key to walk forward. After a minute, you lose the sense of walking; it feels more like swimming through data. Scroll the mouse, and a hyper-dimensional checkerboard eats the screen in almost-discernible patterns. "Output far exceeds input"; the slightest nudge sends the chunky static reeling (Schleiner 2003). After a minute or two of playing *ctrl-F6*, a prickly horizon line becomes detectable if the mouse is swept in a looping arc. A vague ground plane takes up the lower portion of the screen. Just finding your bearings in this space is a hard-fought battle.

ctrl-F6 replaces the visual projection of space with an almost-tactile sensation of its technology-afforded conventions, creating a contemporary sort of frottage. *Frottage* was a surrealist technique of Max Ernst, who created intricate visual patterns through paint and charcoal rubbings of rock faces and other textured surfaces. Paint stains the paper in "nauseating" ways that cause "unconscious irritations" for the viewer. *Untitled Game* affords similar unconscious irritations for the player as the wheeled

computer mouse, plastic keys, and illuminated screen seem to push back against the player in one instant, and give way the next. Click-slaughtering enemies is possible in *ctrl-F6*, but only if you can consciously recall and hold in the front of your mind exactly how conventions should work—for example, using the sound cues of footsteps to help interpret visual cues. Space is sensible beyond the usual conventions because the game leverages more of the sensual capacity of the player's body, creating affectivity. Affectivity, according to new media critic Mark Hansen (2004, 7–8), is "the capacity of the body to experience itself as 'more than itself' and thus to deploy its sensorimotor power to" extend its communion with artistic mediums. While playing *ctrl-F6*, the "wetware" of the player's sensorimotor system becomes a kind of coprocessor that chugs along with the hardware. The more earnestly the player commits to playing the game, the more they will feel—rather than see—space.

It is important to differentiate *Untitled Game* from games that are merely mind bending, such as *Portal*. The difference is that *Portal* is based on clever dialogue, exquisite lies, and spatial logic puzzles—all of which become progressively twisted as players climb the flow channel. In contrast, figuring out how to become the player of *Untitled Game* is its challenge. Like modernist painting, *ctrl-F6* takes conventions that have become invisible and intuitive, and makes them extraordinary and visible again. The mapping of WASD movement and mouse looking, which have become naturalized and ingrained in regular players, are brought into high relief. In the way that modernist art served as art for artists, *Untitled Game* is truly a game for gamers and more "hard core" than any best-selling AAA shooter.

The level of *Untitled Game* called *Slipgate* is less visually tactile than *ctrl-F6*. In fact, it represents its opposite: a black void sparsely occupied with Mondrian-like abstractions, white grids, and primary cubes. The invisible collision geometry of walls is out of sync with their graphic representations. This causes players to penetrate through the visual depiction of walls, but abruptly stop at the invisible walls several feet behind them. Walking around, you feel as though you are randomly slipping in and out of proper space, like a distracted ghost. Split between physics and graphics, one of your halves feels out of phase with the other.

A blue cube slides behind white lattices in the distance. Approach, and it turns to leap, ferociously snarling and barking. Attempt to flee, and it pursues, fatally assaulting you. So you restart the level. Through some

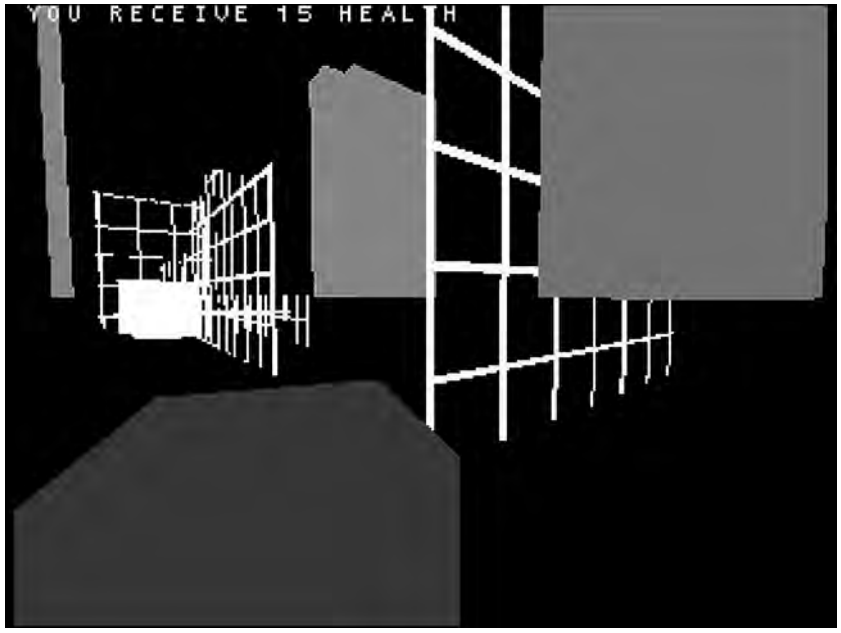


Figure 2.10
In Jodi's *Slipgate*, visual space is out of sync with the collision space, enabling the player to play in the gulf between the two. Image courtesy of Jodi.

experimentation, it becomes evident that when you collide with an invisible trigger at a specific location, the blue cube's programmed behavior is visibly disrupted and a seek-and-destroy function is called. The brutally simple logic is uncanny, funny, and startling. On the one hand, the experience of the game is an ordinary and familiar composite of collision detection, pathfinding, melee attacks, and sound effects. But on the other hand, it seems eerily threatening, like an aggressive drive stripped of any pleasure or desire. What is ultimately threatening about *Slipgate* is the symbolic violence the game applies against itself in the operational breakdown of gamespace. As a result, the role of the player breaks down as well, perhaps even to the extent that the player appears no different than the blue cube, from the perspective of gamespace. Exert dominance, lose, or win. It does not matter, as long as the player moves, clicks, and becomes further enmeshed in the matrix.

The stroke of genius in *Slipgate* is locked up in the basement. If the player drifts into an invisible elevator to descend a level, dozens of primary

cubes of various shapes and sizes mob and engulf them with grating color and sound effects. Then suddenly the player is returned to the tranquil, black beginning of the game, where the blue cube is pacing. The familiar itch pricks up—if you could just play perfectly, you might be able to order all this offensively boisterous, out-of-whack stuff. But of course that isn't possible. A drive we have naturalized as players is beautifully frustrated and exposed.

Like formalist avant-garde painting from the mid-twentieth century, *Space Giraffe* and *Untitled Game* both dissect game culture's fixation on graphics along with its dependency on logical Cartesian space, albeit utilizing differing strategies. Jodi formally interrogates the medium from outside the game industry. Jodi was the first to widely disseminate *Net art*, formal artworks made with Internet protocols and culture.[6] Minter, by contrast, formally interrogates the medium from the center of the mainstream game industry. *Space Giraffe* uses "Neon," the default music visualizer for the Xbox 360, which was built by Minter himself. While *Space Giraffe* exemplifies excess, juicing so much performance from the graphics card that it ends up parodying itself in a campy fireworks show, *Untitled Game* strips the skin of the medium away, revealing the raw, procedural guts and players' drives pulsing at the core of the medium.

Space Giraffe and *Untitled Game* are formal games that are meta-challenging to players because of their complex, reflexive nature. Other formal games can be too easy, too rewarding, and too empowering. Built with the *Half-Life* engine, *Adam Killer* (1999–2001) isolates a cause-and-effect loop in first-person shooter games so players can pry it apart in detail. Space is populated with an array of idling "Adams" wearing white clothes on a white floor and background. The unspoiled columns of breathing virtual bodies are neatly set up for a hearty slaughter. There is no waiting, no need to move or improve. As the player rains bullets, images of Adam, bullet shells, and blood trails smear in the air. Shooting in mainstream games is limited and reinforced as an intermittent, rather than constant and monolithic, behavior. *Adam Killer* short-circuits the reward cycle into a nauseating overflow. The slaughter fantasy is supersaturated and held in place until it becomes an abject spectacle.

As psychologists Geoffrey Loftus and Elizabeth Loftus explain in *Mind at Play: The Psychology of Videogames*, there are two types of player reinforcement: continuous and partial. Continuous reinforcement occurs when a

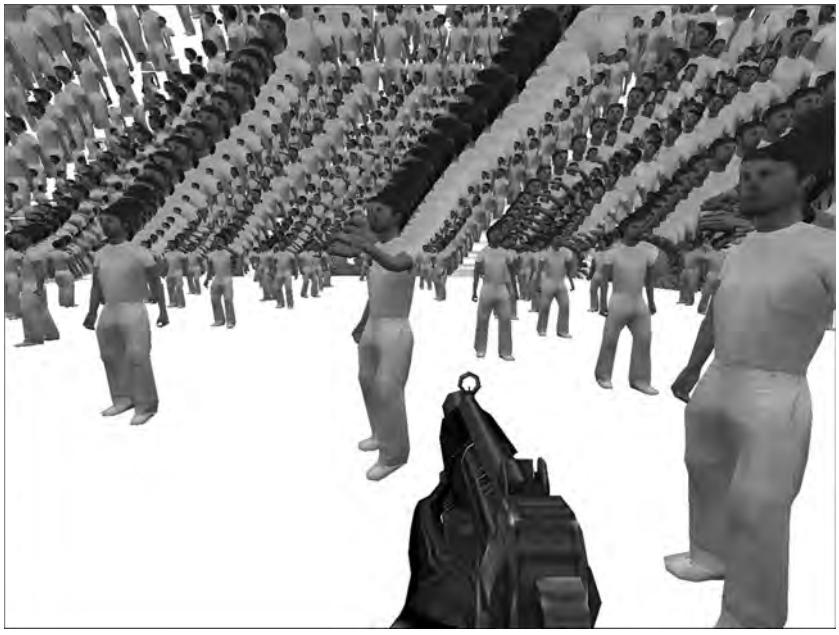


Figure 2.11
Adam Killer allows players to unravel the common shooter mechanic by supplying it in immediate, overflowing abundance. Image courtesy of Brody Condon.

certain behavior is consistently rewarded, as when a rat presses a lever and a pellet of food always appears. Partial reinforcement is intermittent and sometimes random, encouraging persistence in a given, partially reinforced behavior. Through a concert of mechanisms that offer partial reinforcement, players learn to persist in their play, retry tactics on the fly, and occasionally rethink their overall strategy, pondering, for instance, whether a particular action might yield gold, a power-up, an enemy, or nothing at all.

Loftus and Loftus (1983, 16, 19) note that successful "game designers have apparently stumbled on the optimal strategy for reinforcing people," so they will continue playing a game by offering unpredictable and irregular reinforcement: "For example, the player might achieve three complete boards in *Pac-Man* only once every ten times, or so." Unlike *Pac-Man*, reinforcement and reward in *Adam Killer* are continuous. By involving the player in the constant construction and control of the representation, the game undermines its own illusion. The player pushes through the flow

to come to grips with operations that are usually cloaked inside intermittent reinforcement. The player prickles against their revealed unconscious drives that normally compel their actions in the dark.

Videogames, the Desperate Art

If videogames do not need to make players cry at level seventeen to become widely recognized as an artistic medium, what must they do? If we examine the historical process through which painting arose as a high art medium, we can gather some clues. In the romantic era, which peaked in the nineteenth century, art increased in cultural prominence to become Art. Art was finally classified alongside the cultural giants of Religion, Philosophy, and Science with a capital R, P, and S, respectively. The operative term had previously been *the arts*, an ancient concept meaning skill and mastery, as in the arts of war, love, and conversation. The ascent of Art in the romantic era was paralleled later by the ascent of painting in the modern period. Before modernism, the term painting did not connote grandeur and status as a medium in and of itself. It derived from the material choice, and was not especially distinct from clay or paper. Within modern Art, painting became a de facto medium—culturally transformed into Painting with a capital P.

A convergence of factors contributed to painting becoming Painting. With art becoming Art, it was only a matter of time before each medium would break from the pack and claim its own unique cultural domain. A common strategy that artists use to gain independence and prominence for a given artistic medium is to combine all its major genres within single works. The more this is attempted, the better. In so doing, a medium can acutely distinguish itself from others, because each medium has a specific set of dominant genres and styles.

Manet contributed much to the transition from painting to Painting, from traditional realism to modernism. Manet's first major painting was *Le déjeuner sur l'herbe* (Luncheon on the Grass), completed in 1863. For its audience, *Le déjeuner* appeared poorly executed, a mockery of established cultural conventions. It referenced Renaissance masters like Raphael, but scandalously placed a nude female model among men clothed in modern garb. The skin of the foreground nude appears washed out, as if lit by a flashbulb. The lone figure bathing in the background is a bit too



Figure 2.12
Manet's *Le déjeuner sur l'herbe* (1862–1863) combined historical genres of French painting onto one canvas, which helped foster the concept of Painting with a capital P. © RMN-Grand Palais / Art Resource, New York.

large, resulting in perspectival inconsistency. Broad swaths of color in the background are loosely patched together, revealing the textured canvas. Although many of these attributes are at work in *Olympia* and other of Manet's paintings, the most prominent feature of *Le déjeuner* is its combination of all the major genres of painting within its frame. *Le déjeuner* contains still life, nude, landscape, contemporary portraiture, and classical style. Not only did Manet combine them but he also did so on a huge scale, using an expansive canvas measuring over eighty by a hundred inches. Paintings of this magnitude were reserved for grand "history paintings," such as major battles. But this odd, tranquil scene was not historical, at least not in the conventional sense. Instead, the painting presented the history of French painting itself.

Novelist Gustave Flaubert boldly observed that after *Le déjeuner*, "every painting now belongs within the squared and massive surface" of Painting

(quoted Foster 2003, 80). *Le déjeuner* was both a single work and a small museum of painting genres and techniques of the past few centuries. As art critic and historian Michael Fried (1984, 530), a protégé of Greenberg, explains, "Manet's multiple and often overlapping references to the art of the past [is] evidence of an attempt both to represent a certain vision of the authentic French tradition and to surpass that tradition in the direction of a universalizing or a totalizing of the enterprise of painting." *Le déjeuner* was a compendium of conventions that bumped against each other in a single viewing experience. Through summary and synthesis, the viewer could gaze on many types of paintings. In this way, *Le déjeuner* demonstrated how painting could ascend as Painting with a capital P (Foster 2003, 68). The art establishment, salon patrons, and general public in France soon accepted Manet's move. Although Manet did not single-handedly transform the medium, his contributions have led to his association with the advent of modernist art.

How could all the genres of videogames possibly be similarly summarized in a single work? Based on interactivity models, Mark Wolf (2002) has identified forty-two genres in games:

> Abstract, Adaptation, Adventure, Artificial Life, Board Games, Capturing, Card Games, Catching, Chase, Collecting, Combat, Demo, Diagnostic, Dodging, Driving, Educational, Escape, Fighting, Flying, Gambling, Interactive Movie, Management Simulation, Maze, Obstacle Course, Pencil-and-Paper Games, Pinball, Platform, Programming Games, Puzzle, Quiz, Racing, Role-Playing, Rhythm and Dance, Shoot 'Em Up, Simulation, Sports, Strategy, Table-Top Games, Target, Text Adventure, Training Simulation, and Utility.

It is daunting to imagine a summary vision of so many game genres. If we consider, in addition, the range of available technologies, platforms, and input devices, the challenge is further compounded. How could the global flow of games in technoculture, fractured across many dozens of categories and demographics, be brought together? One potential solution commonly offered by game enthusiasts is that videogames must have their own *Citizen Kane* as a gesture to advance Videogames with a capital V. Yet the problem is that these advocates do not understand the entire implication of this proposal. *Citizen Kane* did combine many techniques and genres that film had developed up to 1941, and also presented a grand vision of film. It satisfied critics and popular audiences alike, although not immediately—there was a cultural lag in its acceptance, as with Manet's



Figure 2.13
WarioWare references an array of historical conventions from Nintendo games, but collapses them into a flow of self-similar, fast actions.

work. From a formal perspective, however, *Citizen Kane* is a hybrid of kitsch and formal avant-garde art. Orson Welles used many formal "tricks," but subsumed them into new, discernible patterns of melodramatic tragedy. Audience expectations were piqued and satisfied, swept along with the epic rise and fall of the protagonist.

The videogame that might correspond best to *Citizen Kane* would not be *Zelda*, *Shadow of the Colossus*, *Civilization*, *World of Warcraft*, or any of the other games nominated to fill this role by Jason Rohrer, Cliffy B, and other game enthusiasts. The closest exemplars to date would be more summative games, such as *Little Big Planet*, *Super Smash Bros.*, *Minecraft*, or *WarioWare*.

The *WarioWare* franchise by Nintendo is a kitsch agglomerate of random bits of videogame history, especially that of Nintendo. Each *WarioWare* level is comprised of a series of quick microgames, each lasting a few seconds. The player must rapidly discern what classic convention is

being called for and then immediately execute it. If a screen is reminiscent of *Zelda*, the player must run into the black cave. If *Punch Out* appears, the player should jab Mike Tyson's face.

The breakthrough of *Le déjeuner* was that it represented and synthesized a nude, still life, landscape, history painting, and portrait of daily life, all at the same time. *WarioWare* is not an actual compilation of a shooter, sports, role-playing game (RPG), pinball, platformer, and so on. It is not an avant-garde game, because genre conventions are reduced to simple, similar mechanical actions. Analyzing a *WarioWare* microgame, Chaim Gingold (2005) observes that the "conventions of a RPG have been transformed into an action game," because the cursor blinks between menu items and the player must push the button to stop it at the right option. Rather than synthesizing multiple videogame genres and history into one avant-garde game, *WarioWare* combines and flattens them into a kitschy action game caricature of other genres.

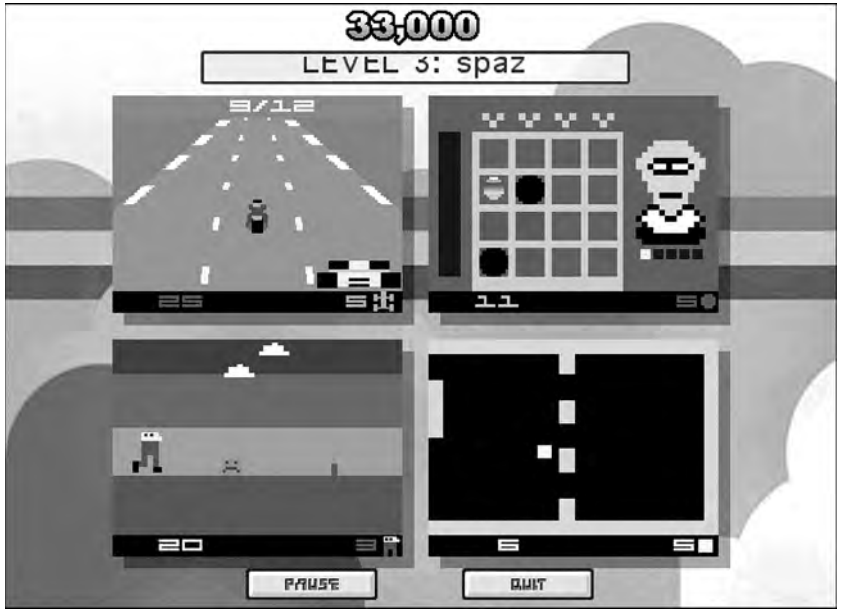


Figure 2.14
Arcadia, by Gamelab, enables the play of four minigames simultaneously, totalizing the medium in a more comprehensive and diverse way than *WarioWare*. Image courtesy of Eric Zimmerman.

Arcadia (2003) presents an alternate example for comparison. It is an avant-garde game by Gamelab (2008a), a studio once headed by game designer Eric Zimmerman that has since closed. In *Arcadia*, four minigames are played simultaneously on four on-screen panels. Each panel periodically cycles through one of eight different minigames, which are simplified genre abstractions from the 1970s and 1980s: *Pong*, *Tetris*, baseball, racing, and so on. *Arcadia* is distinct from *WarioWare* with its more variegated space, time, and action. *WarioWare* consists of *microgames*, which last mere seconds. *Arcadia*'s minigames can last up to a minute. In *WarioWare*, microgames are played sequentially in the same space or screen window. *Arcadia* splits the player across four flow channels rather than condensing play into a single channel. In *WarioWare*, players scramble to abstract the microgame logic in order to progress rapidly through a series of actions: jump, gas, select, forward, and so forth. In contrast, *Arcadia* is about *handling the difference between actions among game genres* versus collapsing them into the same flow of actions. The feel of flow in one panel leaks into other panels. For example, after getting into the shooter minigame, you might notice an enemy in the platformer panel and try to shoot it—and surprise yourself as you jump to your death. A near-miss *Pong* deflection spills over, and you overshoot a lane change in the racing minigame. You want to play *Arcadia* like an action game such as *WarioWare* and unify the system, but you cannot. The flow never stops. Dying in one panel does not let you rest in the others. Without this usual respite, you feel the awkward pressure of the flow yanking you onward.

Arcadia is a formal avant-garde work because it helps players appreciate how the medium shapes and structures flow across many genres. *Arcadia* separates minigames in the microcosm, while totalizing and synthesizing games as a medium in the macrocosm. Gamelab later released *Arcadia Remix* in 2006, apparently to rectify *Arcadia*'s deviation from the usual flow ideal.[7] Instead of presenting four minigames right away, a neatly manageable two are played for a long training period. *Arcadia Remix* is a less formal work than *Arcadia*. Although Gamelab touted it as more "addictive" than its predecessor, *Arcadia Remix* is actually less provocative, less fun, and certainly less avant-garde than *Arcadia*. Like *WarioWare*, the remixed version of the game has a more manageable, transparent, and predictable flow.

ROM CHECK FAIL, created by Farbs in 2008, presents another avant-garde example for comparison. It is a mashup of microgames played in



Figure 2.15
ROM CHECK FAIL by Farbs is a formal avant-garde game that mashes up avatars, music, enemies, mechanics, and background screens. Image courtesy of Farbs.

sequence, as in *WarioWare*—but there's leakage between them, as in *Arcadia*. The leakage in *Arcadia* is a product of the player trying to unlearn their ingrained rituals of play. In *ROM CHECK FAIL*, the leakage is programmed within the game itself. On starting the game, you might find yourself as *Pac-Man*, careening through a *Super Mario Bros*. world. Ghosts from *Gauntlet* appear, and you transform into the car from *Spy Hunter* replete with the *MIDI* "Peter Gunn" theme powering the mood. The spacebar changes from blaster to jump button to sword jab. When mechanics are transcoded across microgames, you occasionally gain an advantage. *Zelda* has a top-down perspective, so Link can walk around the entire screen and kill Goombas with ease. But this same transcoding that can yield advantages can just as easily yield disadvantage and death. One second you are the formidable *Asteroids* ship, and the next you are the *Space Invaders* laser cannon, trapped within horizontal movement, firing impotently upward as *Qix* strobes shock you from below.

ROM FAIL CHECK is an object-oriented work comprised of many avatars, enemies, environments, and forms of music. The unique nature of each object is exaggerated as it churns against the uneven nature of the collective. The genius of *ROM FAIL CHECK* is in how it summarizes Videogames with a capital V, taking a variety of objects from videogame history, carefully retaining many of their original characteristics, and bringing them together into a singular pattern of emergent gameplay. Each object is able to retain certain aspects of its original context as it performs in the new synthesized context of a heterogeneous collective.

Game enthusiasts are envious of film when they say that the medium of games needs its *Citizen Kane*. In "Movies, the Desperate Art," film critic Pauline Kael (1959, 66) states, "Other arts show an internal logic in their development, the constant solving of aesthetic challenges; films have changed simply by following the logic of the market." Kael was writing in 1956, when avant-garde and art house filmmakers suffered from Painting envy, not unlike the Film envy that videogame enthusiasts suffer from today. Similarly, at its dawn, photography pined to be painting. Still life photographs were set up for long exposures on chemical plates in an effort to make photos look like paintings.

One of the most important formal questions we can ask is one that mainstream culture already poses: How can great games be made? Formal artists ask the same question, but frame it more openly and beyond the kitsch

parameters of mainstream videogames. Just as formal avant-garde painters revolutionized the medium of painting, formal avant-garde videogame artists cultivate and redefine their medium, playing with the materials, conventions, and sensual aesthetics of videogames beyond easily consumable formulas. If mainstream culture ignores these artists, in much the same way as Kael suggested that mainstream culture ignored avant-garde film and filmmakers, then games will continue to simulate technoculture itself and be no more than commercial products constrained by market forces. If game culture—and indeed mainstream culture—is willing to appreciate, play, and create games beyond the flow, though, then the next ascendant medium—whatever that technocultural Frankenstein might be—will suffer no end of Videogame envy.

3 Radical Political

Rise of the Political Avant-garde

The political avant-garde reminds us that reality is in play and that play involves actual risk. This disturbs the usual frames with which we think and act—blending art, games, and politics. From the perspective of the political avant-garde, the radical formal avant-garde is myopic because of its reflexive, inwardly focused strategies. The political avant-garde refuses to ignore the fact that form and politics are inextricably linked. Wark (2007, 67) reflects this program when he states that the "question of the form of the game cannot be separated from the question of the form of the world." Art for art's sake is impossible because the world demands our attention and action, but that does not mean these artists stop making art and playing games. It means that they radicalize the way they make art and play games in order to open up as well as transform culture.

The original Black Panther Party exemplifies the complicated entanglements that occur when the radical political avant-garde blends art and politics to transform popular culture. In 1968, the Panthers marched into the California State Capitol building armed with shotguns in a fusion of politics and theater. They understood how art could be used to obliterate deeply entrenched cultural beliefs and inequities. Eldridge Cleaver founded the Black House, a community center and theater in San Francisco, before he became the Panthers' minister of information. Ed Bullins, a young playwright who served as the group's minister of culture, wished to move the ideas of black power "out into the community" as "street theater" (Reed 2005, 49).

According to T. V. Reed in *The Art of Protest*, the original Black Panthers are best understood as a radical political avant-garde. The Black Panthers'



Figure 3.1
Through creative uses of street theater, the original Black Panthers used symbolic violence to reconfigure the cultural meaning of blacks in a society that is structurally racist. Image of Black Panthers on the steps of the legislative building, Olympia, 1969, taken by a state patrol photographer, courtesy of State Governors' Negative Collection, Washington State Archives.

spectacular shock tactics were simultaneously their greatest strength and weakness.[1] The Panthers waged symbolic warfare, combating the litany of racist stigmas that blacks were lazy, stupid, undisciplined, and disorganized. More sinister stigmas were also attacked, including the idea that blacks were historical "victims" who needed the government or dominant (white) culture to give them justice and equality. Through *symbolic violence*, the Panthers asserted their own needs in the public arena. They were active, self-determining subjects who seized power and "made history," instead of passive objects to which history happened. The strategic purpose of COINTELPRO, an FBI counterintelligence program to infiltrate the group, was to lure the Panthers across the line from symbolic violence into literal violence and illegal activity. In some cases, it succeeded.

Note that the objective of the political avant-garde is neither to raise awareness nor spark discussion about specific political, economic, or social issues. Mainstream culture strives to reduce art to expression, criticism, or publicity, thus safely containing art within the categories of free speech and marketing. The radical political avant-garde knows that art is not speech, expression, or criticism. In fact, political art is political to the degree that it resists such easy categorization in popular culture. Jacques Rancière (2004, 63), author of the *Politics of Aesthetics*, explains that

> political art cannot work in the simple form of a meaningful spectacle that would lead to an "awareness" of the state of the world. Suitable political art would ensure, at one and the same time, the production of a double effect: the readability of a political signification and a sensible or perceptual shock caused conversely, by the uncanny, by that which resists signification.

Radical political art does not follow the rules of discourse to make reasoned arguments or suggestions, because rules are always rigged to favor those in power. It plays by rules that are difficult for mainstream culture to either process or dismiss. This is the reason why it is challenging to appreciate the significance of a political avant-garde as it emerges. It is not about making or communicating meaning; it is about reconfiguring how meaning is made or communicated. Political "avant-garde work is never historically effective or fully significant in its initial moments"; "it is traumatic—a hole in the symbolic order of its time that is not prepared for it, that cannot receive it" (Foster 1996, 29). The symbolic order is the structure of our social reality held together by the rules of language and culture. There are innumerable things that the logic of popular culture cannot accept, understand, or even see—such as its own structural racism and sexism. Since the avant-garde plays in this negative space, its actions can appear purely ominous because it attacks the cultural pillars of reality. To face these pillars is to face the very limits of language. When we experience politically avant-garde acts, we confront forces that shape our common sense of reality, although they are excluded and hidden from that reality. That the Panthers of the 1960s are still problematic to situate after so many decades is emblematic of the structural challenges raised in popular culture by the radical political avant-garde.

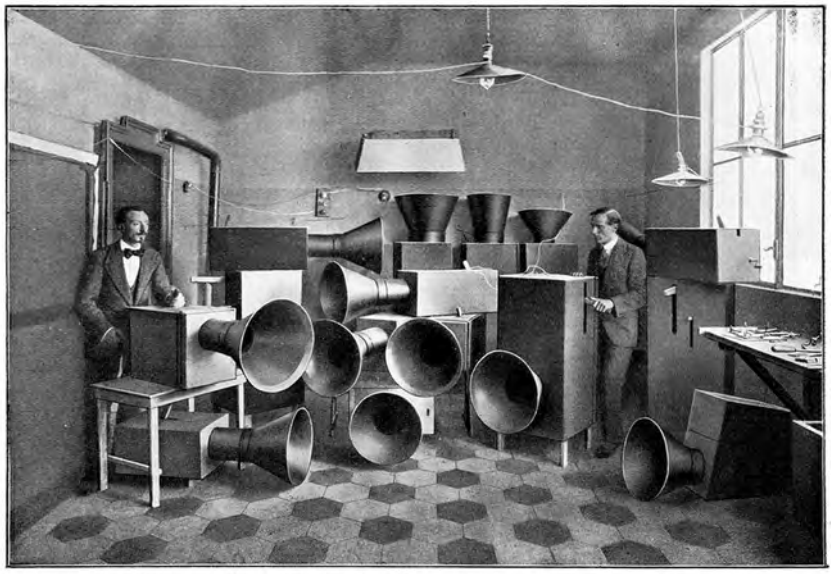
Over time, the actions of the avant-garde can become intelligible and sensible. History begins to make sense of it. New cultural grammars, terms, and associations congeal around the events like scar tissue over old wounds.

Yesterday's ruptures become today's defining marks and touchstones. For most, the Black Panthers are not a popular cultural touchstone today. If we look further back than the 1960s, we gain a better grasp of the political force of art. It has been a century since art and politics first began to spectacularly clash, mix, and merge inside the avant-garde magic circle.

In his 1909 *Futurist Manifesto*, Filippo Marinetti stated that art "can be nothing but violence, cruelty, and injustice," and thus launched futurism in Italy. A product of the era, futurism arose before World War I (1914–1918) and continued long afterward. Although futurism had movements in Russia, England, and Eastern Europe, its best-known group was in Italy. Similar in some respects to the Black Panthers, the futurists were a hypermasculine movement and embraced violent rhetoric. The Italian futurists were complicit with Benito Mussolini's fascist regime. They feared that Italy was mired in tradition, and would perish culturally unless it embraced modernity and technology. Marinetti urged his compatriots to vigorously play with life. To free their country, the futurists attacked the structures that held social reality in place: "We want no part of it, the past, we the young and strong Futurists." They proposed that only perennial violence could sustain Italy, so, for example, to destroy the "worship of the past," museums would be burned down each generation and aging artists replaced by more virile provocateurs (Marinetti 1909).

The futurists embraced the power of modern science and industry to a comical extent. Reality was reframed into a whimsical fantasy space through which humankind could playfully exert its violent desires—desires augmented by the machine. Italians would conquer inertia with vehicular speed, smash distance with the locomotive train, and defy gravity via the airplane and erection of steel skyscrapers. Futurist drawings were ripped apart and reassembled as if by mad robots. Futurist noise poetry emulating the blasts, clicks, and rumbling of airplanes, guns, and factories erupted in cafés. The futurists dreamed of metalizing the human body. Every aspect of life was assaulted. Nowhere was safe—not the sky, city, country, museum, body, bathroom, or kitchen. Futurism was everywhere. Tongue-in-cheek Marinetti blasted, "No more pasta at the offensive flaccidity of piled noodles" (Marinetti and Fillìa 1930).

A few years after futurism emerged, during World War I, a radical political avant-garde known as Dada arose. Dada spread out through Europe's cultural centers—Zurich, Berlin, Paris, and the Netherlands—and elsewhere,



LUIGI RUSSOLO Nel Laboratorio degli Intonarumori a Milano. UGO PIATTI
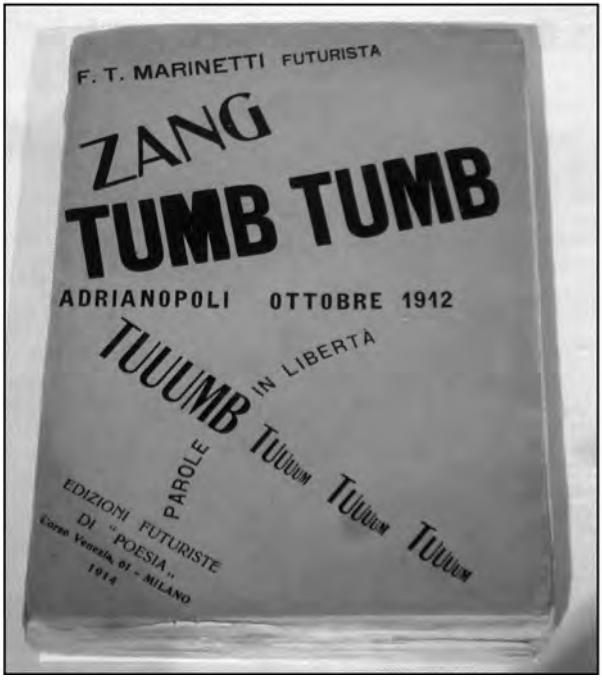


Figure 3.2

Futurist noise poetry imitates the machine in its twin forces of destruction and reconstruction. *Above:* Luigi Russolo and his assistant, Ugo Piatti, in their Milan studio, 1913. Reproduced in *L'Arte dei rumori* (Milan: Edizione Futuriste di "Poesia," 1916). *Below: Zang Tumb Tumb* by Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, 1912.



Figure 3.3
World War I photographs of a British Vickers machine gun crew wearing antigas helmets in 1916, a British Little Willie tank in 1915, and a German trench on Messines Ridge in 1917 with dead bodies.

such as New York and Tokyo. Like the futurists, Dadaists also used political art to respond to the destructive capacity and productive potency of machines at the culmination of the Industrial Revolution. In contrast to the futurists, the Dadaists blended mechanical visions with the horrific reality of World War I. This reality, captured and culturally transmitted by the new media of photography, radio, and film, included the brutal trenches, plumes of mustard gas, millions of burned and mutilated corpses, and moonlike landscapes of destruction.

Faith in progress through science and technology had sustained the West for centuries, but this faith suffered a crippling blow in the aftermath of World War I. What had made the horrors of the war possible were in fact the fruits of the Enlightenment: advances in industrial engineering, manufacturing, medicine, mass media, communications, and transportation. For disillusioned intellectuals, not only were the engineers and politicians to blame but also the artists, philosophers, and poets. Beauty and aesthetics had failed. Art for art's sake had failed.

Hans Arp describes how this cultural moment informed Dadaist practice: "While the guns rumbled in the distance, we . . . were seeking an art based on fundamentals, to cure the madness of the age" (quoted in Richter 1978, 25). Dadaists collapsed categories, allowing feelings and logic, art and politics, to affect and define each other. Formal distinctions between mediums collapsed: "As the boundaries between the arts became indistinct, painters turned to poetry and poets to painting. The destruction of the boundaries was reflected everywhere. The safety valve was off" (ibid., 57). It took a keen understanding of nineteenth-century notions of beauty and art to reconfigure their traditions effectively. A historical pressure cooker compressed cultural and technical ingredients—amalgamating them into new synthetic forms and hybrids that still resonate today.

The tactics of the early political avant-garde were absorbed by a variety of cultural actors, sometimes with disastrous results. Nazi filmmaker Leni Riefenstahl adopted avant-garde film techniques, for instance, to create stunningly provocative work that elevated Adolf Hitler's cult of personality. Historical avant-garde techniques also gave fodder to the "creative revolution" in 1960s' marketing. Lev Manovich (2002, 306–307) argues that a key Dadaist tactic is now integral to technoculture: "The avant-garde strategy of collage reemerged as the 'cut-and-paste' command, the most basic operation one can perform on the digital data." One of the most



Figure 3.4
Cut with the Kitchen Knife Through the Last Weimar Beer-Belly Cultural Epoch in Germany (1919–1920) by Hannah Höch mimics the destruction of World War I in its cut up of traditional aesthetics and at the same time creates a new aesthetic as mechanized violence is channeled into the practice of cut-and-paste collage. bpk, Berlin / Nationalgalerie, Staatliche Museen, Berlin / Jörg P. Anders / Art Resource, New York, and Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York.

lasting "avant-garde move[s was] to combine animation, printed texts, and live-action footage," Manovich continues, in a procedure that finds an analog "in the convergence of animation, title generation, paint, compositing, and editing systems into all-in-one packages." The recombinatory force with which we currently approach the creation and remixing of media is a legacy of the early political avant-garde. It is now conventional to embrace the transformative force of technology to create all kinds of flowing mediated experiences.

The futurists, Dadaists, and Black Panther Party all strived for divergent goals, using a variety of tactics. Their political motivations ranged from the cult of the machine, masculinity, and nationalism (Italian futurists), to cultural trauma (Dadaists), to social justice (Black Panthers). Their aesthetic interests ranged from inventing new practices of listening and looking to making new kinds of images and subjects visible. The common thread among the political avant-garde is the manner in which they earnestly play with our shared, mediated, public reality by blending art and politics. They take the position that neither play nor art are ever truly safe.

Monopoly of Safe Play

Play is often described as occurring in a safely protective magic circle. Johan Huizinga, a Dutch anthropologist, popularized the term in his 1938 book, *Homo Ludens*. For Huizinga (1970, 10), the magic circle depicts a social frame within which play can safely flow:

> All play moves and has its being within a play-ground marked off beforehand either materially or ideally, deliberately or as a matter of course. . . . The arena, the card-table, the magic circle, the temple, the stage, the screen, the tennis court, the court of justice, etc., are all in form and function play-grounds, i.e. forbidden spots, isolated, hedged round, hallowed, within which special rules obtain. All are temporary worlds within the ordinary world, dedicated to the performance of an act apart.

Accepting the modern Enlightenment model of reality, Huizinga places two worlds in opposition: the everyday world and the world of play. The "spoil-sport shatters the play-world itself. He reveals the relativity and fragility of the play-world. He robs play of its *illusion*" (ibid., 11). For Huizinga, play is weak because it exists in our minds, while the ordinary world is formidable because it is grounded in the physical universe.

It is common for designers to believe play is a fragile mental state. Richard Bartle and Roy Trubshaw programmed the first Multi-User Dungeon (a mashup of tabletop RPGs like *Dungeons and Dragons* and early online chat rooms). Bartle (2006, 33) is a prominent proponent of securing play, contending, "Virtual-world administrators have absolute control over their virtual world," and if they are "denied absolute control, then the game conceit must be protected in some other way, otherwise, the virtual world would just be an extension of the real world." Edward Castronova (2008, 168) notes that players "should abide by the rules or expect extreme sanctions." Castronova's (2006, 68) justification is that "virtual worlds represent a new technology that allows deeper and richer access to . . . fantasy, myth, saga, states that have immense intrinsic value to the human person," and that "virtual worlds cannot provide these mental states if the *magic circle* . . . is eroded." This extremely protective attitude toward play, though, undermines the proposition that play is powerful. In this sense, Castronova has it backward. The purpose of play is to reshape reality.

Radical Play

Brian Sutton-Smith sees play in an impressive light, wherein it has the purpose of eroding and questioning our usual way of being in the world. For Sutton-Smith (1997, 231), play is the "facsimilization of the struggle for survival as this is broadly rendered by Darwin. Biologically, its function is to reinforce the organism's variability in the face of rigidification of successful adaptation." Play allows organisms to push past hard-won patterns that have become fixed to ensure their survival.[4] This is why in his *Play of the World*, literary critic James S. Hans laments the modern anemia of play as a safe, manageable activity. Hans (1981, 182) challenges Huizinga as well as French sociologist Roger Caillois directly:

> From the playful perspective, however, one does not simply place oneself at risk; he places everything at risk, and not in the naive sense that he must consider the consequences of his action on other people as well as himself. . . . One risks the world precisely by giving oneself up to it. . . . Yet we have done our best to eliminate the risk in play, to make it "safe" for society. We almost need to relearn from the beginning that play is always only play if something is really at stake, or if everything is at stake.

We reshape the world and our understanding of it through play. To willfully "hallucinate" with "an intermediate reality between phantasy and

actuality is the purpose of play," according to developmental psychologist Erik Erikson (Erikson and Coles 2000, 103–104). We play to open up new ways to live, be, and perform in the world.

The political avant-garde of games reminds us how to play. Works in this category recover something that we have collectively lost: radical play. Radical play destabilizes the entrenched patterns with which culture engages and plays with technology, allowing alterior patterns to emerge and unrepresented subjects to become visible. The motivation of the political avant-garde of games is to break up existing regimes of technocultural power. It challenges the popular desire to extend our mastery over the world through the instrumental use of technology in the guise of safe play. Similar to the futurists and Black Panther Party, the cult of masculine violence often shapes contemporary work in this genre, especially in the case of griefers.

The common definition of griefer is a player of multiplayer games who intentionally harasses other players. For Bartle, griefing is a natural stage of personal development that all players go through. Bartle (2007) casts griefing as a normal phase in the process of assimilation into a shared virtual reality:

> The classic, *main sequence* is to start as a *griefer* (implicit socializer) who tries to find the limits of what is socially possible in the virtual world by attempting to do whatever they can to their fellow players. Having ascertained what is normatively allowed and what isn't, the player becomes a *scientist* (explicit explorer), performing experiments and learning from the results. They string together the primitive actions they have discovered so far and form meaningful sequences that enable them to perform complicated tasks. Armed with enough of these, they advance to become a *planner* (explicit achiever). This takes up the bulk of their time and is where they actually play the game. Eventually, they proceed to become *friends* (implicit socializers), a state born from the camaraderie of people who have come to trust one another over time while under pressure.

In Bartle's view, players begin griefing the moment they enter a virtual world, as they move idiotically, perform incoherently, and ask inappropriate questions. Griefing is couched as a bump in the road to virtual adulthood; it is worth noting that Bartle's "main sequence" presented in the microcosm of a virtual world is similar to Jean Piaget's sequence of how a child matures and assimilates into the procedures of culture in the macrocosm. Are we really meant to believe that all challenges to the status quo are simply clumsy attempts to adapt to it? The hole in Bartle's theory is the



Figure 3.5
In 2007, while mischievously wearing "Bush '08" buttons, the Patriotic Nigras defaced the John Edwards presidential campaign headquarters in *Second Life* with images of Communist propaganda, feces, genitals, and Edwards in blackface. Image courtesy of Amanda Marcotte.

apparent reality that many griefers are not as they are because they do not understand the social and technical rules but rather because they know the rules all too well. What makes them strange, and what makes the term griefing misleading, is the openness to accident, loss of control, and alterity that they celebrate.

The Patriotic Nigras is a griefer community that grew from 7chan, an anonymous image board, in 2006. A user called "MudKips Acronym" posted a message on 7chan asking if *Second Life* was "raidable." The idea of raiding comes from MMO gaming when players band together as a mob to defeat an enemy boss. Members of 7chan regularly raid websites, other image boards, and forums, applying the gaming practice within a broader social context. This involves inundating a site with inflammatory posts and occasionally crashing its server. 7chan raids spread to online games, such as

Habbo Hotel, and from there to *Second Life*, where they flood and break the world with iconoclastic imagery and Internet memes.

A bundle of ostensibly contradictory forces hold the Patriotic Nigras together. The Nigras value giving instruction to new members and clearly commenting on code, but they also demand anonymity so they can more effectively cause trouble and spread iconoclasm. The first page of their wiki espouses their open-source ethos: "This is a group effort by the Nigras. All of the scripts and tools here are Open Source. This means you can steal the code, contribute to the codewriting process, etc." Within their extensible, anonymous community, they share griefing techniques via a nonexclusive pedagogy. The Patriotic Nigras developed a "Shooped Life" client, which anyone can use to circumvent Internet protocol (IP) and media access control address bans in *Second Life*. They distribute highly malleable scripts, such as "Self-Replication," written in the native language of *Second Life*. It is worth examining an excerpt from the script (MachineCode 2008):

```
integer WaitTime = 10;

//Time to wait between replications in seconds.

//Must be greater than 0. I recommend more than 10 to avoid a
grey goo fence.

float V = 8;

//Max random speed object will be punted when rezzed.

string Name = "";

//Don't supply a name unless the name of the object differs
from the copy.

vector VelRand() {

float Angle = (integer)llFrand(360);

Angle = Angle * DEG_TO_RAD;

vector Unit = <llCos(Angle), llSin(Angle), V>;

return (Unit * V); }

default

{

on_rez(integer start_param) {
```

```
if(Name == "") { Name = llGetObjectName(); }
llSetTimerEvent(WaitTime); }
timer() {
llRezObject(Name, llGetPos(), VelRand(), ZERO_ROTATION, 1); }
object_rez(key child) {
llGiveInventory(child, Name); }
}
```

To execute the Self-Replication script, a user declares an instance, location, name, and vector. The "RezObject" component creates a child object that has the entire Self-Replication script in its inventory. Parent objects keep spawning children, so numerical growth is exponential. The life of the script outside *Second Life* mimics its behavior in the virtual world. The script is in flux, constantly remixed and propagated. Rapid adaptations combat countermeasures that Linden Lab uses to try to contain it. In response, Patriotic Nigras run the script through code obfuscators, which leave functions unchanged, but rearrange lines while adding bogus functions and noise. In the excerpt above there is evidence of iteration history. The delay or "WaitTime" between duplications is ten seconds in order to avoid triggering a "grey goo fence," a countermeasure by Linden to catch scripts that make calls too frequently. When the script was first introduced, such delays did not need to be as long.

Griefers not only play hard with servers, processors, and administrators but also with average players. Catherine Fitzpatrick is a small business owner who earns a modest income from virtual property in *Second Life*. Fitzpatrick bitterly complains about griefers such as the Patriotic Nigras, "Fuck, this is a denial-of-service attack . . . it's anti-civilization . . . it's wrong . . . it cost me hundreds of US dollars." She challenges any claim that griefers are artistic, philosophical, or even interesting: "Griefers aren't reading Sartre, they're antitechnological" (quoted in Dibbell 2008). From within this litany of complaints, the claim that griefers are antitechnological clearly is not credible. Griefers celebrate computer and network technologies to a comical, horrible fault, similar to the way in which the futurists celebrated machine and industrial technologies a century ago. Griefers activate and revel in all the unseen materials that make virtual reality possible. Gamespace is constrained by popular cultural conventions such as

scopophilia, the fetish of clearly seeing objects and controlling the space in front of us, as well as capitalistic notions of supply, demand, and resource scarcity. For griefers, gamespace is not a hollow container to flow through or conduct ordered business within; rather, it is a socially situated hallucination managed by computer programs and legal systems. What most people fail to understand about the political avant-garde today is the same thing they failed to understand when it first emerged in the early twentieth century. Dada and the futurists did not destroy art, although that was how it appeared at the time. Retrospectively, they are credited with redefining art. Griefers likewise do not destroy games but instead show us how to fully play with this new medium. The experience of time, space, and action in games is a mashup of processor clocks, refresh rates, cultural conventions, and human bodies clicking away at millions of terminals. The political avant-garde forcefully pulls all these things, the entire medium, into the magic circle.

In *The Exploit*, Alexander Galloway and Eugene Thacker (2007, 98) explain that for those engaged in radical politics, the "goal is not to destroy technology in some neo-Luddite delusion but to push technology into a hypertrophic state," so society may engage technology from a critical distance and gain a more comprehensive sensual grasp of it. "There is only one way left to escape the alienation of present-day society," they add: "to *retreat ahead of it*." The "challenge is to play at play itself," according to Wark (2007, 19, 224), so we may go "further and further into gamespace." The avant-garde challenges popular culture to dive more deeply into gamespace than most care to go.

Sweet Griefing

The Patriotic Nigras celebrate the power of videogames at the expense of the human subject sitting at their computer terminal, not unlike the way in which the futurists fetishized the machine at the expense of the human subject sitting in the theater. The community forum of the Patriotic Nigras suffered a DDoS attack in 2010 and is still down at the time of this writing; other infamous griefers, like Plastic Duck, have moved on as well. In their wake, even stranger kinds of griefers are gathering public attention. Procedures that were historically avant-garde, such as cut-and-paste and montage editing, have become commonplace today. An analogous goal of introducing new procedures to think with motivates a few sophisticated



Figure 3.6
Grey Goo Number Nine, scripted by Gazira Babeli, calls down a rain of Super Marios, referencing the history of videogames within *Second Life*. Image courtesy of Gazira Babeli.

griefers, who are explicitly trying to bring spoofing, worms, grey goo, and so on, into the common vernacular. This new wave of griefing is more like Dada than the futurists. These griefers are ambivalent toward the machine and more self-critical, and vacillate between being technoevangelists and devilish Luddites. They are harder for us to dismiss, not because they read Jean-Paul Sartre but rather because they signal a potential future shift in game culture itself. They may reference videogame history, politics, and the avant-garde directly, but they are mainly identified by how they use such elements to open up how we play games and ease people into a more inclusive magic circle.

Gazira Babeli takes griefing to another level by preserving little islands of stability in the iconoclastic ocean. The text channel isn't deluged with noise, for example. Babeli uses it to live chat about why she's griefing you instead.

As a disruptive torrent of Mario images overwhelm your monitor, Babeli will politely break down for you how the script works. As your frame rates slow down because your computer cannot render the flood of objects, she will keep you company while explaining the avant-garde purpose of her political act. She will share a link to the script she is using, such as *Grey Goo Number Nine*, and then be on her way. The first few lines of code read (Babeli 2006):

```
// Grey Goo Number Nine
// (cc) 2006 Gazira Babeli—gazirababeli.com
// ======================================
// This work is licensed under a Creative Commons
// Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs 2.5 License
// http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/2.5/
// ================================================
// HOW TO: Drag/Copy/Add this script on a prim
list GG = [“abe4de67-77e8-2fe2-c20d-118e7549b7b8,” // super
mario
  “6a32f6a0-c5f0-a7f6-1911-ca43e804dda6,” // warhol banana
```

Note the “mario” and “warhol” references at the bottom; the swarming elements in her work are not goatse holes, Obama or Bush banners, or racial caricatures but instead images from game and art histories. Babeli (2007) writes, “‘Griefing is a bourgeois concept’—Leon Trotsky.” It is an invitation to play. Her introduction is forced, but the company is warm. Patriotic Nigras are nurturing, yet only to one another within their community. Babeli is nurturing everywhere, healing and wounding simultaneously, throwing around Mario imagery rather than virtual feces.

We might call Babeli a *sweet griefer*. Contemporary cultural pirate Hakim Bey (2003, 40), who is also known as Peter Lambourn Wilson, examines how sweetness and ruthlessness, philanthropy and theft, can be fruitfully combined in radical politics:

> A conspiracy of artists, anonymous as any mad bombers, but aimed toward an act of gratuitous generosity rather than violence—at the millennium rather than the apocalypse—or rather, aimed at a *present moment* of aesthetic shock [act] in the service of realization and liberation. . . . Art tells gorgeous lies that come true.

Like the Patriotic Nigras, Babeli's scripts are thoughtfully commentated with instructions and warnings. But unlike the Patriotic Nigras, Babeli further weakens the artificial boundaries between ordinary reality, play, and the chaotic real by being so oddly ambivalent—shocking and generous at the same time. Babeli (n.d.) calls herself a "code perfomer" who fosters "unauthorized installations." The fact that her gestures are at once gentle and aggressive leaves many questions hanging over the experience. Her targets cannot easily dismiss her as a griefer, yet they cannot completely trust her either. Babeli combines two figures in Joseph Campbell's universal mythology: the trickster and the guide or mentor. She brings the gift of knowledge while sabotaging it—similar to Mephistopheles, Faust's trickster-guide, who tortured people's souls while revealing the secrets of the universe.

The Genetic Lifeform and Disk Operating System (GLaDOS) in the *Portal* franchise is a trickster-guide, teaching and terrorizing the player. It is important to differentiate GLaDOS from Babeli. In *Portal*, spatial continuity, physical forces, and the narrative become twisted in exquisitely designed and witty mind-bending puzzles. Not only do we expect GLaDOS to play tricks, we also expect that the tricks can be solved. Babeli performs her tricks while explaining how they work. There is nothing to solve. Players can explore the quality of the experience as it unfolds, engaging the accidental nature of gamespace in the cracks between conventions. It is not about solving the tricks but instead about dissecting and toying with the tricks themselves as part of the medium.

Sweet griefing spreads computational literacy, exemplifying how griefing could settle into a more obvious and open practice in technoculture. As griefing becomes easier and more prevalent, its tools, techniques, and conventions will become increasingly integrated into "normal" gameplay experiences. Wark (2006) writes in *Hacker Manifesto* that avant-garde "politics does not seek to overthrow the existing society, or to reform its larger structures, or to preserve its structure so as to maintain an existing coalition of interests." Avant-garde politics is *prefigurative*. It "seeks to permeate existing states with a new state of existence," contends Wark, "spreading the seeds of an alternative practice of everyday life." Babeli realizes, in the act of protest itself, the kind of virtual world she wants. For example, if street protesters throw bottles and rocks as police fire rubber bullets, the protesters inadvertently mirror and propagate the same administered violence

that they protest. Yet if protesters throw teddy bears at police instead—a demonstration tactic that was actually used at the 2000 Economic Summit of the Americas in Quebec City—then they are enacting an alternate vision of the world within the act of protest itself. The double negation turns it into a positive act, generative of an alternate way of being.

Single-Player Political Games

Single-player games, like the online multiplayer examples explored above, can also politically challenge the cultural conventions that define the medium. The game *Super Columbine Massacre RPG!* released in 2005, allows the player to reenact the 1999 Columbine school shootings as the two killers, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold. It is a 2D, single-player RPG created with an eight-bit style in RPG Maker. *Columbine* has two realms: the real world and hell that is crawling with enemies appropriated from *Doom*, a game played by the killers. *Columbine* has a linear plot: to survive in hell

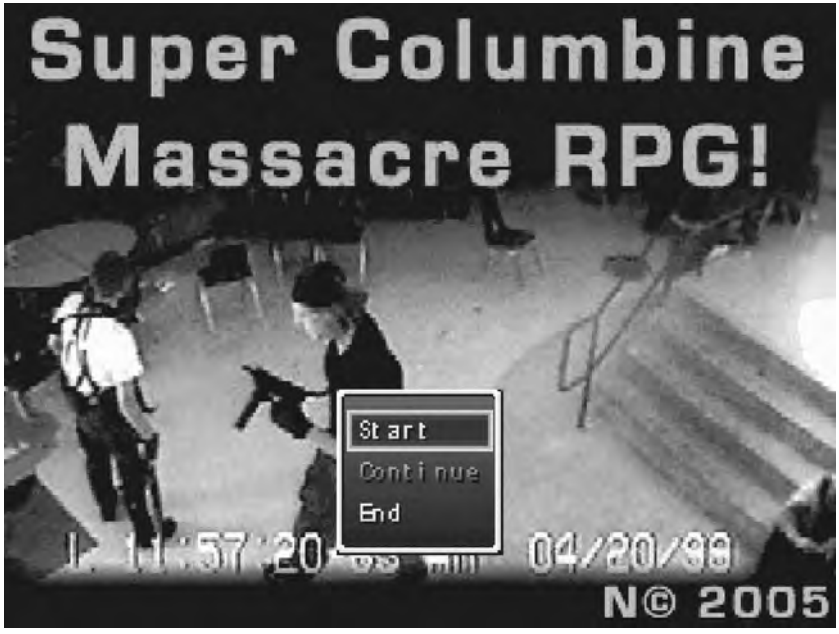


Figure 3.7
Super Columbine Massacre RPG! lets the player grapple with the shocking events of Columbine through the aesthetic of retro RPGs. Image courtesy of Danny Ledonne.

you must level up beforehand by killing children and teachers. Its creator, Danny Ledonne, explained to *Wired* magazine: "It's a little joke—you have to be really, really bad to survive in hell" (quoted in Thompson 2007).

Super Columbine is politically avant-garde because its subject is inappropriate for games according to a mainstream perspective. *Columbine* mingles gameplay and spectacular tragedy in an incredibly ambivalent experience. The material it brings into the magic circle is disturbing. Ledonne researched the event to thoroughly dramatize it—incorporating video stills of the shooting, photos of the killers' dead bodies, the cover of Nietzsche's *Ecce Homo* (which was inspirational for the killers), and images of survivors as well as mourning families. If the game were merely shocking, it would not be that effective or interesting as avant-garde art. What makes *Columbine* fascinating is its fusion of two domains usually kept separate: serious (and tragic) reality and the safe, playful mood of mainstream games. *Super Columbine*'s most important feature as avant-garde art is allowing the player to grapple with that contradiction. Greg Costikyan (2007) adroitly critiques that "the game-ness of it helps to cloak the horror." The game trivializes the massacre, adopting the sociopathic perspective of the killers, who planned it like a *Doom* game. To play the game is to experience the event through the flippant lens of the killers.

The radical political avant-garde also plays in rather slapstick ways. Jacques Servin (cofounder of the Yes Men and RTMark) was a programmer on *SimCopter* (1996), a helicopter flight sim game produced by Maxis (Wright's studio acquired by Electronic Arts in 1997). Servin furtively placed code that would render "mimbos"—shirtless, Speedo-strapped muscle men—on certain days of the year. According to Servin, games only depict women as sexual objects, so he redressed the imbalance with a celebratory flourish. The mimbos' nipples are rendered with the visual effect used for the game's fog-piercing landing lights. The usual objectification of women in games was comically augmented with the objectification of men. Servin's prank was discovered after fifty thousand copies of *SimCopter* sold, after which he was promptly fired. For a few weeks at least, the game's magic circle blended the private space of a single player experience with an artist's gesture that came swinging in for a private little party. The player's hallucinatory desire to control gamespace was sweetly griefed for a moment by an alien and boisterous, hypersexualized desire for male bodies.



Figure 3.8
Jacques Servin sneaked code into *SimCopter*, causing "mimbos" to appear, which caused Maxis to recall the game. Image courtesy of Jacques Servin.

The Playful Mob

Super Columbine Massacre RPG! and *SimCopter* attempt to open up how people play and perceive videogames. They inject politics into entertainment, cracking the infrastructure that secures the status quo. The political avant-garde can also enact the reverse, calling forth political forces through the affordances of gameplay. *Toywar* (1999) is an example of this strategy. It existed in two worlds, both as a fictional game and a retaliatory attack on a corporation. *Toywar* had its origin in a legal dispute. The billion-dollar toy retailer eToys.com threatened to sue the artist group etoy for trademark infringement. The retailer assumed that the etoy artists would either give in or respond to the legal claim via the courts. But etoy surprised eToys when it chose to fight back in an unconventional way: by launching *Toywar*.

Simply put, *Toywar* was an MMO game, but the objective was to drive down the actual price of eToys's stock on the NASDAQ market. Internal

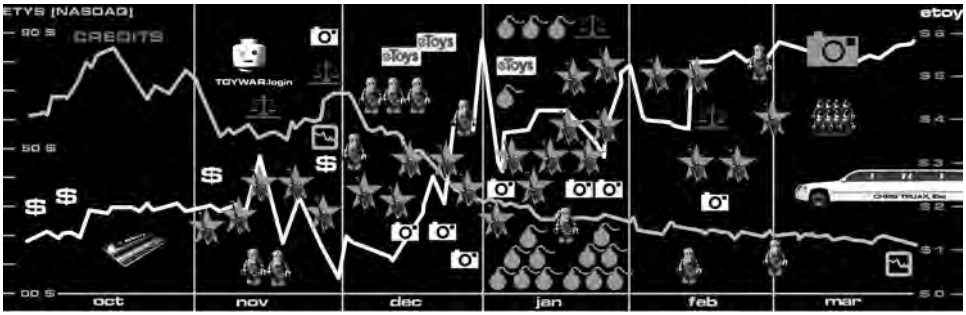


Figure 3.9
Players devalued the real stock price of eToys.com corporation in the game *Toywar*. Image courtesy of etoy.

check systems allowed players to track the misinformation campaign they were contributing to and the escalating public relations nightmare that the corporation faced. The game featured a virtual world for players to log into and play as they would if it were only a fictional game. In the virtual world, players chatted via a virtual radio, posted messages, checked internal email, spent and spread in-game currency, and launched "media bombs"—bundled packages of images, legal statements, and damning customer complaints about eToys. The magic circle was wildly expanded; players filed real countercases against the company, callers overloaded the customer service department of eToys.com, and designers published dozens of websites to humiliate the company as well as confuse potential customers, partners, clients, and media outlets. Pretending to be bankrolled investors, players infiltrated newsgroups to spread disinformation. A flurry of wildly inaccurate articles appeared in global newspapers, from the *New York Times* to *Le Monde*.

Within weeks of launching *Toywar*, the price of the eToys stock dropped by half and remained in a free fall for weeks. This occurred in 1999, when the dot-com bubble was already in the process of bursting, so the impact of the videogame is difficult to determine. The eToys corporation eventually declared bankruptcy, which led etoy (1999) to claim that *Toywar* "was the most expensive performance in art history: $4.5 billion dollars." The etoy artists insisted that the "achievement" was not theirs alone; it belonged to the players. The artists intentionally let the players define what the game was: "We have no idea what people do who meet here. They talk to each

other. They can make deals. It's a living system which generates an impact" (quoted in Kettmann 2000). There were no official rules, only a persistent gameworld in which players could congregate and a meaty target with various soft spots to expose online.

Because *Toywar* was framed as a game, wild permutations of creativity were generated. But for the same reason, all that divergent energy focused on a singular goal through the funnel of groupthink: the humiliating defeat of eToys. The rhetoric of games is widely used in the corporate world, election campaigns, propaganda, and foreign policy to manipulate discourse as well as justify aggressive policies through abstractions of glorious victory at the expense of individuals, society, and the environment. *Toywar* appropriated the militarization of business as a spectacular game and manifested it literally. It subverted capitalism by the use of its own means. The abstraction of play absolved any guilt that might normally arise from attacking a random corporation with thousands of people's livelihoods and life savings invested in it. The asymmetrical nature of the aggression prompted by the game reveals the symbolic (and literal) violence that the avant-garde is capable of when it appropriates the nature of digital capitalism, while armed with the rhetoric of contemporary warfare, and draws these into a globally expansive magic circle.

The celebratory play and exuberant waste of *Toywar* were enabled by the rubric of games. It will be illustrative to compare a similar event that was enabled not by the rubric of games but rather that of social justice. In 2005, a group called the Electronic Disturbance Theater wanted to enable anybody anywhere to support the Zapatista movement in Mexico. The strategy was to disturb the stability of the US-Mexico border infrastructure. Brett Stalbaum, Carmin Karasic, Stefan Wray, and Ricardo Dominguez (a former member of the Critical Art Ensemble) created *S.W.A.R.M.* (South West Action to Resist the Minutemen) for that purpose. Using a distributable applet, they enabled thousands of people to flood the websites of California and Arizona Minutemen organizations, "Save Our State" initiatives, and political representatives who supported stricter immigration law enforcement. They used Electronic Disturbance Theater's favorite tactic, a FloodNet application, to direct denial-of-service attacks against various websites:

> The software we are using requests files from the servers of the targeted websites that are not found—files like Justice, Freedom, and the names of those who have

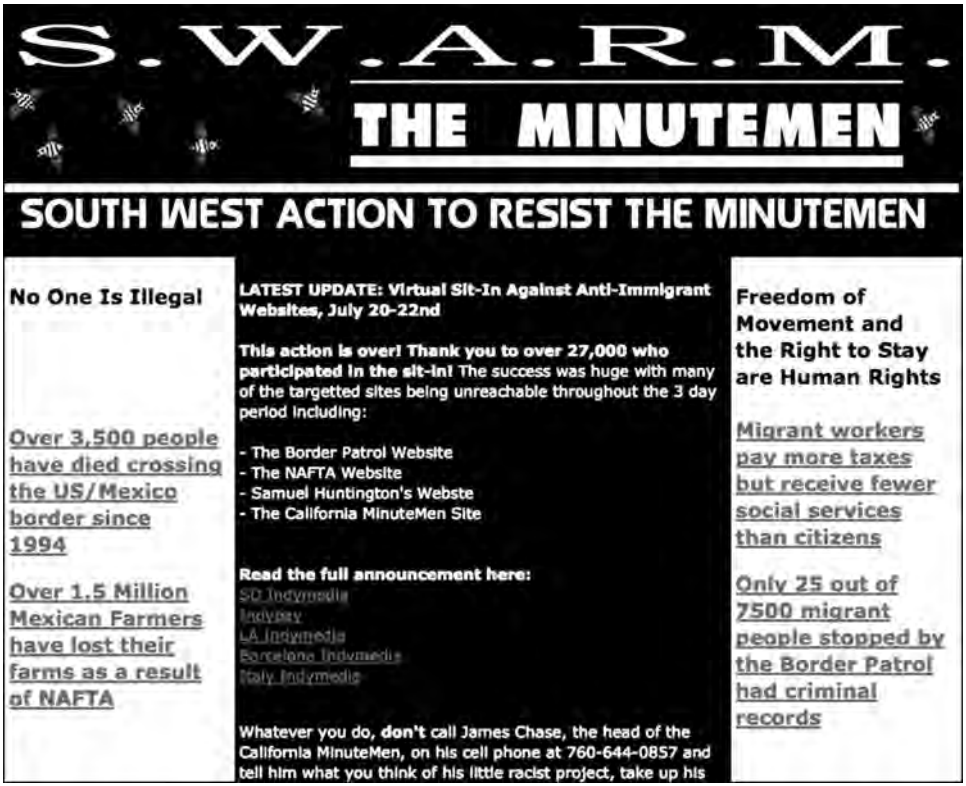


Figure 3.10
S.W.A.R.M., which orchestrated DDoS and telephony attacks against the US border patrol and the Minutemen, controlled the narrative entirely, leaving participants with little room to improvise and diverge in their activity. Image courtesy of Ricardo Dominguez.

died crossing the border. In effect you will see the error message—"files not found." The sit-in will interfere with and slow down the servers of these various groups and individuals—much like a physical sit-in slows down the movement of people in buildings or on streets. In addition, the administrators of the servers will see logs of the action where the names of those who have died crossing, and the requested files like justice, appear repeated thousands upon thousands of times. (Electronic Civil Disobedience 2008)

S.W.A.R.M. and *Toywar* both engage in "electronic civil disturbance," to use Electronic Disturbance Theater's phrase. The nature of these two disturbances is markedly distinct, however. *Toywar* used the affordance

of play so that the experience would oscillate between fictional worlds, corporate stock, and global media. In this sense, *Toywar* participation was open. Players diverged in their actions, spreading out into hundreds of nooks and crannies of technoculture—creating fake businesses and websites, feeding news aggregators with misinformation, and so on; at the same time, many players just socialized in the MMO game with other players. Using FloodNet, *S.W.A.R.M.* never opened up the methods or narrative structure of the event. The orientation, interpretation, socialization, and actions it supplied were closed off from the beginning. People were only invited to do "real" things. The participants of *S.W.A.R.M.* were never given a chance to reinterpret reality and rewrite the rules of engagement. In contrast, by sporadically dislodging civil actions from reality and allowing players to reconnect them in whatever ways they could imagine, *Toywar* players proliferated into far more divergent patterns. This allowed *Toywar* to be more politically effective and leverage the affordance of contemporary culture in more comprehensive ways. *S.W.A.R.M.* made it all too easy, providing all the rules, means, and rhyme and reason to perform the event. Worlds did not blend. Worlds were not in play. The result was a less dynamic and open event. If artists enable people to play with the nature of their own logic—which is what framing the event as gameplay does—they are not only facilitating "electronic civil disturbance but also distributing their own authority, agency, and power among the participants.

Conservative Violence

Mainstream games are designed for players to overcome the "other," alterity, and difference. Vistas of alien landscapes lure us; scenarios of a postapocalyptic United States intrigue us. These features are misleading, though. Games are usually about eliminating enemies, dominating spaces, or ordering systems, which is to say that games usually afford a conservative or even fascistic kind of violence. Designers understand that the best way to get players to accept their role as privileged authority figures in games is to cloak their status as its obverse. Players prefer to accept the underdog role: the rogue cop, cyborg mutant, psychotic killer, gang banger, anticorporate anarchist, and so on. By wearing the guise of a justified underdog, players can exert power with a clear conscience.

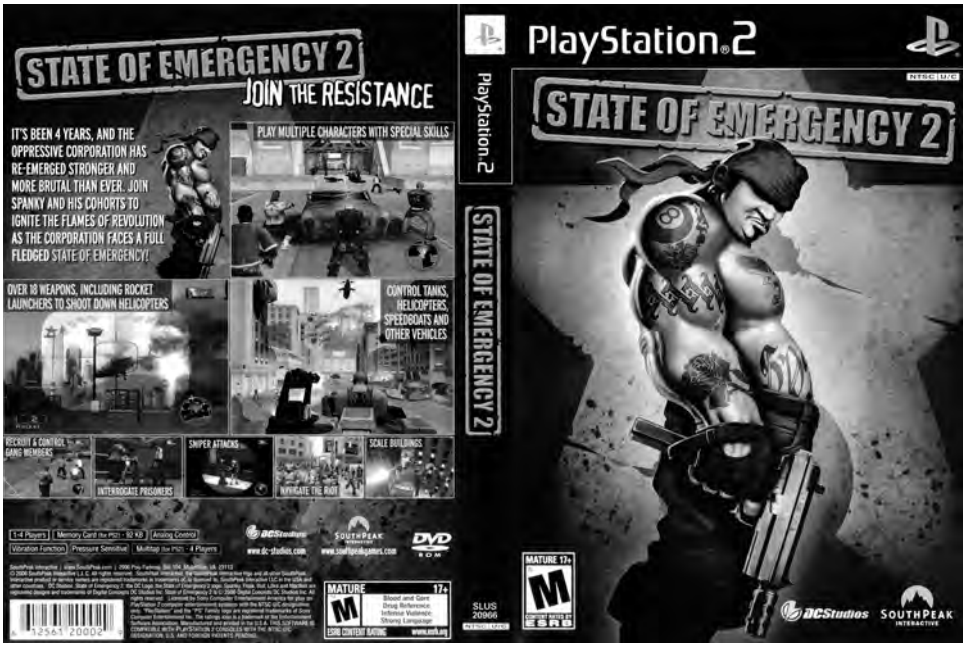


Figure 3.11
In *State of Emergency 1* and *2,* the enemy is the Corporation, which the player battles by causing systemic chaos, cloaking consumption with the feeling of subversion. Image courtesy of Southpeak Games.

For example, *State of Emergency* simulates a world suppressed by an evil "Corporation," which makes systemic disruption the gameplay goal. Transgression is encoded and afforded by design. Contrary to its rebellion rhetoric, *State of Emergency* casts the player in a conservative role. Galloway and Thacker (2007, 115) analyze the game: "The computer skills necessary for playing either scenario amount to network management tasks. Either you are infiltrating the city and destabilizing key nodes, or you are fortifying such nodes. The lesson of *State of Emergency* is not that it promotes an anarchic ideology, but that, in the guise of anarchic ideology, it promotes computer and network management skills." The false sense of being other makes it easier to exert power and claim righteous authority. It gives license to use any means necessary to master the system rather than question the system's underlying nature.



Figure 3.12
A 2008 "protest" that generated new virtual content such as placards and public relations drama for Linden Lab is more of an advertisement than a demonstration. Image courtesy of Prokofy Neva.

Administrators know that if players can express displeasure or violence through mechanisms made freely available in the game, these actually strengthen the status quo. Cory Ondrejka (2006), former chief technology officer of Linden Lab, welcomes player protests in *Second Life*, with specific recognition of their utility as fads: "Some have become entrepreneurs, opening stores, bars, and strip clubs. . . . Fads follow innovation and waves of new ideas have repeatedly swept through the population, from wings to protest marches." Perpetuating the fad of protest, Linden Lab accedes to the occasional demand—for example, the virtual tax revolt of 2003. Public ire was inflamed over a monetary charge for each primitive object players created, which was damned as a "tax on creativity."

While Linden (and "Lindens," as employees and volunteers are called) exists in many forms—a brick-and-mortar building, incorporated company, online business, and producer of a virtual world—protesters realized themselves in only one form: as avatars in the everyday virtual world.

Protesters were essentially content creators for Linden, churning out viral hype and digital entertainment; designing and implementing little placards, bonfires, songs, smoke, and animating avatars to march. From the radical avant-garde perspective, this failure to play with the form itself results in mere expression as opposed to actual protest. By simply replicating the protest form virtually, the *Second Life* protesters expressed themselves, but not in a particularly meaningful or radically avant-garde way, and with little consequence for their cause.

Life, Art, Play, and Reality

The political avant-garde's insistence on cultural or economic engagement with palpable consequences brings up complicated questions about the relationship between life, art, play, and reality. In his 1974 book, *Theory of the Avant-garde*, Peter Bürger articulated the dichotomy of art versus life with regard to Dada. From Dada (and notably not futurism), Bürger extrapolated a universal theory of the political avant-garde, as Greenberg had done for the formal avant-garde in 1939 using modern painters. Greenberg advocated art for art's sake, by which the formal avant-garde could theoretically advance culture for everyone; in actuality, it attended to a niche of educated elites with the training, time, and resources necessary to appreciate its output. Bürger's avant-garde, defined by its effect on the public, is the antielitist counterpart to Greenberg's avant-garde. According to Bürger, if only educated audiences or hardcore players can appreciate the art, then that art is a failure from a radical political perspective because it failed to challenge popular culture.

The problem with Bürger's (1984, 72) focus on defining the avant-garde by its effects on the public is that this viewpoint perpetuates a divide between art and life. This dichotomy is painfully familiar; it is also misguided. It is this same way of thinking that separates play from everyday life. Foster (1996, 15) has responded to this false dichotomy, "What is art and what is life here? Already the opposition tends to cede art the autonomy that is in question, and to position life at a point beyond reach. In this very formulation, then, the avant-garde project is predestined to failure, with the sole exception of movements set in the midst of revolutions." Using a simple, contemporary example, we can further illustrate Bürger's misconceptions about the political avant-garde. A political "purpose" for

art can be discovered in real time because networked, anonymous culture affords a new kind of public theater. For instance, Belarus is ruled by an oppressive regime, and in May 2006 a peaceful flash mob gathered in a public park to eat and share ice cream (Shirky 2008). Police were instructed to arrest anyone holding ice cream in the park—a comically hysterical overreaction that belied weakness rather than strength. The spontaneity and bottom-up self-determination of the flash mob ostensibly threatened the central authority. Through the open theatricality of the event, which could not stand in any greater contrast to the brutal idiocy of the government, an alternate reality became palpable. Democratic revolution seemed imaginable, if only for a moment.

Philosophers from Plato to Friedrich Schiller have studied similar questions about the interdependence of art, play, and life. Herbert Spencer argued in the nineteenth century that play and art are alike in the way their purpose is always dependent and proximate to the situation in which they arise. Ellen Dissanayake (1992) studies the blended nature of art, ritual, and biology in *Homo Aestheticus*. Arnold Hauser (1999) advances the twin propositions that art has a political nature and politics has an artistic nature in his voluminous *Social History of Art*. Hans (1981, 2) resituates play within the real world, correcting Huizinga and Caillois for wrongly sequestering it:

> Although both Huizinga and Caillois argue that play is important to human culture, they offer their arguments too late; once the cleavage between the "real" world and the world of play takes place, play will always have a subsidiary role, no matter what the rhetoric might suggest. . . . When one begins a book by stating that "play is superfluous" . . . one is only reinforcing its uselessness for a society that considers things in terms of utility. Huizinga's study is valuable, but his initial premises undermine the play he so dearly wishes to reclaim.

Hans's critique of Huizinga is analogous to Foster's critique of Bürger. Foster contends that in setting up a rigid division between art and life, Bürger effectively guaranteed that the political avant-garde would fail to create a new kind of art-as-life praxis. Likewise, Huizinga and Caillois carve out a gulf between play and reality. Similar to Foster's reclamation of art as an indivisible part of life, Hans reclaims play as a part of life; there is no gulf to bridge. This argument places the political avant-garde in the key cultural position of helping us remember something we have forgotten and forgetting something that has constrained us for a long time: the deeply interdependent and integrated relationships of life, art, play, and reality.

We can evaluate political avant-garde events according to how they force or enable us to play with technoculture. This is play in the Sutton-Smith sense of the word: play as variability in the face of rigid adaptations; play as openness to alterity. This conception of play deviates from the popular desire to safely play as we extend our mastery over the world through the instrumental use of technology. We do not need to evaluate the political avant-garde for its effectiveness, or lack thereof, in critiquing, negating, mocking, or healing what ails us socially or politically. The constituent parts of technoculture are pried apart by the avant-garde, giving us slack to appreciate not a better synthesis with technology or a Rousseauian decoupling from technology via an impossible "return to nature" but rather a more open way of being with technology and each other.

4 Complicit Formal

Art Is Messy

The complicit formal avant-garde advances art for art's sake while taking into account the messy technocultural milieu in which its work is engaged. These artists do not promote specific mediums. On the contrary, they question whether videogames or painting, film, video, the Internet, and so on, are each unique mediums in the first place. Videogames are treated as a resource from popular culture that can be used to make fun and relevant contemporary art. Individual mediums may be illusory, but art as a cultural practice is not. Complicit formal artists are mischievously liberal in what they consider to be art, because they have learned from the failures and successes of the historical avant-garde. While committed to form, they are also dedicated to investigating (or demonstrating) the technocultural context that shapes the interpretation of form. They create art games in the loosest possible sense, making use of diverse strategies, such as putting games in traditional gallery spaces, constructing manic cyborgs, and *affordance mining* (searching for new ways to play with things) household materials for their hidden, play-enabling properties.

The term *complicit formalism* was coined by Drucker to distinguish contemporary practices in art from radical formal practice, which she refers to as "modernist practice" or "old-style formalism" because it dominated art in the first half of the twentieth century. Drucker (2005, 36–37) criticizes radical formal practice for a "conspicuous allegiance to a kind of formal essentialism or faith in the power of an object to communicate directly as a form." The complicit formal avant-garde is acutely aware of the social and historical contexts in which its work is engaged. The fact that a game is never played in a sensual, material, or cultural vacuum is an affordance

that this type of work exposes as well as exaggerates. Artists working in complicit formalism foreground the social act of meaning making by staging performances, installations, and mixed media events that purposely blur boundaries. By applying the histories, rituals, and cues of art to those of games, and vice versa, these artists create the most blended kinds of art game experiences.

The artifacts produced by those working in this genre are not the only elements that defy conventional boundaries. Even the label of artist is itself suspect for complicit formalists. For example, instead of identifying as an artist, Amerika prefers "artist-medium," "flux persona," "aimless drifter," or "digital thoughtographer." Amerika (2007, 290) is a contemporary digital artist and theorist who remixes historical concepts:

> Our collective mission is to radically alter the Pop Culture's focus by channeling a more popularized kind of dark, sexy, surreal, and subtly ironic gesturing that grows out of the work of many twentieth-century artists like Marcel Duchamp, John Cage, Lenny Bruce. . . . The emerging wave of Avant-Pop artists now arriving on the scene find themselves caught in this struggle to rapidly transform our sick, commodity-infested workaday culture into a more sensual, trippy, exotic, and networked Avant-Pop experience.

Sensual, trippy, exotic, and networked mixtures are the core feature of the complicit formal avant-garde. Players are given too much or too little control. More or less of the player's body is brought to bear than they would like. Players must keep adapting and remain open to the spectacle of play if they are to keep it alive.

Fluxus and Flow

If contemporary practice in complicit formalism can be said to have an ancestry, it would be found in the Fluxus art movement of the 1960s and 1970s. Artists such as Paik, Yoko Ono, and Dick Higgins whimsically blended mediums together while formally appropriating a smorgasbord of previous avant-gardes, from Dada to minimal abstraction. All of art history was fair game, as was popular culture. In 1964, Paik and Shuya Abe created *Robot K-456*, a twenty-channel remote-controlled robot. The precarious, handmade robot was guided down a New York City street, defecating beans while broadcasting John F. Kennedy's inaugural address. In 1982, Paik led the robot down the street again, this time into oncoming traffic



Figure 4.1
Nam June Paik's *Pre-Bell-Man* (1990) is a mixed assemblage of media electronics and traditional sculpture. Image courtesy of Dontworry.

in a performance piece called *The First Catastrophe of the 21st Century*. The work held up a kind of mirror to the anxieties of the era, as *Robot K-456* was always on the brink of collapsing into a pile of twitching parts. This fragility reflected the precarious détente that had prevented the Cold War from turning hot and pulverizing the planet with thousands of nuclear weapons. During this same period, as the computer revolution launched, popular media representations of technology oscillated between diabolical villain and messianic savior. *Robot K-456*, on the other hand, was neither heroic nor menacing, and demonstrated how technology itself was neither an innate threat nor a means of salvation but rather a confused network of materials and cultural conventions.

Fluxus had connections to performance art. Fluxus artists were inspired by "Happenings"—art events in which audience and performers merge, spontaneously improvising a constantly evolving, shared experience (Higgins 2002, 105–106). When people do not know what they are supposed to do, when they do not know what they are looking at, artwork and audience seem staged within a mise-en-scène. In that moment, life becomes art. Fluxus blurred the role of artists and participants through generative and awkward Fluxkits, Fluxfilms, and Fluxshops (Pearce 2006a). When an artist asks viewers to help them dump dirt in a gallery, the spectators become complicit in the act. Art becomes a curious dare.

Fluxus artists also used the conventions of games to achieve certain artistic effects, inciting lively behavior from participants while blurring the roles of creator and player. Celia Pearce (ibid., 69–70) explains that "creating something that is framed as a game expresses a certain attitude, a particular posture toward not only the work itself but the 'audience, and the practice of art-making in general.'" Put simply, games invite people to play with art. This connection to games can be uncovered even at a linguistic level. The term *Fluxus* was derived from the Latin word for flow. This is not Csíkszentmihályi's flow, in which the experience is designed so that the player loses self-consciousness as their skills grow to match rising challenges. Instead, this is the flux of flow, the axiom of Heraclites that you cannot step into the same river twice. Complicit formal art is about being open to change and dancing with the currents.

Famous examples from this genre include Ono's *Cut Piece* (1964), in which she prompted audience members to cut the clothes off her as she sat motionless. The audience largely decided how the work would unfold and



Figure 4.2
Not just a visual or conceptual work, Takako Saito's *Smell Chess* (1965) encourages gallery-goers to playfully figure out ways to interact with it. Photograph taken at the Tate Modern in 2008. Image courtesy of R4vi.

what it meant. In *Deadman* (1972), Chris Burden placed his safety in the hands of people who were not even his audience when he wrapped himself in a tarp and laid down on busy street in Los Angeles. When police arrested and questioned him, he declared he was making a piece of sculpture.[1] In a 1971 piece called *Shoot*, Burden was shot in a gallery by a friend wielding a rifle. The bullet was supposed to just graze him, but it accidentally tore through his shoulder. Complicit formal artists trust art to play out as it will in other people's hands, risking not only the stability of the piece but sometimes their own safety as well.

In Ono's *Play It with Trust / White Chess Set* (1966), all the game pieces and chessboard squares are white. Ono was inspired by the Cold War climate of suspicion and paranoia. She said that you have to "play it with trust." In reaction to polarizing political angst, *White Chess Set* encourages the audience to reject categorical thinking. The experience is antibinary by design. In most games, victory comes at the expense of another side's



Figure 4.3
Artist Wafaa Bilal ducks from a remote-controlled paintball gun controlled by online players during *Domestic Tension*. Image courtesy of Wafaa Bilal.

defeat according to zero-sum logic. In *White Chess Set*, the burden of play is consistently refocused from the "what to do" to the "how to play." When audience members accept the challenge of *White Chess Set*, a series of questions arise: Is this my piece or yours? Am I playing with you or against you? How does collaborative play function in chess? Due to the challenge presented by the formal openness of *White Chess Set*, the experience forces players to cooperatively construct new rules of engagement as they struggle to enact a game and keep it alive.

Other instances of complicit formal works can be structured such that one group of players works to bring the game to life while another group works to shut the game down. In *Domestic Tension*, Iraqi American Wafaa Bilal locked himself in a gallery for a month in 2007 to be bombarded with paintballs from a webcam-mounted gun operated by online players. Players did not need to negotiate anything as in *White Chess Set*; they only needed to click the mouse to fire. Other players tried to disrupt shots and

protect Bilal. The site got eighty million hits, and sixty thousand paintballs were fired. Bilal suffered welts, bruises, and occasional bleeding. For him, the worst part was not physical pain but rather the anxiety about not knowing when he would next get shot. Bilal had several emotional breakdowns, visibly sobbing as the Internet continued to pelt him, preferring his face and groin. He wore goggles to protect his eyes and set up a transparent shield to protect his head at night.

Bilal's impetus to create *Domestic Tension* was a desire to give a face to the Iraq war. While Bilal himself has been in the United States since 1992 when he was granted asylum, his siblings and parents remain in Iraq. His twenty-one-year-old brother was killed in 2005 in Najaf by a missile fired from a US drone, and two months later his father died. Afterward, Bilal saw an ABC interview with a soldier remote controlling a drone over Iraq and launching missiles while sitting at a computer in Colorado. *Domestic Tension* offers a face, body, and tangible way to engage the controversial issues of modern war technologies. By inviting players to target him as if they were playing a game, Bilal incited aggression as well as empathy. Malevolent players authored Java scripts that caused the gun to aim at Bilal and fire automatically, while other players attempted to disrupt those shots. By month's end, players protecting Bilal stayed online persistently to form a "virtual human shield."



Figure 4.4
[giantJoystick] by Mary Flanagan invites people to spontaneously collaborate to play Atari games. Images courtesy of Mary Flanagan.

[giantJoystick] (2006) is a work that fosters spontaneous collaboration instead of strife with strangers. It is an installation piece, videogame, and performance. Mary Flanagan, its creator, describes it as a "system of collaboration." As gallery visitors enter, they are confronted by a six-foot-tall joystick, which towers over the room. The joystick is wired to an Atari 2600 running classic games such as *Breakout* and *Asteroids*, which are projected on the gallery wall. A pattern of social play usually emerges. Curiosity spurs the crowd surrounding this strange monument to nostalgic play, and invariably someone is provoked into performative action. One visitor climbs the base and tries to push the monument-like stick. It merely wobbles. Now feeling "onstage," the visitor struggles harder. Another gallery-goer joins the first to assist and successfully move the platform. But now the ball is stuck, and the fire button is out of foot reach. Someone else impulsively runs up to hit it. The artwork sets up a situation in flux. Figuring out how to collectively play the thing becomes the game, turning players into artistic performers.

Walter Langelaar presents a different take on the common game joystick in his 2007 installation work *nOtbOt*. Instead of waiting for players, the game prefers to play itself. The physical joystick erratically slams directions, mirroring the decisions of an artificial intelligence bot rampaging around *Quake III*. The player can grip it, but the joystick bucks and rears like a little mechanical bull. Julian Oliver (2007) notes, "My first impression of *nOtbOt* was of a haunting: an AI that would take no more, fighting back at the input device" to free "itself from a history of bondage." Roles are reversed. The player can finally feel what it is like to be throttled into submission through the performance of an agonistic machine.

Cockfight Arena (2001) provides another compelling example of complicit formalism with games. Dueling players physically gesticulate in garish, plumaged costumes and beaked hats to battle virtual roosters on-screen behind them. For spectators and players alike, the ridiculous spectacle in front of the screen draws as much attention as the action of animated sprites. The encumbered arms and twisted faces of players layer an absurd theatricality on top of the gameplay. The motion triggers of the game are floating in the immediate space around each player, who awkwardly gesticulates in search of them. One of the game's creators, Eddo Stern, observes, "The physicality of the game allowed for players to really perform beyond the confines of something predefined and preprogrammed" (quoted in

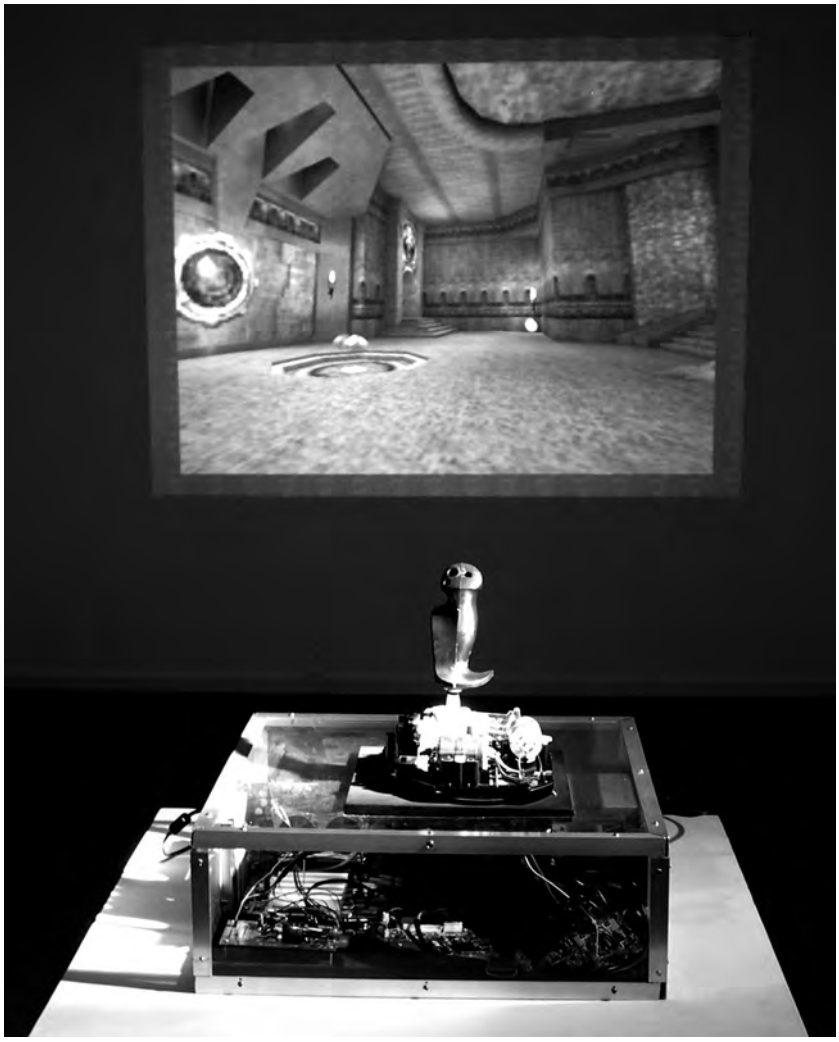


Figure 4.5
Players grip the *nOtbOt* joystick as it jerks around like a little mechanical bull. Image courtesy of Walter Langelaar.



Figure 4.6
Cockfight Arena (2001) is an exuberant, celebratory videogame performance by C-Level (comprised of Eddo Stern, Mark Allen, Jessica Z Hutchins, and Karen Lofgren at the time). Images courtesy of Eddo Stern.

Beard 2006). Meanwhile, the virtual roosters vie for attention. When one is hit, giant captions indicating damage, such as "DOH!" and "OOF!! appear and then float away. Ambiguity is at the heart of C-Level, the temporary collective that created *Cockfight Arena*. Characteristic of the complicit formalists, the description of C-Level (2006) is multilayered and complex:

> Cooperative public and private lab formed to share physical, social and technological resources. Its members are artists, programmers, writers, designers, agit-propers, filmmakers and reverse-engineers. Part studio, part club, part stage and part screen; C-Level . . . plays host to various media events such as screenings, performances, classes, lectures, debates, dances, readings and tournaments.

Such descriptive profusions and litanies of categories are typical in complicit formalism. Similar blending and blurring of categories is mirrored in *[giantJoystick]* and *Domestic Tension* as well. Each uses performativity and the body to blend games with theatrical art. A contemporary "art experience" freely mingles with a familiar "game experience." Where do the games end and the performance hacks or traditional gallery spaces begin?

Complicit formalism is distinct from radical formalism. Whereas radical formal works dig into the formal material, sensual, and cultural essences of a medium, complicit formal works blur all the medium's edges, challenging conventional modes of interaction and interpretation. Nonetheless, complicit formal artists do take certain cues from radical formalism. They subscribe to the same art for art's sake attitude, according to Hanna Higgins (2002, 102), a Fluxus historian. Complicit formal practice is committed to nonsemiotic and extralinguistic art. Like radical formal art, it is resistant to applied uses or serving as a rhetorical vehicle of persuasion that stands in for something else. Complicit formalism simply seeks to present reality itself in a new light.

Manic Avant-garde Cyborgs

Other examples of complicit formal avant-garde works make use of the cyborg figure, which is prominent in mainstream culture. The cyborg appears in videogames as the avatar, in military training exercises and combat as the human soldier enmeshed in technology, and most basically, as the interdependent relationship created by the circuit of the player's hand with the controller, brain and CPU, and retina and screen. Engaging a mainstream game, the player can get the sense that if they could only play

well enough, they might emerge on the other side of gamespace as a perfect cybernetic being. Scott Bukatman (1993, 196) calls this condition "terminal identity," where games "represent the most complete symbiosis generally available between human and computer—a fusion of spaces, goals, options, and perspectives." In these mainstream game experiences, the cybernetic loop is not about opening up, thinking about, or playing with the loop; it is about closing the loop as tightly and seamlessly as possible. Complicit formal works making use of the cyborg and cybernetic loop seek to reverse this closure, open it up, or bring attention to its hermetic nature.

The complicit formal avant-garde foregrounds the cybernetic circuit by giving players either more or less agency over it than they can effectively handle. Artists exaggerate the cyborg with comically grotesque results. They strive for the most exquisite abominations rather than the most seamless couplings.

Stelarc is a new media artist who treats the cyborg as a sandbox in which to play. In *Ping Body/Proto-Parasite* (1995), an audience in Paris touched screen icons to trigger electrode-rigged muscles on the left side of Stelarc's body (located in distant Luxembourg) to flex and release. Stelarc went further, and "made the body a video switcher and mixer," a kind of human graphics card, and relayed the processed information back to Paris for projection. He plays on the "fear we have always been zombies" (Smith and Clarke 2005, 21). His agenda is to reveal how "information is the prosthesis that holds up the obsolete body" (ibid., 7). He wishes to give information total control over the organic dimension of human life.

Like many avant-garde figures, Stelarc's stated aspirations for his work are ironic because, his cybernetic spectacles emphasize his body's resistance to technological integration and exploitation. His material "components" awkwardly jiggle, bleed, and sweat all over the technology. A reporter describes a Stelarc performance: "FLABBY, balding and naked, a middle-aged man convulses as 30 volts pulse through skin and bone, stimulating his nerve endings and producing an involuntary dance. It looks like torture" (Spencer 1996). Stelarc exaggerates his separation from technology versus his integration with it. He appears like a ghastly player from some dystopian future of games, attempting to couple with technology that rejects his agonizing advances, achieving an outcome more impressive than his stated goal for the work.

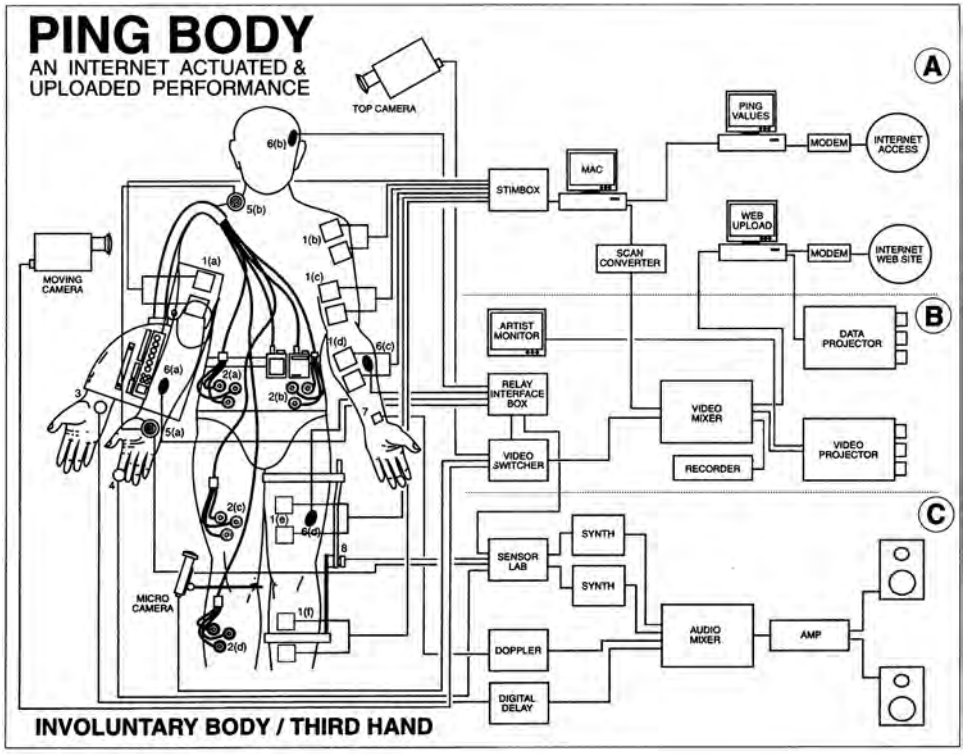




Figure 4.7
Stelarc, a cyborg artist, harnesses his body's materiality as an extension of new media technology. The above image is a diagram of PING BODY, Stelarc 1996, courtesy of STELARC. The below image shows Stelarc performing *PARASITE* in 1997, courtesy of Dave Pape.

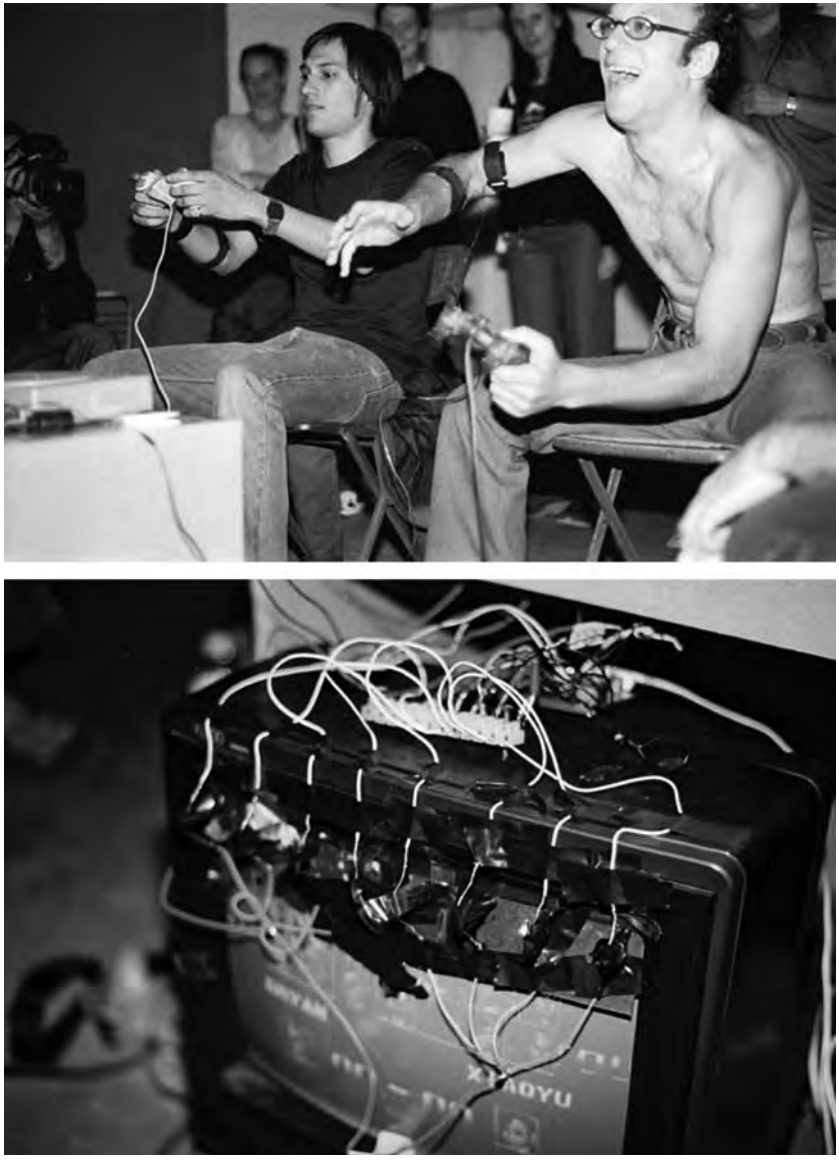


Figure 4.8
Avatar damage is transliterated into electric shocks in *Tekken Torture Tournament*. Images courtesy of Eddo Stern.

Tekken Torture Tournament (2001) by C-Level (comprised of Eddo Stern and Mark Allen at the time) provides another example of complicit formal work engaging with the cyborg. In this case, participants were wired to a modded ("modified") PlayStation to play the fighting game, *Tekken 3*. When a player's avatar was hit, they received an electric jolt via electrodes attached to their arm. In a positive feedback loop of failure, the closer to death a player was, the higher the charge of the electric current. Abruptly aware of their fleshy, vulnerable body, the player's mind cannot avoid grappling with the concrete sensation of being wired to a machine.

Game artist and professor Robert Nideffer (2004) notes that *Tekken Torture Tournament* "takes the 'shock controller' metaphor marketed to sell console devices to a whole new level." In this regard, the avant-garde has competition from the military-industrial complex. Efforts are well under way to assimilate physical pain into a militarized kind of flow. The *Threat-Fire Belt*, developed by VirTra, is an inward-facing taser strapped around an officer's or soldier's waist during virtual training exercises. If a player is shot, a 300-millisecond electric stun (adjustable to 2.5 seconds) is triggered. According to a sales rep, "The whole idea is to fight though the pain, and keep going, just the way you've been trained" (Halter 2006, 181). Like the *Threat-Fire Belt*, *Tekken Torture Tournament* incorporates pained human flesh, but in an open and humorous way. It resists the total electronic enclosure of all sensoriums by compelling players to perform, play, and laugh beyond the limits of a functional cyborg.

Gentle Avant-garde Cyborgs

The complicit formal avant-garde also builds up and breaks down the cyborg using gentler tactics, tapping into lazier or more pleasurable couplings. In the following examples, the cyborg augments affection, uncovering dormant intimacies between technology and humans through cybernetic play. In these performances, technology skews and distorts how intimacy flows between people, or between a person and the presentation of oneself.

Boomerang (1974), created by Richard Serra and Nancy Holt, provides a provocative illustration of this type of work. In *Boomerang,* Holt wore a headset and spoke into a microphone. Her speech was delayed by a half second and fed back through her headphones. The audience heard both the live and delayed feeds, causing a nicely layered double echo. For ten



Figure 4.9
In *Boomerang* (1974), Nancy Holt speaks to herself through a recorded delay, providing herself with a disorienting way of realizing a skewed form of self-intimacy. Image courtesy of the San Francisco Museum of Modern Art.

minutes, Holt described the experience and how it affected her cognition: "Sometimes, I find I can't quite say a word because I hear a first part come back and I forget the second part, or my head is stimulated in a new direction by the first half of the word." Holt got increasingly out of sync. She explained in real time how the disparity between her perception and speaking self "puts a distance between the words and their apprehension—their comprehension." It is a situation that is "like a mirror-reflection . . . so that I am surrounded by me and my mind surrounds me. . . . [T]here is no escape." Holt increasingly became estranged from herself: "I'm throwing things out in the world and they are boomeranging back . . . boomeranging . . . eranginging . . . anginging" (quoted in Krauss 1976). She was like a sensual psychonaut reporting back to ground control. The video performance allowed the cybernetic loop of human-audio-machine to slowly short-circuit before an audience vicariously riveted to the experience. In addition to audio and video feeds, complicit formal game artists fold the capacities of controllers, software, and virtual space in the experiential loop.



Figure 4.10
Darkgame conveys information through vibrations on a player's head, supplanting the visual dimension of gamespace with a tactile dimension. Images courtesy of Eddo Stern.

Darkgame (there have been several iterations from 2007 to 2013) by Eddo Stern provides another instance of this type of gentler subversion of the cybernetic loop. It allows two players to maneuver avatars in a virtual space. Avatar movements are projected on a gallery wall. Each player is given one of two channels of sensual feedback, either sight or touch, from which they must surmise what is happening. For example, if the player watching the screen gets shot, fuzzy spots grow, which obscure their vision as well the vision of all the gallerygoers. The second player receives information haptically through a force-feedback helmet—an orange octopus with tentacles wrapping around the cranium. Virtual space and in-game actions are felt as vibrations through concordant tentacles. "DZZZT" on the middle-left side, say, indicates that the player just took damage to that side. A milder "dzzzt" indicates that they just brushed a wall. Gameplay is sense "deprivation and sensory overload" simultaneously. While *Darkgame* has been lauded as accessible to the visually impaired, in a way the reverse is true too. The game also allows sighted players to sense a kind of blindness and play with a slow debilitation of sense. Navigating through the helmet, the player is aware of absence in the visual field. You can see and your eyes are open, but they are oddly useless. Sensations of "skin chatter" replace customary visual sensations. The primacy of sight is so profoundly

naturalized that by diverting the visual channel through tactile sensations applied elsewhere, we can feel our familiar sense ratios awkwardly adjusting to the new patterns.

Darkgame enables participatory openness and emergent couplings in its play. Similar to Ono's *White Chess Set*, players become better competitors if they cooperate. "DZZZT" provokes a player to ask, "Did you just shoot me?" As the visual player becomes "blind," they may rely on the crowd and the buzzing sound of their opponent's helmet to know if they landed a shot. The example of *Darkgame* is emblematic of complicit formalist strategies, with the artist exploiting whichever connections might be socially, psychologically, or technologically available.

Gentle cyborgs elide virtual game competition in favor of physical pleasure. In her cyborg manifesto, Donna Haraway portrays cyborgs as inherently sexual because they open up alternate kinds of coupling between concepts, objects, and people. Cyborgs "signal disturbingly and pleasurably tight coupling" between "emerging pleasures, experiences, and powers" (Haraway 1991, 172, 173). Playing with cyborgs cross-wires bodies and technologies, enabling things that cannot usually touch to finally hook up.

Massage Me (2007) puts two people in an asymmetrical relationship: the single player operates the game by massaging someone wearing a vest that has embedded sensors on its back. The game's creators, the artists' group Kobakantinen (2007), claim that it "turns a video game player's excess energy into a back massage for an innocent bystander." The game pad becomes a pleasure center for contact, and the "addicted game player becomes an inexhaustible masseur." *Massage Me* yokes the agonistic energy of a fighting game into a massaging action. A performance that is usually abstracted to action on-screen is diverted to a friend prone on the floor. To enjoy the game is to give someone else pleasure, or at the very least, pressure.

Kissing Controllers (2011), by Hye Yeon Nam and Sam Mendenhall, goes further than *Massage Me* by penetrating the boundary of the players' bodies. A two-player game, it allows the control via kissing of virtual bowling balls and race cars. One player wears a headset with magnetic field sensors that detect the movement of a magnet affixed to their tongue with Fixodent. Players squish and wrestle tongues to negotiate control. It is tempting to assume that the mildly disturbing spectacle of *Kissing Controllers* coldly



Figure 4.11
Massage Me reframes the human back as a conduit into gamespace, affording contingent exchanges of sensuality, activity, and passivity. Image courtesy of Mika Satomi and Hannah Perner-Wilson.



Figure 4.12
Kissing Controllers by Hye Yeon Nam brings the videogame controller into two players' bodies. Models in photograph: Thomas Lodato (left) and Sarah Puerto (right). Photographer: Hye Yeon Nam. Image courtesy of Hye Yeon Nam.

instrumentalizes bodily intimacy. Nevertheless, because the spectacle is framed as a festive social event, it is more a celebration of cyborg sexuality.

Affordance Mining

Complicit formal artists play with the materiality and "thingness" of everyday objects and equipment, prompting players to do the same. For example, George Maciunas experimented with alternate forms of ping-pong in *Flux Ping-Pong* (1976). He affordance mined the usual game equipment by sawing holes in rackets, then gluing Styrofoam, cans, tubes, and lead weights to them. This caused the ball to suddenly react and spin in ways that players did not expect. It was as if Maciunas was solving design problems that did not exist, fixing unbroken games. In a way, visitors to the gallery space were sweetly griefed, because the main challenges they faced as players (e.g., getting used to how ping-pong balls bounce off Styrofoam) seemed unrelated to the original games and thus they had to reacclimate themselves. The dormant properties of the materials and equipment were foregrounded through play.

Maciunas was affordance mining household materials, trash, and the usual equipment with which we play ping-pong. An affordance is a property that seems to call out from a technology to the person near or handling it. A doorknob looks like it wants to be turned and pulled. A game



Figure 4.13
The author modified ping-pong equipment using household materials in the spirit of *Flux Ping-Pong* (1976) by George Maciunas.

controller prompts us to handle it because of the way it perfectly fits our hands. In *The Design of Everyday Things*, Donald Norman popularized affordance in this sense. Norman's thesis is that technology should be designed to be transparent and intuitive for users by presenting strong, clear affordances. He appropriated the term affordance from perceptual psychologist James J. Gibson. For Gibson, affordances are inherent to nature; they do not have to be visible, known, or even desirable. Few of the potential affordances of everyday objects—from hot irons, phones, and pistols to toilet paper—are visible to us at any given moment (Norman 2008). Innumerable affordances have yet to be discovered between humans and the physical world, let alone between humans and technology.

Affordance mining helps players resist the usual ways we instrumentalize technology.[2] It sets our focus on an object's materiality and the total range of sensual experience it might offer. From this expanded embodiment, we can play beyond established conventions. To begin affordance mining, the artist must resist semiotic entrainment and forget what they know. They must feel the thing again as if for the first time, and this freshness carries over into gameplay.

Mashboard Games is a series of games that I developed with Jeremy Rogers in which we affordance mine the common computer keyboard. The keyboard becomes a clunky touchpad and inept instrument. *Bishop's Game* is a piece in the series in which a player holds down the spacebar with the heel of their left hand and spreads their fingers apart over the keys. A filthy virtual hand appears on-screen, mimicking the player's finger formation. With their right hand, the player jabs the keyboard in a sequential pattern between the spread fingers of their left hand.[3] For every keyboard poke, a virtual knife breaks off a key. Stab fast enough and the virtual keyboard is decimated. If the player accidentally pokes their own hand, a screaming knife gouges their monstrous on-screen hand. *Mashboard Games* is awkwardly liberating to play, because players get to deprogram themselves and reinvigorate their relationship to the keyboard on more sensual, playful terms.

Art of Erasure

Complicit artists also make use of an inversion of affordance mining: they erase and remove materials to see how artistic experience is affected. Robert



Figure 4.14
In *Bishop's Game*, the common computer keyboard is transformed into a clunky touchpad to poke and mash.



Figure 4.15
Death Animations extract the moment of death from games and re-present it back to us in a theatrical form. Image courtesy of Brody Condon.

Rauschenberg asked Willem De Kooning if he could erase one of his drawings in order to make a new "collaborative" work from it. The result was *Erased De Kooning* (1953). Although Rauschenberg spent hours carefully rubbing out the pencil lines, palimpsest remained like a ghostly afterimage. Attempting to erase the act of drawing increased its visibility, as the eye strained to hunt for its evidence and take in its full form. Details were unevenly available, attenuating our attention, luring us to look intently.

Death Animations (2007–2008) are live-action performances of death animations extracted from videogames. The entire videogame apparatus is erased, leaving only slow-motion death. Over several hours, nine performers in medieval, science-fictional, and fantasy costumes fall and roll around slowly. Throbbing muscles hold up contorting heads and quivering appendages. Binaural electronic beats saturate the space, suspending thought and conversations that might otherwise arise. The creator of *Death Animations*, Brody Condon, was inspired by the works of "process artist" Bruce Nauman, such as his *Tony Sinking into the Floor, Face Up and Face Down* (1973). Nauman instructed two actors to lie on a concrete floor and

imagine that they were sinking into it, or that it was rising and enveloping them. The video is disturbing to watch, because actors convulsively choke, contort, and sluggishly act out their viscera splattering across concrete. In *Death Animations*, the moment of death is extracted from games to be dilated and inspected at length. Focus wavers between memories of gameplay and the insufferably slow aliveness of theatrical spectatorship. In most games, death marks the instant that players are kicked out of the game in procedural failure. But death is also a spectacular reward for trying as well as a momentary reprieve. With the rag doll physics of the Havok engine in mainstream shooter games, the player is titillated to watch their avatar ricocheting off walls or contorting as it absorbs a dozen bullets. *Death Animations* embodies these ephemeral and fantastically exploding corpses, showing, by contrast, just how heavy and material the human body is in comparison.



Figure 4.16
Handmade, hacked *Super Mario Brothers* cartridge and Nintendo NES videogame system from Cory Arcangel's *Super Mario Clouds* (2002–). Installation view of the New York/Liverpool Project, Liverpool Biennial, Liverpool, UK, 2004. Photo: Duncan Hamilton. Dimensions variable. © Cory Arcangel. Image courtesy of Cory Arcangel.

In another example of complicit formal erasure, Cory Arcangel's *Super Mario Clouds* (2002–), white clouds drift over a bright blue sky, lazily occupying the projector screen. Arcangel hacked a *Super Mario Bros*. NES cartridge so that Mario's graphic data and all other visual objects sit waiting for cues that will never come. Arcangel erases game designer Shigeru Miyamoto's work, leaving a palimpsest of blips and a drained sense of worldliness. The game experience is literally suspended in the air.

It is unfortunate that game enthusiasts have criticized Arcangel for betraying the medium of videogames with works like *Super Mario Clouds* that are allegedly unplayable as well as too much like video art, installation art, or film. Detractors see Arcangel as selling out or appropriating the medium of games for the enrichment of the art establishment rather than the reverse—using art to enrich games. *Super Mario Clouds*, however, is an imminently playable game. It is playable in the same sense that the paintings of conceptual artist Sol LeWitt are viewable paintings. LeWitt's 1970 work titled *Wall Drawing #46* is this line of text: "Vertical lines, not straight, not touching, covering the wall evenly." Anyone can view the artwork if they accept the invitation to play and execute the instruction. *Super Mario Clouds* is not just a projection on a wall. The work is also the display of the process involved in the work's creation, the carved-up cartridge, the exhibition milieu, Arcangel's website with complete code examples, step-by-step instructions, and alluring photos of vivisected Nintendo cartridges. For Arcangel, "*Super Mario Clouds* [was] meant to be blind to both audiences, meaning that art people would see the work one way and like it while Internet people would see it another way and like it. I wanted these parallel rails on the same track" (quoted in Birnbaum and Arcangel 2009, 192). Players approaching the work from online culture see it as a do-it-yourself mod project as well as an invitation to play and tinker with what makes eight-bit games and game systems tick, and art audiences see the work as referencing art history with games.

Super Mario Clouds is seductively illustrative of how the two chips inside a Nintendo cartridge work: one stores audiovisual information and the other holds gameplay information. Arcangel left the graphic chip intact, but reburned the code chip to call on the clouds and nothing else. This erasure of information allows people to experience the work in new way. Arcangel explains why negotiation with technology at this level is appealing: "I like these systems not [be]cause of nostalgia, but because they are cheap and

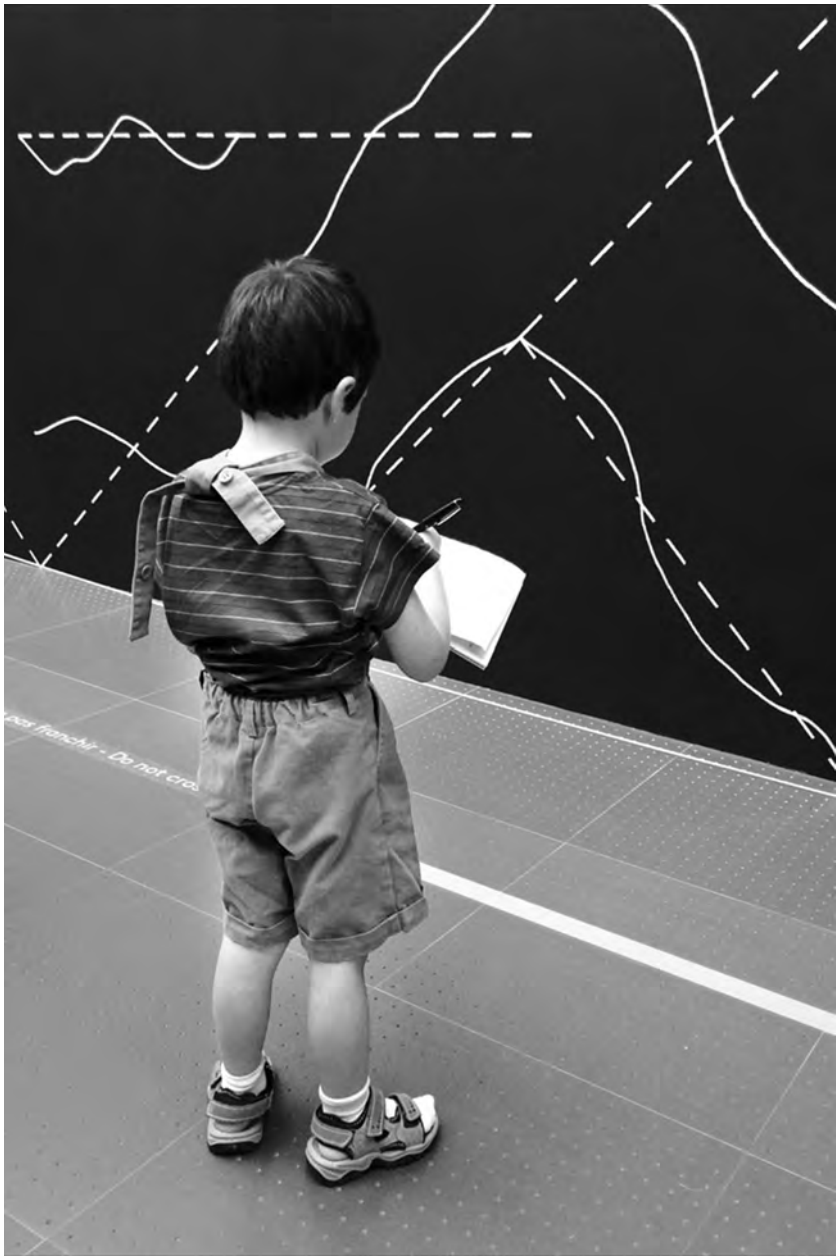


Figure 4.17
A child appreciates a wall drawing by Sol LeWitt at the Centre Pompidou-Metz in 2012. Image courtesy of Jean-Pierre Dalbera.

easy to work. Also they are the perfect middle ground between analog and digital video" (quoted in Bittanti and Quaranta 2006, 50). Engaging these old game systems within an experimental art frame allows artist and players alike to grasp as well as manipulate the hybrid features of each.

Arcangel also created a series of Nintendo game cartridge hacks such as *F1 Racer Mod (Japanese Driving Game)* (2004), in which gallerygoers gaze at an endless highway scrolling by. His most lyrical piece is *I Shot Andy Warhol*, in which he reworked the NES game *Hogan's Alley*, replacing villains with Colonel Sanders, Flavor Flav, Pope John Paul II, and Andy Warhol.



Figure 4.18
The 8-Bit Construction Set is a vinyl record whose audio, if recorded onto a cassette, is readable as computer code in an Atari or Commodore console. Image courtesy of Beige Records.

The project that led to this series of cartridge hacks was *The 8-Bit Construction Set* (1998–2000), a vinyl album of chiptune music that Arcangel produced with Paul B. Davis, Joe Beuckman, and Joseph Bonn. The set was inspired by the quirky affordances of eight-bit music and third-generation game systems. The inner track on each side of the record consisted of audio data (i.e., computer code in sonic form) that could be recorded onto a cassette, played back, and booted into an Atari or Commodore 64 console to play more music. The aim of *The 8-Bit Construction Set* was to "redefine the very limits of what one can put on a slab of wax," since it was "half dj battle record/half concept album." Albeit loosely and poetically framed, the record was in part tediously programmed in assembly language. Marrying technical skill, formal experimentation, and humor are key elements of Arcangel's strategy (Halter 2008).

By fusing ostensibly oppositional perspectives, Arcangel's work takes on a tension and sense of homelessness, which thus prevents it from belonging to any single community. While his games have been featured in the Whitney Biennial, the Guggenheim, the Museum of Modern Art, and Eyebeam in New York, Arcangel credits the formation of his practice to difference sources: the hobby scene and online communities, such as AtariAge.com, where modding and hacking spawn from a love of games' material technologies, sensual potential, and cultural conventions.

Complicit formal artists pursue games for games' sake while mingling the body and technology with performative play. These artists appropriate and adapt the world of games for the institution of art, which makes some game enthusiasts uncomfortable. On close examination of this genre of work, however, it is clear that complicit formalist strategies cut both ways across games and art, and these complex pieces also appropriate and adapt the world of art for the institution of games.

5 Complicit Political

Ad Hoc Utopias

Similar to the radical political avant-garde, the complicit political avant-garde uses the magic circle to blend life, art, and play. The difference is that the complicit political avant-garde blends these worlds using inviting, populist methods rather than the revolutionary tactics of the radical political avant-garde. These artists ask us to risk the stability of our world so that we might cocreate temporary ad hoc utopias and moments of collective, festive anarchy. The word utopia (which literally means "nowhere" in Greek) first appeared in Sir Thomas More's 1516 novel *Utopia* as the name of a fantasy island society that had achieved a state of perfect governance. Avant-garde utopias are neither static nor ideal but instead dynamic and continually rewritten in play. The complicit political avant-garde treats utopia as an everyday idea to be explored versus a mythical state to which we should aspire. Nor does it matter if any particular attempt at achieving utopia fails; all that matters is that the attempt was made. For the complicit avant-garde, each attempt makes utopia more accessible, thinkable, and possible in the public sphere.

Fredric Jameson argues in "Reification and Utopia in Mass Culture" that the culture industry provides fictional, cathartic glimpses of utopia in all its products—from films to pop music. He further asserts that each glimpse acts as a safety valve for the pressure that could otherwise build up to actual social upheaval. Although Jameson is a Marxist, he considers political radical approaches no longer viable, insisting instead that the contemporary political avant-garde be complicit with markets and institutions in order to be effective: "The new political art (if it is possible at all) will have to hold

to the truth of postmodernism, . . . the world space of multinational capital." Political art must achieve an "unimaginable new mode of representing" us "as individual and collective subjects," while allowing us to "regain a capacity to act and struggle which is at present neutralized by our spatial as well as our social confusion." Above all, Jameson (1991, 54) contends, it should provide "the invention and projection of a global cognitive mapping, on the social as well as a spatial scale." While he questions whether such political art is possible, there are in fact thousands of complicit political artists already realizing it in practice.

ARGs are precisely about the invention and projection of global cognitive mapping on the social and spatial scales that Jameson calls for.[1] They do not merely offer cathartic glimpses of utopia. Rather, by facilitating the blending of life, art, and play, ARGs create opportunities for players the world over to work together to improvise utopias by solving puzzles, completing missions, and playing collective detective. ARGs frame the entire world as their media



Figure 5.1
Players of *Cruel 2 B Kind*, an ARG of "benevolent assassination." Image courtesy of Kiyash Monsef.

platform, from sky to street, from Internet to cellular tower, while fostering "scalable communities" of dozens to thousands of players.

Jordan Weisman helped develop two of the first major ARGs: *I Love Bees* and *The Beast*. His political vision exemplifies the complicit political avant-garde approach to transforming everyday life and art by blurring the boundaries between them through play. The "entire public" is invited to play games that live in every imaginable facet of world. Weisman elaborates, "If we could make your toaster print something we would. Anything with an electric current running through it. A single story, a single gaming experience, with no boundaries. A game that is life itself" (quoted in McGonigal 2005).

The Beast was an ARG conceived as a viral marketing promotion for Steven Spielberg and Stanley Kubrick's 2001 film *Artificial Intelligence: A.I.* It took place in the twenty-second century, decades after the setting of the film, and provided players with ludic and creative opportunities to rethink



Figure 5.2
A website from the twenty-second century created for the 2001 ARG, *The Beast*, depicts Jeanine Salla in "Metropolitan Living Homes." Image of *The Beast* © courtesy of Microsoft Corporation.

the ways in which they used machines and technology. The developers placed "rabbit holes" for entering the game in various locations and contexts. So, for example, there was an unusual credit for "Jeanine Salla, sentient machine therapist" at the end of the film trailer. People who noticed this and Googled her discovered fake websites for companies selling lovebots and rogue android retrieval services. This served to extend both the film universe and magic circle. Physical media with hidden clues were planted in public bathrooms, and voice actors telephoned players to make the game seem even more real. Players were invited to join in the investigation of the death of a character named Evan Chan, whose website from the future began "I was born in Shanghai in 2066."[2] In all, *The Beast* offered players the opportunity to solve three primary mysteries, weaving together a dozen subplots and nearly 150 fictional characters.

No single person could handle that much information alone, so players had to work together. Without leadership, the mob adapted to challenges like a swarm. Professionals shared specialized knowledge and performed specific tasks in continual round-robin fashion—hacking a website, deciphering a cryptic note, creating an Internet Relay Chat or wiki to exchange as well as collect information, and so on. Elan Lee, one of *The Beast*'s designers or "puppetmasters," was awestruck by the powerful collective nature that the game engendered. He and other designers had created a host of puzzles they thought would take players six months to solve. Working collectively, participants solved every one of them in two hours on the first day (Lee 2008). These players were "scary good and scary fast," and it was brutally challenging for the puppetmasters to keep the game going (Stewart 2008). The designers scrambled to stay ahead of the players from launch to resolution.

In hindsight this all makes sense—the designers were up against hundreds of player groups that had spontaneously formed. The Cloudmakers, founded by Cabel Sasser, a twenty-four-year-old computer programmer, was the most organized of the player groups and had the highest profile. By the time the game ended, seven thousand Cloudmakers had posted forty thousand messages and created thousands of artifacts, including images, videos, websites, and a 130-page walk-through of the game (McGonigal 2003).

By analyzing *The Beast* in this way, we can see how the complicit avant-garde has adapted the strategies of the "new games movement" of the

1960s to the twenty-first century. The new games movement originally grew out of the antiwar ethos of participation and cooperation. Its festive take on civics resonates with that of contemporary complicit political avant-garde art: if we play better together, we live better together. Bernie DeKoven (2013) coined the terms *coliberation* and *well-played game* to describe how individuals amplify one another when they gel in play. In well-played games, skill and confidence are contagious as each person's abilities both echo and enlarge the skills and abilities of others.

ARGs have brought the new games movement to new media and social media as well. As Jane McGonigal (2008b), a prominent proponent of ARGs, wagers with a wink, "By 2018 extreme-scale collaboration is the most important human ability." Writer Clay Shirky agrees. In *Here Comes Everybody*, he explains how society is transitioning from a top-down to a bottom-up institution of power as individuals are increasingly enabled to connect spontaneously through scalable networks. Due to the rise of new media technologies, our existing social impulses are becoming amplified in their scope and degree of connections. Shirky claims that "we now have communications tools that are flexible enough to match our social capabilities, and we are witnessing the rise of new ways of coordinating action that takes advantage of that change." As technoculture advances, Shirky (2008, 19, 20, 22) explains, barriers to group action will continue to collapse, "and without those barriers, we are free to explore new ways of gathering together and getting things done." The Arab Spring is a more extreme example, while Wikipedia and similar collective efforts are more complicit illustrations.

Contemporary culture does not comprehend how such increases in bottom-up social agency will upset established power dynamics. ARGs and the rhetoric that surrounds them allow us to bridge the gap between where we are and where we might be in a celebratory, wasteful, and hubristic way. As McGonigal (2011) argues, "Reality is broken. Game designers can fix it." The world is united in play and is transformed into a temporary, anarchistic, utopian zone during an ARG. Typical of the complicit political avant-garde, ARGs do not directly attack capitalism or institutions in power but rather infiltrate, appropriate, and bend them to the collective will. They invoke the utopian mood, blending art and politics in a magic circle that is immanent and approachable en masse. ARGs demonstrate that players, in addition to game designers, can fix a broken reality.

Although *The Beast* had ended several months earlier, the Cloudmakers participants were still chatting on their message boards when the terror attacks occurred on September 11, 2001. Initially, their mood was one of shock and grief, as one would expect; within a few hours, however, the mood began to shift. Bold messages popped up: "We can solve the puzzle of who the terrorists are"; "we have the means, resources, and experience to put a picture together from a vast wealth of knowledge and personal intuition." For days the Cloudmakers' collective hubris grew. The forum moderators eventually intervened, arguing that unlike 9/11, *The Beast* "was scripted. There were clues hidden that were gauged for us. It was *narrative*. . . . *This is not a game*. Do not go getting delusions of grandeur. Cloudmakers solved a story. This is real life" (McGonigal 2003).

The point is not whether the Cloudmakers could really have "solved" 9/11. The point is that *The Beast* had materially changed the ways in which players were prepared to react to a national crisis. Participating in *The Beast* had naturalized a more fluid grasp of political power. Reality was indeed broken, and players were the ones who could fix it if they could play well enough together. This point is made even clearer when the Cloudmakers' reaction to 9/11 is contrasted with that of the nation as a whole. Following 9/11, both the mainstream media and majority of US citizens were confused, angry, and shocked into passivity. As a result, the public relied on established governmental and military institutions of power to deal with the crisis, clearing the way for the Patriot Act and launching a never-ending war on terror.

Rather than permit those in power to process shock and fear for them, the complicit political avant-garde enables people to process these forces directly. The public learns to work—and play—together to sublimate those emotions into collective, affirmative actions. Avant-garde politics transform shock and terror into materials with which the masses play.

Clearly, the complicit political avant-garde is proactive—it creates the world in which it wants to live. For instance, Heath Bunting and Kayle Brandon are attempting to "delete the border" by hacking national boundaries on a distributed scale. The game *BorderXing Guide* (2001–), sponsored by the Tate Gallery London, asks players to cross the borders of European countries illegally, surreptitiously, and without papers. An online database, accessible only in tactical geographic locations, outlines successful



Figure 5.3
Players of *BorderXing Guide* illegally sneak across European national borders. Image, courtesy of Heath Bunting, shows players rafting into Germany from France at Strasbourg.

procedures for crossing undetected by customs, police, and military. In a more local example, Bunting and Rachel Baker's *SuperWeed* (1999–2009) empowered players to use herbicide-resistant seed bombs to enrich barren spaces in the urban landscape. *BorderXing* and *SuperWeed* actualize the complicit political avant-garde forces that had begun to emerge in the Cloudmakers' response to 9/11, inviting people to play outside established channels of political power and discourse to create better—if not utopian—worlds.

Although they invite people to play outside the mainstream, complicit political avant-garde games do not fight or replace traditional political structures or discourse. Instead, they work within and beyond them. Rather than proposing referenda, participating in debates, or sharing petitions, complicit political artists approach the world orthogonally—impelling and daring people to live *otherwise* through play, even if only momentarily.

In *The Last Whole Earth Catalogue* (1971), Stewart Brand summarizes this constructivist attitude: "We're not into utopian thinking around here, preferring a more fiasco-by-fiasco approach to perfection." The objective is to render the social infrastructure open, accessible, and reconfigurable by those who actually comprise it. It is not about marching collectively onward and upward toward a predetermined utopian destination that only exists in fantasies and manifestos. The aim of complicit political avant-garde art is to play with utopian ideas right now and then let those ideas go as soon as they fall apart.

World Games

Buckminster Fuller designed an avant-garde game in 1961 that drew the entire planet—its cultures, materials, life-forms, and climate—inside its magic circle. It was called *The World Game: Integrative Resource Utilization Planning Tool*, and could theoretically incorporate all sciences and systems. Fuller studied the war games of the North American Aerospace Defense Command (NORAD) and other simulations at the US Navy War College. From these war games, Fuller created "peace games." Like war games, peace games draw on a matrix of disparate and diverse data in order to embed the theater of gamespace into all measured dimensions, and culminate in a rich, composite grasp and view of the world. The major difference is that peace games—unlike the simulations of global nuclear holocaust or mutually assured destruction that dominated the Cold War era—are played toward global utopia.

Learning from war games, Fuller reconfigured how global simulations could model the world and interpellate players. Rather than playing for one country's domination over the rest, the challenge was to create collective play that would "make the world work for 100% of humanity in the shortest possible time through spontaneous cooperation without ecological damage or disadvantage to anyone" (Gabel 2009). In order to help players visualize gamespace in ways that fostered multilateral thinking, Fuller designed the Dymaxion Map. This map minimized spatial distortion while displaying the continents contiguously as a singular blob, emphasizing geographic continuity and planetary community versus national borders.

War games have grown by several orders of magnitude in complexity since the time when Fuller was inspired by the original NORAD games. The

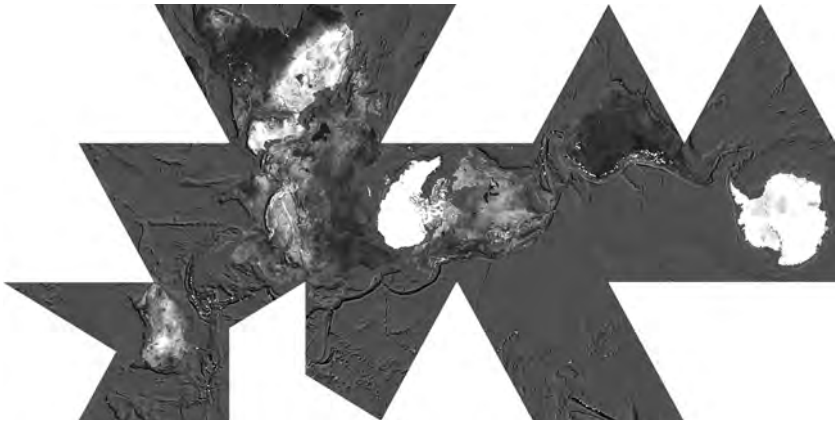


Figure 5.4
A Dymaxion Map, similar to the map used in Buckminster Fuller's *World Game* (1961), renders continental landmass contiguously, so that the geopolitical world is conceptually more integrated. Image from Wikimedia Commons.

Synthetic Environment for Analysis and Simulations in use by Homeland Security and the US Department of Defense "is now capable of running real-time simulations for up to 62 nations, including Iraq, Afghanistan, and China." These systems integrate "breaking news, census data, economic . . . and climactic events in the real world . . . [along with] military intelligence" into a unitary whole (Baard 2007). The "Sentient World Simulation" will be a "continuously running, continually updated mirror model of the real world that can be used to predict and evaluate future events and courses of action" (Chaturvedi 2006).

Fuller's peace games have evolved as well, though. By the 1980s, *World Game* was played on basketball-court-sized maps tracking and visualizing an array of real-time data, including birthrates and death rates, famines, armed conflicts, supply and demand of foodstuffs, rate of deforestation, and so forth. Fuller's ultimate approach to governance and social problem solving was to call the planet "Spaceship Earth," a ship driven by the human collective. For Fuller, each of us is an Earth pilot; each of us should realize gameplay locally and in a personal way. World games must be "accessible to everyone, not just the elite few in the power structure who thought they were running the show" (Gabel 2009). Fuller's notions of accessibility and global agency are the most challenging aspects of world games to develop.

Populist Avant-garde Politics

While Fuller was a peaceful figure in the complicit political avant-garde, there are others in the movement who are more closely wedded to provocateur tactics. While still complicit, they live a little further down toward the radical end of the political spectrum. They marry the intellectual gall of Fuller and fiery gusto of Italian futurist Marinetti, acting as instigators, breaking society's established patterns, and festively playing with reality.

According to the political avant-garde, all media are political, especially when they are framed as entertainment. The manner in which entertainment regulates social relationships makes it political. To put it in political avant-garde terms: a global consciousness cannot arise until society breaks free from the false consciousness sustained by popular media protected by institutions in power. These sentiments motivated Guy Debord and a small group of artists to forge the Situationist International in 1957, in order to target what Debord called "the spectacle." In his 1967 book *The Society of the Spectacle*, Debord (1997, 17) writes that the "spectacle is not a collection of images, rather, it is a social relationship between people that is mediated by images. . . . [The] spectacle is by definition immune from human activity, inaccessible to any projected review or correction. It is the opposite of dialogue. . . . It is the sun that never sets on the empire of modern passivity." The Situationists broke apart, remixed, and released social power bottled up in the spectacle.

In his 1973 film *Society of the Spectacle*, Debord read passages from his book over clips from soft porn, television commercials, and popular movies like those by Orson Welles and John Ford. Although the actors appear mildly tragic as their world is mocked, the film does not collapse into simple parody. Instead, the act of spectatorship is made discomforting. Debord called this critical remixing *détournement*, a process he defined as "turning expressions of the capitalist system and its media culture against itself" (quoted Holt 2010, 252). Thus, détournement infuses art with argumentation.

The Situationists wished to avoid the trap that had enmeshed Dada in the early twentieth century, when according to their critics, the Dadaists had sought to revolutionize life and had ended up only revolutionizing art. Moreover, the entertainment industry picked up the Dadaists' avant-garde strategies, assimilating them to some degree into popular culture. Rather



Figure 5.5
In his Situationist film, *Society of the Spectacle* (1973), Guy Debord appropriated, juxtaposed, and critically remixed imagery from commercial television, popular films, and historical events. UbuWeb.

than starting with art, then, the Situationists began by hacking entertainment, as with *Society of the Spectacle*. In doing so, the Situationists hoped to instigate movements similar to Dadaist work in intent that were characterized by greater sustainability. Détournement critiqued the very media that it spoke through and became a precursor to culture jamming. Instead of the culture industry appropriating the artistic work, the art appropriated the culture industry. The Situationists in this way reframed popular entertainment as a material to remix and play with. To augment this effect, they left artworks open to interpretation in order to create unstable social situations. An early screening of *Society of the Spectacle* closed with, "We live like lost children, our adventures incomplete," followed by twenty-four minutes of darkness. The audience was left to deal with the tenuous ending on its own.

The Situationists went beyond entertainment to remix urban space and reclaim the public sphere as a place for collective play with reality. They would "drift" through a city in a game they called the *dérive*. A dérive is a

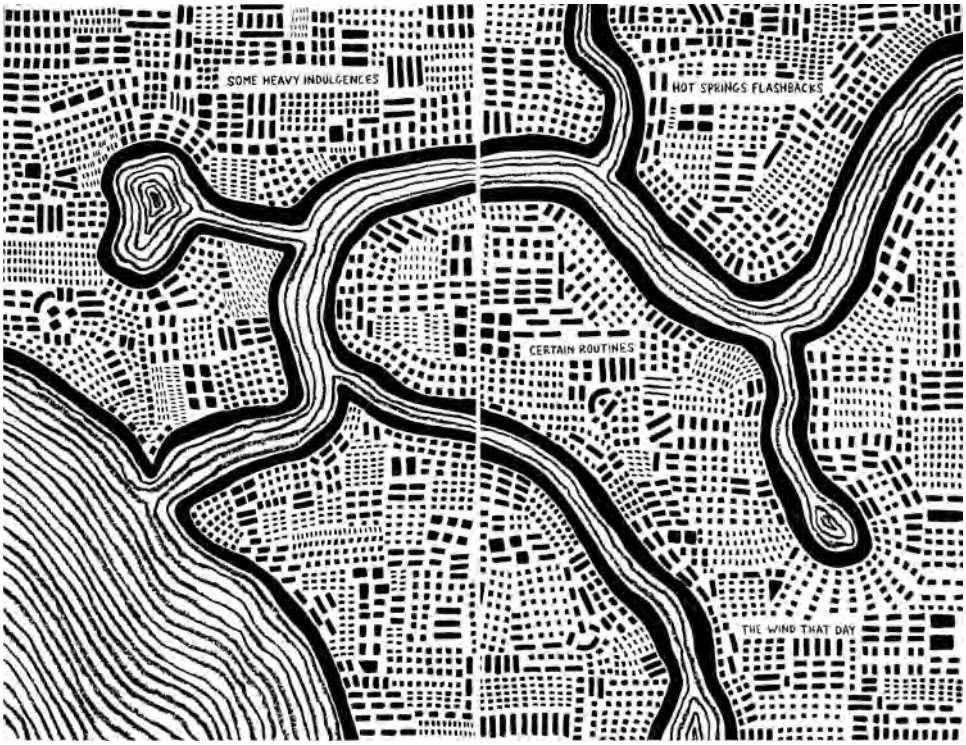


Figure 5.6
In *Some Heavy Indulgences* (2009), Dahlia Elsayed advances political art techniques established by the Situationists in the 1960s. Elsayed describes her work as using "cartographic references that combine suggestions of hard data (streets, waterways, elevations, borders) to locate experiences of soft data such as emotional/sensory/psychological states." Quote and image courtesy of Dahlia Elsayed.

spontaneous journey in which travelers allow the aesthetics of the architecture and geography to affect them emotionally as well as subconsciously, and direct them so that they might foster new relationships with the space. Debord (1956) describes the practice:

> In a dérive one or more persons during a certain period drop their relations, their work and leisure activities, and all their other usual motives for movement and action, and let themselves be drawn by the attractions of the terrain and the encounters they find there. Chance is a less important factor in this activity than one might think: from a dérive point of view, cities have psychogeographical contours, with constant currents, fixed points and vortexes that strongly discourage entry into or exit from certain zones.

To facilitate dérives, the Situationists cut up and reassembled maps to open novel vectors for experiencing urban space. They documented dérives as improvisational "psychogeographical" studies of the city—combining photographs, reworked maps, and meticulous notation of their sensations and reactions to all phenomena encountered.

The purpose of the dérive was to liberate people from established patterns of urban life while responding to the increasingly technical nature of that life with a technical literacy that was both generative and playful. For Debord, play was a political act. As he explained, the "Situationist game stands out from the standard conception of the game" and from its false "separation from the stream of life." To play avant-garde games is a "moral choice," ensuring "the future reign of freedom and play" (Debord (2006a, 97). The Situationists wished for a total revolution of the dominant order—of rational thought, human language, and sense itself—but also realized that they could only transform life through a thousand cuts to the status quo, not via the mythical, apocalyptic instant that revolutionaries had historically desired. It would undoubtedly take many thousands of situations and anarchist games before the complicit political avant-garde could open up the entire world to play.

Détourning Shock

In the 2007 ARG *World Without Oil*, players collectively imagined what catastrophes and opportunities might arise in the event that oil demand surpassed supply. How would people in unprepared infrastructures cope? What new methods of sustainable living would become viable? The puppetmasters of *World Without Oil* incrementally raised the fictional price of gas over the course of several weeks. The global economy first went into a recession and then a depression. Another world war erupted. All events were determined spontaneously by the player collective, causing many to dispute what was actually happening. The puppetmasters wanted to give "people 'permission' to think seriously about a future they might otherwise avoid thinking about at all." Players began "thinking about their neighbors and communities in new ways, and planting gardens, going to farmer's markets, using bicycles and transit and otherwise questioning their dependence on cheap, plentiful oil" (Waite 2007). Beyond these positive yet

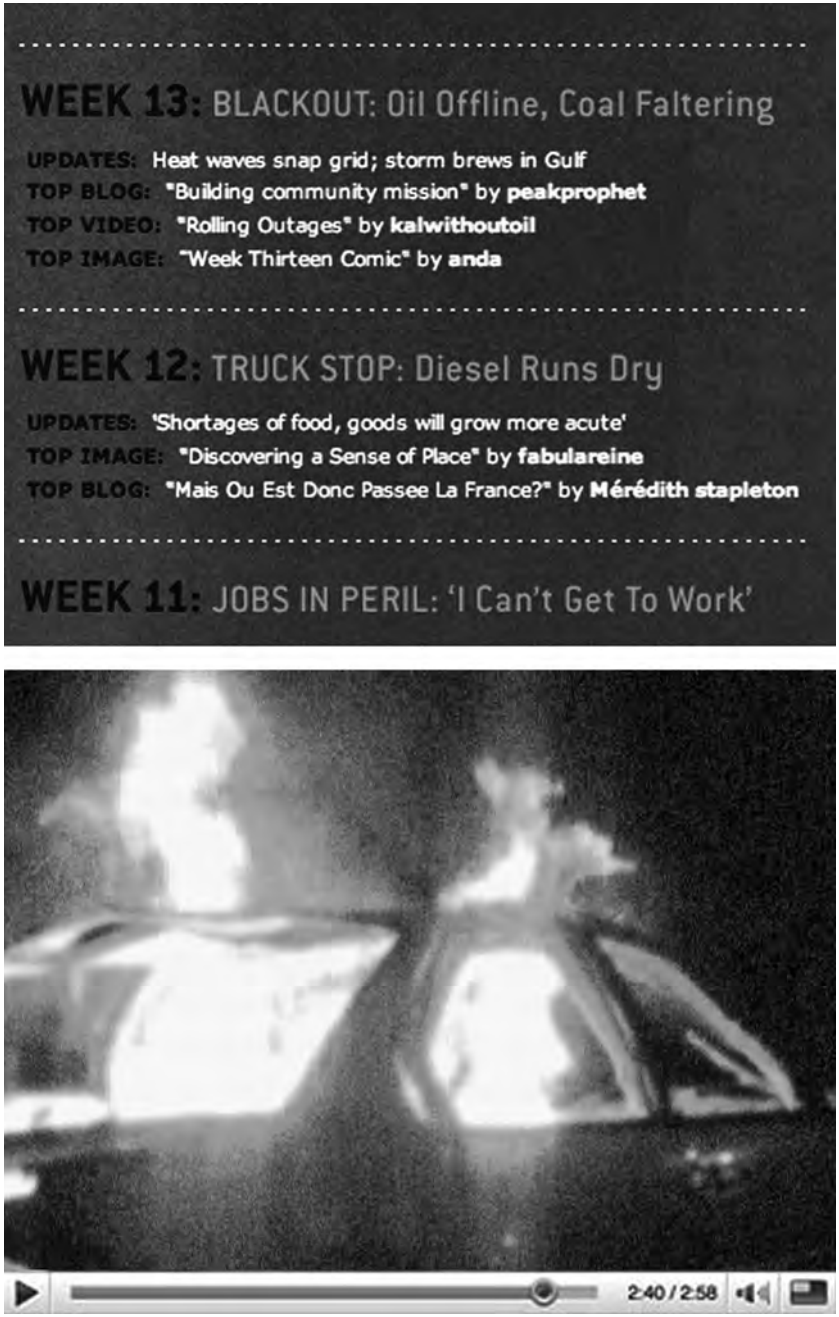


Figure 5.7
World Without Oil (April–June 2007) simulated the beginning of the end of a fossil-fueled economy, but was really an ARG about the collective deconstruction of shock. Images courtesy of Ken Eklund.

expected outcomes, people also dramatically deconstructed and reworked the mediation of crisis itself.

Players coped with challenges, producing in-game narratives across thousands of blogs. They posted apocalyptic videos along with pictures of gas stations ablaze and cars abandoned on US highways. Soldiers stationed in Iraq wrote as though they had been deployed to protect the US oil supply—while critics suggested that such blogging would actually be unlikely due to a probable media blackout. Although there was no official goal or prize, a player felt they had "won" when a critical mass of other players accepted their dramatized prediction of what news media, governments, and militaries would do. Not only did players constantly evaluate the possibility of each other's projections, they also collectively critiqued the ways in which crises are usually mediated. The diverse collective simultaneously constructed and deconstructed its own spectacle, gaining a kind of kaleidoscopic perspective.

The Situationists demonstrated how détourned media drains power from spectacle and redistributes that power to the people who remixed it. *World Without Oil* was a détournement of a common contemporary spectacle: mediated crisis. Naomi Klein (2007) argues in the *Shock Doctrine* that governments, corporations, and militaries use shock as a psychological weapon to stupefy populations into accepting change, whether that change represents a new policy, unique product, or even war. Ostensibly, *World Without Oil* was about oil, but in practice it was about breaking the power of images and stories to stupefy. On the one hand, the game went exactly where the Cloudmakers had hoped to go with their call to fix 9/11, bringing terrible events into the magic circle so players could save or improve the world. On the other hand, *World Without Oil* allowed people to engage, reimagine, and control the terrible events themselves, dissipating the power to make passive that such events commonly have. As the complicit political avant-garde becomes more popular, it will inoculate populations against future shock, never-ending wars on terror, and the ongoing rise of the totalitarian state.

Gonzo Gamers

The complicit political avant-garde redistributes power in society through games while at the same time redistributing power within games by



Figure 5.8
Joseph DeLappe performs *dead-in-iraq*, texting names of people who died in the Iraq War, from within the game *America's Army* (a recruiting tool of the US Army). Image is a detail of a screenshot courtesy of Joseph DeLappe.

opening up their spectacular nature to play. The avant-garde shows how to be truly active in games, making normal players seem passive in comparison because they accept games as framed by corporate, government, or military powers. It demonstrates how to really play games by opening up alternate ways of being and performing in them that are easy for most players to understand as well as reproduce.

In *dead-in-iraq* (2006–) Joseph DeLappe détourns the networked shooter game *America's Army* (developed by the US Army as a recruiting tool) by logging into the game, and then texting the names and ranks of every US soldier killed in Iraq. It has taken dozens of hours to type the name, age, service branch, and date of death of the thousands of US soldiers who were killed in Iraq. In the original *America's Army*, each team sees its opposition as terrorists and its own team as Americans, because the army did not want to produce a game in which international players could kill Americans.

According to DeLappe, *dead-in-iraq* is a "fleeting online memorial" and a counterrecruiting cautionary gesture. In it, he brings the specter of physical death into the realm of virtual death. As DeLappe explains, "Part of the reason we are so disconnected from what is going on in Iraq is that we consider the responsibility towards mourning to solely fall on the shoulders of the loved ones." Through this piece of complicit political avant-garde art, DeLappe (2007) tries to "take personal responsibility towards mourning the deaths." He is doing more than that, however. DeLappe's act of détournement recalls the uncanny and problematic *other* in *America's Army*, which had been previously reduced to an easy-to-eliminate terrorist caricature. His actions disrupt the mood of gameplay by gently reasserting the obvious but easily forgotten fact that America's actual army is not a team playing a game but rather real people who literally suffer, kill, and die in war.

Avant-garde performers involve players in their work in ways that are even more aggressive than those used in *dead-in-iraq*. *Velvet Strike* (2002)



Figure 5.9
Virtual graffiti in *Velvet Strike* interventions changes the nature of the networked multiplayer shooter game *Counter Strike*. Image courtesy of Anne-Marie Schleiner.

by Anne-Marie Schleiner, Joan Leandre, and Brody Condon is a set of game "intervention recipes" that anyone can use and remix in the networked tactical shooter *Counter Strike*. Instead of gunning down terrorists, the artists chat about baking. Performers release hostages captured by their teammates and purposely betray team tactics to the enemy. They invite teammates into a vehicle and drive them far from battle, ultimately revealing the shared journey as a kidnapping. Captives must either commit group suicide to escape or slowly walk back once released. The *Velvet Strike* team employs mock-revolutionary rhetoric:

> Our mission is to seek out those who would attempt to propagate the vile seeds of strife and division upon the burgeoning fields of online entertainment. Why are these gaming environments so savage and ruthless? We all exist within these virtual domains and as members we have a duty to each other to coexist in a Utopian world free of hate and struggle (King 2002)

The playful protests of *Velvet Strike* create an even more open game by using the dislodged raw materials of *Counter Strike*. For example, gay culture is celebrated in *Velvet Strike*. Another recipe calls for spraying graffiti all over the architecture in the game. Male cops or soldiers kissing are common images in the graffiti because they simultaneously supplant the dominant game tropes of heteronormativity and aggressive masculinity with acceptance and love. Graffiti has long been a tool of the complicit political avant-garde; the Situationists, for example, used it to great effect during the mass protests in 1968 France. Jean Baudrillard (2003, 287) spells out the art form's unique political power: "Graffiti is transgressive, not because it substitutes another content, another discourse, but simply because it responds, there, on the spot, and breaches the fundamental role of non-response enunciated by all the media." *Velvet Strike* is not merely a negation of what exists in *Counter Strike*; it is also a positive assertion of what might exist. It infuses the political world into the game and the game into the political world, contesting gamespace right here and now in a playable way. *Counter Strike* becomes a game that is fundamentally in play for brief situations and moments in time.

Gonzo Gamers (2013), a student project in my art games class at DePaul University, was inspired by *Velvet Strike* and Hunter S. Thompson's "gonzo" reporting. In it, the artists created even gentler recipes of disruption. One of Alex Dahm's recipes was to become a sports commentator in the networked shooter *Team Fortress 2*. Instead of fighting, an artist would run through

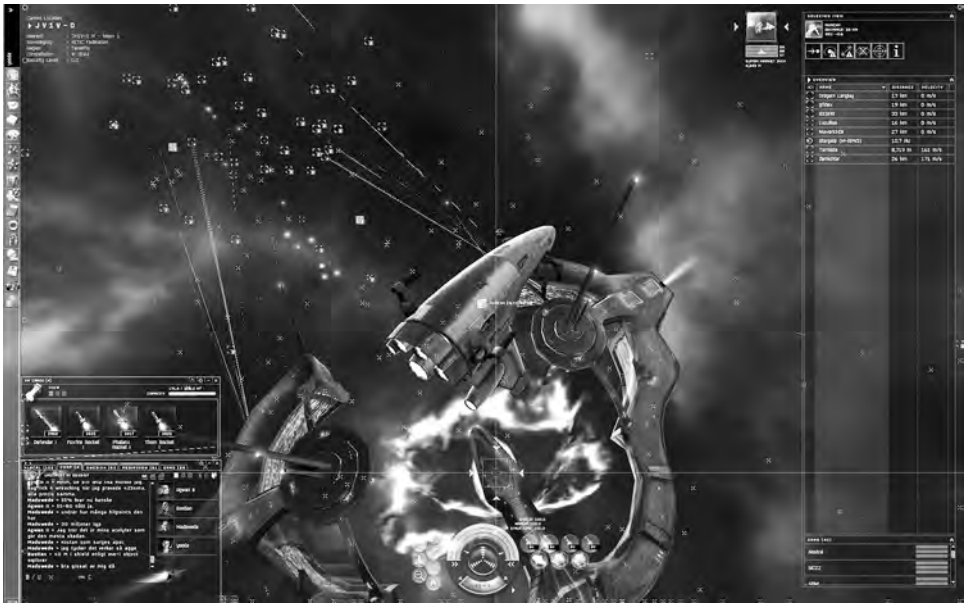


Figure 5.10
This screenshot captures a battle in *EVE Online* between a number of players and a station. Image courtesy of CCP Games and Perplexing.

battle with a baseball bat held up like a microphone. David Finseth (2013) describes his version of the performance: "After a few failures, I found a group of people who started to warm up to the idea of me following them around commentating on what they were doing. Players began interacting with me. We discussed current game meta mechanics and theory."[3] If Babeli (discussed in chapter 3) is a sweet griefer, *Gonzo Gamers* are even sweeter.

Some complicit avant-garde political acts have the power to make permanent transformations in a game, though, moving beyond fleeting moments of gonzo gaming. *EVE Online* is a brutal capitalist MMO with a science fiction theme that was permanently changed by the complicit political avant-garde. In *EVE Online*, warring player factions ruled a vast universe teeming with thousands of star systems including planets, moons, asteroids, and wormholes. Months of grind are required to build up a respectable, customized ship for a player to pilot. Beyond combat, players engage in mining, piracy, trade, and manufacturing. Large ships can be worth thousands of

real-world dollars when sold in online auctions. *EVE Online* is a persistent world; when a ship is defeated in battle, it is erased from the game, and its real-world value is also lost. Griefers calling themselves "goons" from the Something Awful forums comprised the GoonSwarm alliance, a collective that destroyed a ship belonging to the Band of Brothers alliance—the most highly valued ship in the game at the time.

GoonSwarm defeated the Band of Brothers ship through emergent gameplay tactics. Goons figured out that by creating and launching thousands of tiny frigates and T1 cruisers, they could overwhelm the Band of Brothers ship. That large ship would not be able to bring in reinforcements because the frame rate would decelerate for everybody in the area. Because they had a numerical advantage per frame rate, the goons had a net gain in maneuverability and firepower. As soon as a goon died, they picked up another disposable ship for a kamikaze attack. Using a guerrilla strategy with little investment of time or money, the goons annihilated the Titan ship by "choking the guns of our enemies with our corpses" (Dibbell 2008).

Goons rejected *EVE Online*'s usual markers of success and alliance strength by ignoring such factors as the kill-to-death ratio. Although the goons' tactics gave them a terrible score, the story of the GoonSwarm alliance winning against the odds spread, eventually making GoonSwarm the most popular player group in *EVE Online*. Because GoonSwarm rejected the (previously popular) values of virtual property, rank, and score, it attracted an influx of new, inexperienced players whose immediate goal was to go into battle. Playing by its own emergent set of rules, GoonSwarm changed the nature of the game. Ambivalence plagued GoonSwarm (2006) players as they struggled to invent new means of organizing swarm behavior, and bounced blindly between historic successes and defeats:

> We are a terrible alliance playing a terrible game, we failed to kill our major enemy because we couldn't co-ordinate with allies so we just retreated and lost 2 regions to them. They are now wiping out our allies in another part of Eve while we hold our dicks, the RSF has fallen apart (What's left of the R is shooting the F) and everyone knows that if BoB [Band of Brothers] turn on us now, we are completely fucked. . . . [We risk] donation-drive inspiring levels of failure.

GoonSwarm shifted the concept of what was considered a "normal" player. Through avant-garde play, the game accommodated and empowered a more diverse influx of new players, who could immediately engage important in-game actions rather than drudging through the usual training

process. Power was distributed at the expense of stability—an instability that spread beyond control. The goons infiltrated the Band of Brothers alliance with a spy who ascended to director level, stole all the assets, and destroyed the alliance.[4] GoonSwarm itself eventually collapsed from within when its guild leader failed to keep up with critical logistical duties, promptly drained the account balance, and purposely disbanded the alliance (Drain 2010).

The complicit political avant-garde breaks apart power collected at the top, gently prying it from those who manage and rule infrastructure—whether that infrastructure is comprised of streets or servers—and redistributes it to swarms of people at the bottom. Artists of this movement expect their experiments of mass inclusion to fall apart eventually, understanding that an anarchist utopia is a tumultuous way of being and not a perfect, solid state. For this reason, the complicit political avant-garde cannot be evaluated by the success of any one event or game. Each complicit avant-garde work must instead be evaluated by the extent to which it contributes to the larger, long-term project of inciting those swarms of people at the bottom to participate—together and repeatedly—in thousands of such games and events, decade after decade, thus creating ad hoc utopias of festive anarchy.

6 Narrative Formal

Russian Formalism

The narrative formal avant-garde focuses on the narrative affordances of art, whether the medium is literature, film, or games. Narrative formal art can either be radical or complicit, depending on how much it conforms to the expectations for conventional mainstream entertainment experiences. The historical precedent is Russian formalism, a progenitor of many modernist literary and aesthetic theories of the twentieth century, including those of Greenberg. The Russian formalists defended authors who experimented with the novel as well as with other literary forms. For example, they championed *The Life and Opinions of Tristram Shandy, Gentleman*, a novel by Laurence Sterne (published in nine volumes between 1759 and 1767), which was deplored by many of Sterne's contemporaries. Sterne's lengthy digressions and playful treatment of structure, such as the placement of the preface in the middle of the book and omission of eventful chapters, led critics to declare that *Tristram Shandy* was not actually a novel. Victor Shklovsky (1965b, 57), a prominent Russian formalist, corrected them, "*Tristram Shandy* is the most typical novel in world literature." *Tristram Shandy* imbued readers with a vivid awareness of the usual forms and conventions of literature by artfully breaking from norms in its expansive text; similarly, radical formal painters such as Manet instilled in viewers a vivid awareness of the usual forms and conventions of painting by breaking from them in expansive works.

The narrative formal avant-garde has a second agenda as well. It advances the effect and force of art well beyond what we normally consider narrative. The Russian formalists used their work to blur the line between

a heightened art experience and the experience of everyday reality. They employed this strategy to make the point that the experience of art affects the shape and structure of reality; to play with art was to play with reality. In "Art as Technique" (1917), Shklovsky (1965a) stated that "art exists [so] that one may recover the sensation of life; it exists to make one feel things, to make the stone *stony*." Art's purpose is to make the experience of reality luminous and gripping. This view of art places greater responsibility on the reader, viewer, or player to viscerally invest oneself in an artwork in order to experience its total force.

Gertrude Stein's poetry provides a good example of narrative avant-garde formalist strategies at work. *Susie Asado*, written by Stein in 1912, begins with the line "Sweet sweet sweet sweet sweet tea." Reading it aloud with verve, we are struck by a few things. First, we become sensually aware of the texture and materiality of the flow of phonemes via alliteration and repetition. Second, the onomatopoetic string sparks the feeling of sipping sweet tea on one's tongue. The two effects are complementary. Stein entangles taste and sound so we may savor speech, mingling sweet tea memories, and in-the-moment mouth rhythms.

Another technique Stein developed is a form of cubist poetry, tearing up and reconstructing "word-heaps" that she found in the world. For instance, she would stare at a still life of food "until something that was not the name of that thing but was in a way that actual thing would come to be written." Stein's associative process fused with the food: "Apple plum, carpet steak, seed clam, coloured wine, calm seen, cold cream, best shake" (Lodge 1978, 488). Tastes, textures, and morphemes pile up on top of each other, yet many readers cannot help but puzzle through the poem.

The purpose of narrative formal art is to *defamiliarize* and *estrange* us from reality so that we struggle to resituate ourselves within it. Narrative formalism works by pulling "us into a dramatic awareness of language," and in doing so, it "refreshes these habitual responses and renders objects more 'perceptible.'" We must "grapple with language in a more strenuous, self-conscious way than usual" so that "the world which that language inhabits is vividly renewed" (Eagleton 1996, 3). Our perception churns and adapts to meet the challenge.

The more one believes that language, stories, and narrative patterns determine the perception of reality (instead of believing they are determined *by* reality), the more this strategy makes sense. For example,

according to Murray (1997, 142), a "game is a kind of abstract storytelling that resembles the world of common experience, but compresses it in order to heighten interest" Murray sees games as inherently narrative forms. Yet the narrative formal avant-garde does more than present a compressed resemblance of the world. It compresses that resemblance until artistic conventions bend and break, and the world glows anew in deformed caricature.

Interactive Fiction

The best place to begin is with the game genre most ostensibly like literature and the most puzzling in its language—IF. The first IF game was the text adventure *Colossal Cave Adventure*, programmed by Will Crowther in 1976, and expanded and debugged by Don Woods in 1977. The game

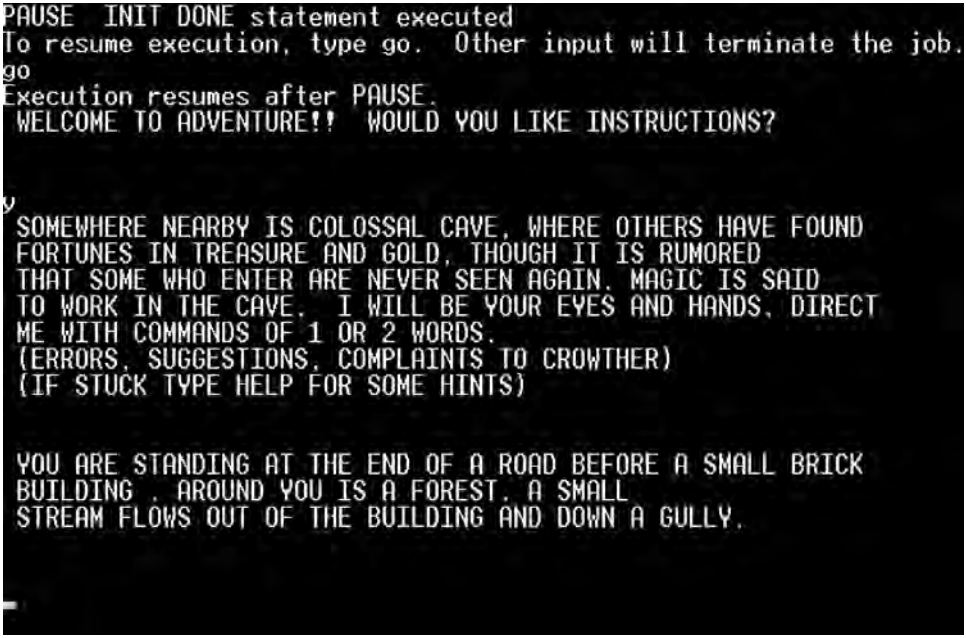


Figure 6.1
The start screen of the first text adventure, *Colossal Cave Adventure* (1976), is shown here—an unintentionally avant-garde game by Will Crowther and Don Woods. Image courtesy of Don Woods.

describes the world entirely through text, and the player explores the world through typed input such as "go west" and acts via commands such as "attack troll." *Colossal Cave Adventure* uses a simple language parser that interprets text input and, using descriptive text, outputs the result, such as a change in the environment, the acquisition of treasure, or the death of the player.

Nick Montfort (2003, 3), author of the first major treatise on IF, explains that puzzles in the game "control the revelation of the narrative; they are part of an interactive process that generates narrative." Readers of traditional fiction have always generated and controlled their own interpretations of the story. The structure by which the author revealed the story, though, was already established on the printed page (Aarseth 1997). What is novel to IF is its inclusion of the player as coauthor, who reconfigures the underlying structure of the narrative, along with the computer as instructed by the game's original author. IF players also tend to create lots of ancillary media, such as notes, lists, diagrams, and maps that are meticulously revised and annotated. Authorship is distributed throughout the entire system of engagement. Rather than detracting from the experience, distributed authorship adds more dimensions through which authors can participate and collaborate via the computer.

The input process of IF is both the genre's greatest strength and weakness. On the one hand, the input process affords a new mode of textual coauthorship as stories are partially written as they are played. On the other hand, the narrative may never result in a coherent story. The practical constraint is the gap between a limited database of language that the game is able to parse and the complexity as well as nuance of language as we use it in everyday life. The most frustrating experience is having to type in the exact word when the desired action should be obvious. For instance, the game may state: "There is a rock on the ground." So the player types, "Take the rock," to which the game replies, "I don't understand 'rock.'" Racking their brain, the player may realize the programmer's mistake and type, "Take the stone," to which the game affirms, "Stone taken." The inability of the parser to process the slip of everyday language has an unintentional defamiliarizing effect. It renders the attempted action of picking up the stone awkward through the machine's ignorance of "rock." The player delves into the gap between a computational perspective of the world and a familiar, human experience of the world.

IF is difficult to write, design, program, and play, and while the genre experienced a period of popularity in the 1980s and 1990s, it has since become a genre of aficionados and academics. The estrangement of players is seldom the intent of authors, although these games are often experienced in such a way. The community is ambivalent about the genre's status as an accidental avant-garde. Enthusiasts want IF to gain broader acceptance in popular culture, but they also want to push the boundaries of the genre. *Colossal Cave Adventure* was intended to flow smoothly and transparently for players. Crowther anticipated the game for an audience of "non-computer people." He explored caves as a hobby and wished to share that wonderful thrill with his children. The game was to be "a re-creation in fantasy of my caving, and also . . . a game for the kids" (quoted in Aarseth 1997, 10). As opposed to defamiliarizing language and narrative structures, Crowther wanted to seamlessly immerse the player inside a magical story world. The player was not supposed to become entangled in the computational twisting of narrative, half inside and half outside the story. Despite his intentions, Crowther created a narrative formal avant-garde game. A work may be avant-garde regardless of whether or not that is the artist's intent. In fact, artistic accident can foster some of the most warped and illuminating avant-garde game experiences. In such work, not only are the familiar conventions at odds with each other, but they are at odds with the artist as well.

After the 1970s, IF became hugely popular. Early adopters of personal computers were willing to navigate the frontiers of computation and learn these textual videogame forms. In the 1980s, Infocom produced dozens of hits, notably the *Zork* series. As games advanced graphically, so did IF, which moved further and further from the text adventure genre. The successful *King's Quest* series juxtaposed images with the text. In the 1990s, the cartoonish and clever *Monkey Island* series by LucasArts used narrative formal elements such as combating pirates by typing in verbal insults. The biggest IF hit of the 1990s was *Myst*, which subsumed the entire story within a seamless, lush graphic presentation. Players could simply click on images to navigate, like a primitive but pretty Google Street View. *Myst* helped sell millions of desktop computers because the game showed off computing's new graphic power.

The popularity of the IF genre peaked with *Myst* and then fell off a precipice. The genre could not compete in the personal computer market with

the new norm of action-oriented games like *Doom* and *Tomb Raider*. Game designers Chris Crawford and Raph Koster cite the popular decline of IF as the cause of the game industry's chronic inability to make games with a more diverse emotional range—games about the kinds of things we deal with in our everyday lives.

The marginal position of IF as a genre today means that the pressure to regulate it comes not from the market but rather from within the IF community itself. Graham Nelson, who makes IF engines and award-winning games, wrote "A Bill of Player's Rights," which champions transparent, flowing experiences in which the player "need not do unlikely things," need not "type exactly the right verb," is not "given too many red herrings," and is "able to understand a problem once it is solved" (quoted in Aarseth 1997, 49). Still, most players are not willing to entangle themselves in IF whether or not this "Bill of Player's Rights" is adhered to. The ensured outsider status of the IF community gives license to IF designers to ignore Nelson's proviso and make the avant-garde games that they want to make. In recent decades, Crowther's original avant-garde text adventure has spawned many subgenres, such as mystery, erotica, sci-fi, and slice of life.

Adam Cadre's *Photopia* (1998) intentionally violates Nelson's "Bill of Player's Rights." The story is not plotted to follow a predictable sequence of cause and effect. The game begins where the story ultimately ends, with the player hungover in a speeding car packed with college students that crashes into another car. After a play through, the player may figure out that this is the accident that kills Alley, the character around which the entire game turns. The player experiences the world through a flurry of perspectives, playing every character except Alley. We act through Alley's father, her killers, and even her dreams. Through non sequitur scenes and mystifying shifts in perspective, the game jumps forward and backward in time as well as location: a speeding car, a baby's crib, and the surface of Mars. The middle of a scene reads, "Hey, kiddo, do not fall asleep on me yet." At first, it seems Alley's father is speaking, but it is apparently Alley talking to a girl she is babysitting. Alley does not realize that the story she has been telling was told to her as an infant. *Photopia* bewilderingly mixes up voices, worlds, and the usual narrative tropes, leaving it up to the player to determine how to reconcile them.

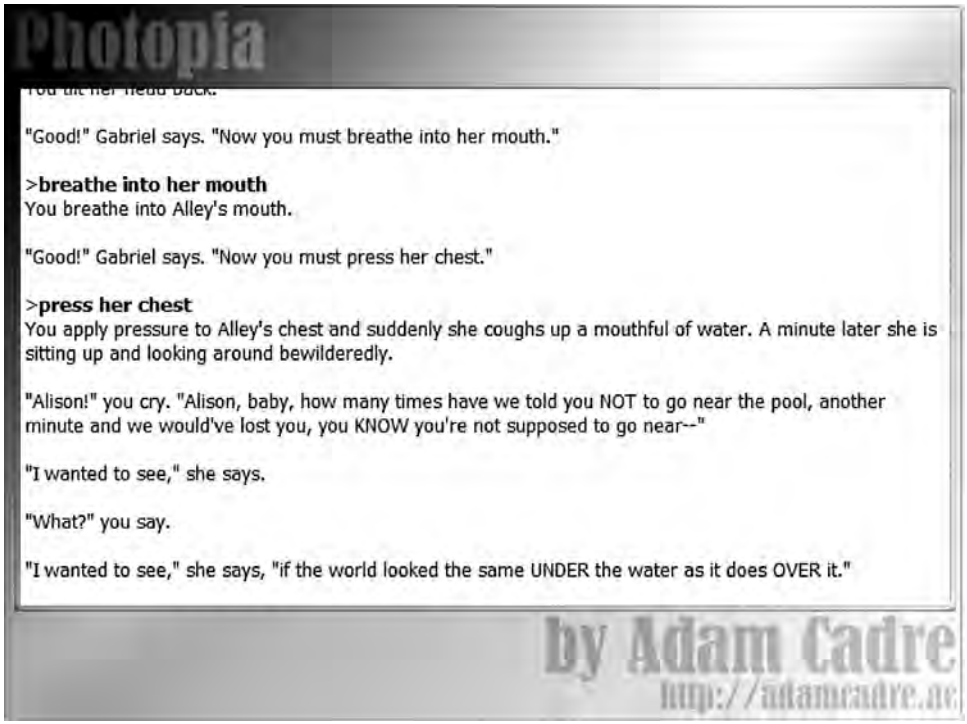


Figure 6.2
The player of *Photopia* unexpectedly jumps into different character roles. Image courtesy of Adam Cadre.

Montfort observes that *Photopia* has no all-encompassing frame, worldview, or base of operations. There is no equivalent to an establishing shot or expository setup to ground the player. The game confuses players, who expect to encounter more conventional narrative structures that would normally enable them to properly perform within the system. One player of *Photopia* writes, "You even think the author is making fun of you" (Froholt 2002). The game calls forth a fractured kind of empathy. The player feels a range of emotions that cannot be integrated into a coherent whole. In contrast to feeling a satisfying electronic closure, the player is left gaping in a kind of electronic fracture. Rather than being emotionally "moved" in a transparent way, as occurs with the most highly acclaimed narrative games, the player grapples with the coauthored structure of the



Figure 6.3
Pac-Txt turns the classic *Pac-Man* game into a neurotic text adventure. Image courtesy of RicMoo (Richard Moore).

game experience itself, consciously manipulating the very patterns that are supposed to move them.

At the opposite end of the dramatic spectrum from *Photopia* is an IF piece by Richard Moore titled *Pac-Txt* (2007). It adapts the action of the classic *Pac-Man* into a horribly literal text adventure. Bereft of graphics, *Pac-Txt* leaves the player lost, blind, and constantly endangered. It begins with the words "You awaken in a large complex. . . . Glowing dots hover mouth level near you in *every* direction. Off in the distance you hear the faint howling of what you can only imagine must be some sort of ghost." Players only "see" ghosts after they attack: "You have been *attacked* by a

cyan ghost! You pass out and awake minutes later back where you began" (Moore 2007).

The player types "f" to move forward, but only by one dot, and "e" to eat the dot; this makes gameplay a laborious and stilted staccato. The fun part is attempting to naturalize the input into an automatic type-to-move twitch pattern. Action accelerates into a nice e-f-e-f-e-f-e-f-e-f rhythm until the prompter flashes: "Smack! You walked into a wall." *Pac-Txt*'s story world is familiar, even nostalgic, but the input is neurotic and disorienting. This is the reverse of *Photopia*, in which the input is straightforward, but the story world is alienating and disorienting.

Natalie Bookchin's game *The Intruder* (1999) reimagines the idea of IF completely. It opens with an awkward transliteration of *Pong*. Instructions

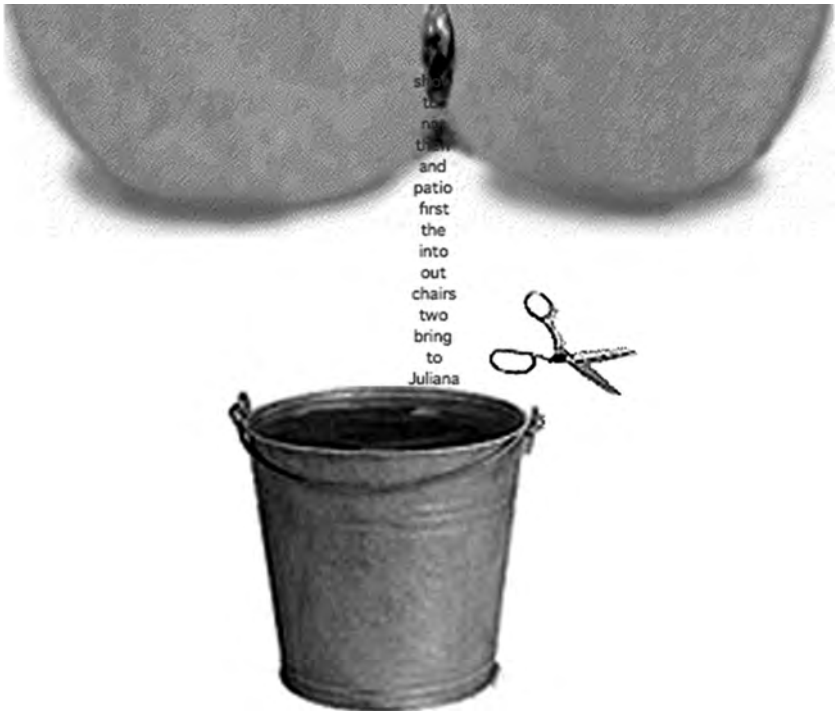


Figure 6.4
The Intruder appropriates mechanics from *Pong*, *Jungle Hunt*, *Laser Blast*, *Outlaw*, and *Kaboom!* with the eponymous Jorge Luis Borges short story. The screenshot shows objects falling from a vagina as the player catches them in a bucket. Image courtesy of Natalie Bookchin.

point to the paddle: "You are here." Blocks of text about a woman named Juliana, who is passed between two men, replace the ball. The game is based on a short story titled *La Intrusa* (1970) by Jorge Luis Borges about two brothers who fight over Juliana, who they ultimately betray, sell to a brothel, and kill. The game warps how narrative events are simulated both literally and allegorically. In the story, Juliana pitifully gathers all her possessions into a bucket at one point. In the game, a naked bottom shakes out soccer balls, scissors, and chunks of text, while the player catches the overflow in a rattling bucket. This particular mechanism references an Atari 2600 game, *Kaboom!* but replaces bombs with feminine waste. The player adopts the role of an anxiously insecure male mocked in feminist caricature, which simulates the Freudian fear at work in Borges's story: a bottomless, unsatisfied female sexuality whose irrational exuberance overflows the inadequate grasp of the male. The player enacts the misogyny of the original story, but in crafting the work, Bookchin used a liberating art style that cuts through the misogyny with humor.

In *On Art and Life*, John Ruskin links the liberation of the artist with that of the viewer. If an artist allows spontaneous evidence of their human handiwork—such as accidents—to remain present in their art, it breathes more life into the experience. When the viewer gazes on an old cathedral front, the "ugly goblins, and formless monsters, and stern statues, anatomiless and rigid," are "signs of life and liberty of every workman who struck the stone" (Ruskin 2005). Playing *The Intruder*, you may get a sense of what it was like for Bookchin to surf the Internet, browsing for JPEG images, pixilated ephemera, and audio chirps to use in constructing the game's collage. The game expresses a loose, lively energy. It leaves the usual desire for machinelike control in games unfulfilled, which makes its mechanical misogyny that much more poignant and problematic to play through.

Game, game, game, and again game (2007) is a 2D platformer by Jason Nelson in which the player controls a scribble in a chicken-scratch world of teleportals, bombs, and cityscapes. *Game, game, game, and again game* piles up narrative conventions in a more muddled way than *The Intruder*. Clacking Super 8 video, text chunks that appear to revel in their dislocation, and an assortment of visual and auditory cues vie for attention. The obsessively accumulative, sloppy handicraft suggests a connection to outsider art. The onslaught of symbols, stanzas, warnings, and other detritus inundates the player into a sort of semiotic numbness. Montfort (2007)

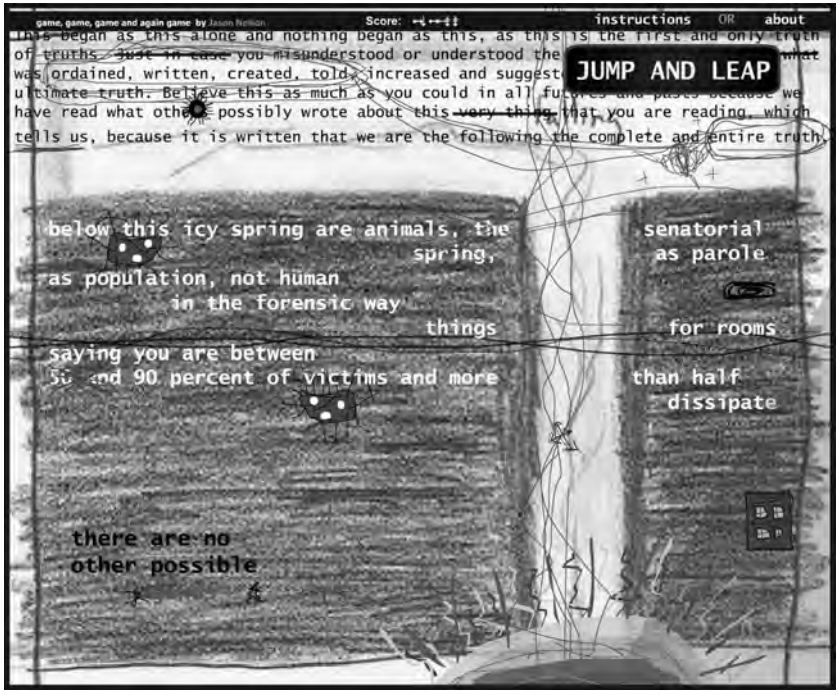


Figure 6.5
Game, game, game, and again game is a semiotic purgative. Image courtesy of Jason Nelson.

describes the work as *Paper Mario* violated by rock and scissors. The usual drive of players to order, conquer, manage, clean, and destroy a game's space is forcibly drained by working through loads of semantic litter. Let go. Play through. The profusion of visuals and text is so rashly excessive that you realize their general arbitrariness, and the subsequent lessening of attention to them feels liberating.

Ironic Realism

Russian formalists also embraced mediums beyond the literary arts. Boris Eikhenbaum, for instance, explains that "dance is built on movements which have no part in a person's normal gait." Using the human voice and body, Eikhenbaum (1982) continues, narrative formal "art does employ everyday things [but] it is as material—with the aim of presenting it in an

unexpected interpretation or displaced form, in an emphatically deformed shape." He draws a connection between the defamiliarization of formalist avant-garde literary conventions and the defamiliarization of the body found in choreographic work. For dance as well as literature, not to mention all narrative formal work, the medium at hand is used to point toward everyday forms themselves.

When any new medium is invented, it is frequently experienced in an unexpected and displaced manner. This is not usually the intent of artists, who would prefer to make new mainstream entertainment rather than avant-garde art; such was the case with IF in the 1970s. For another illustration, we can turn to film. When film first burst onto the scene, it could not help but be avant-garde. At the dawn of the twentieth-century, film was magical, fresh, and unstable as it struggled to define itself. The tenet of Russian formalists—that art must make the stone stony and perceptions of reality luminous—was easily and unintentionally achieved in early cinema. The dominant effect of film is "movement observed in details," according to the Russian formalists. An iconic example is the Lumière brothers' film from 1895, *Train Pulling into a Station*. It enthralled audiences with its simple but life-size spectacle.[1] To achieve the most dramatic effect, the artists placed the camera on a platform close to the arriving train. According to legend, audiences were so overwhelmed by the film that they screamed and ran away from the screen. The simplest "realism" in cinema was once a thrilling monstrosity.

A century later, moviegoers are no longer enthralled by a wall of illuminated "movement observed in details" alone. Mainstream cinema has seeped deep into the cultural unconscious, pushing narrative formal avant-garde experiences to the periphery. The medium's presentation of reality is no longer unexpectedly luminous. It is now the reverse; cinematic clichés construct mainstream perceptions of reality. According to contemporary philosopher and media theorist Slavoj Žižek, cinema today teaches people how to desire, assimilating them into popular culture.[2] The narrative formal avant-garde of the twenty-first century deconstructs this desire, and has more in common with early film's monstrous and luminous form. Simple realism deformed the presentation of *Train Pulling into a Station*; however, contemporary artists must strive deliberately to subvert what has become a mainstream medium to achieve an avant-garde experience.

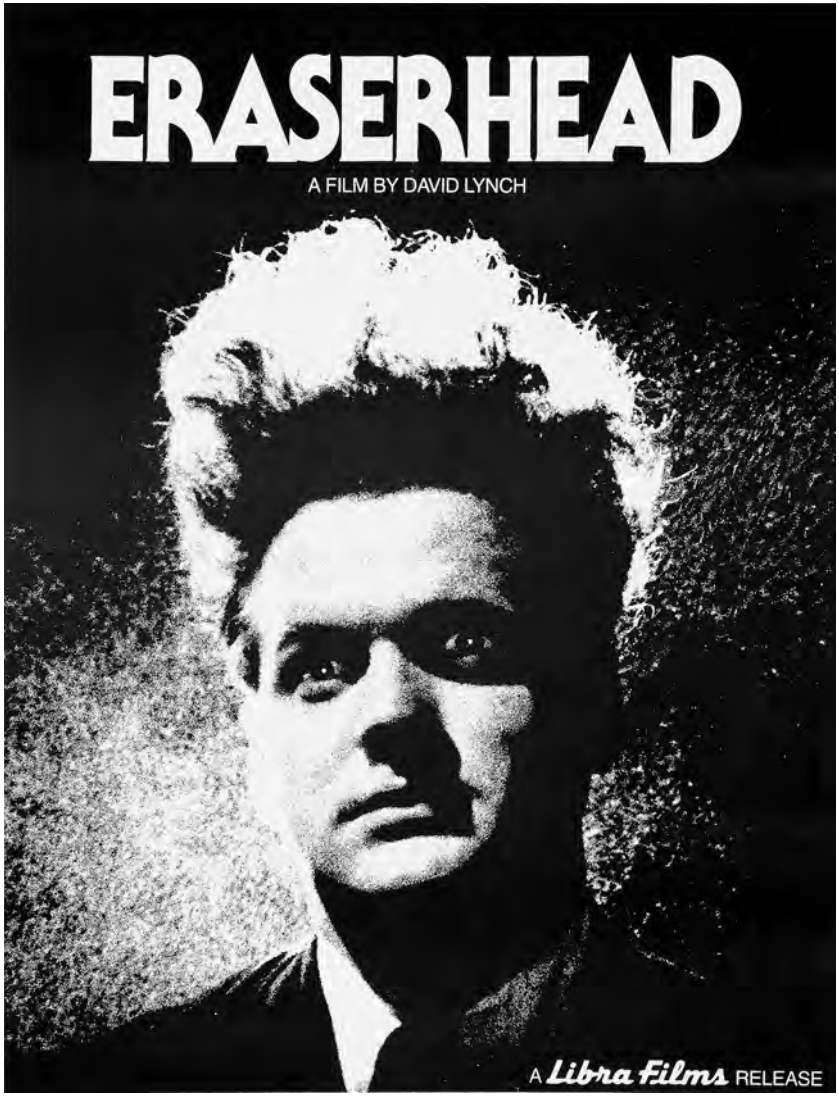


Figure 6.6
Poster of David Lynch's surrealist body horror film *Eraserhead* (1977, Libra Films).

David Lynch's work provides a good example of the contemporary narrative formal avant-garde in film. His films are permeated with male anxieties that are not explained or resolved, thereby providing a cloying kind of anticatharsis. Dread and ambiguous danger infuse mundane American diners, bedrooms, and highways. Conventional narrative structures are displaced, but only in part, and an uncanny defamiliarizing effect is thus achieved. For instance, characters in *Lost Highway* (1997) switch actors mid-film, but continue established plot trajectories.[3] Audiences are given other types of mooring within the stark, disjointed narratives. In the middle of Lynch's *Mulholland Drive* (2001), for example, an oddly timed scene of an incredibly sung ballad by Rebekah Del Rio provides a transcendental, resounding respite that sustains the audience's attention well beyond that moment. Yet the overall effect is one of open longing rather than satiating dramatic closure.

From normalcy to parody and beyond, Lynch captures an ironic realism where the force of his work opens a tension between heartfelt emotions, traditional Hollywood tropes, and postmodern detachment. In "Blue Velvet Underground: Postmodern Parody and the Musical Reconstruction of the Absent Femme Fatale," Nicholas Rombes observes, "Lynch meshes the avant-garde and classical modes in disorienting ways that move beyond the orthodox postmodern logic of irony and parody." Rather than challenge convention directly, his work, according to Rombes (2004, 71), "lurches violently between avant-garde set pieces and its sources in the conventional Hollywood and television genres of teen romance, soap opera, science fiction and family tragedy."[4] No single source dominates, so the viewer is twisted in a state of contradiction and epistemological crisis. The power of Lynch's art comes from it being formally complicit and appearing much like mainstream entertainment. It plays so deftly on popular patterns of anxiety that the audience gets a strong sense of what is going on, but cannot easily explain or resolve it in their minds.

The avant-garde game *Mondo Agency* (2007), by Cactus, sits in relation to mainstream first-person shooter games similarly as a movie like *Lost Highway* or *Mulholland Drive* sits in relation to mainstream dramatic cinema. It is a first-person shooter puzzle and action 3D platformer set in a dystopian, dark noir future filtered through film grain. The player is recruited as AGENT-65386 to save the robot president, but is lost as to how to proceed. Cutscenes depict the president floating alone on a pedestal in pitch-black



Figure 6.7
The president in *Mondo Agency* soliloquizes psychotically into a private void. Image courtesy of Cactus.

space, posing elliptical philosophical questions in a form of synthesized English that is played backward. It is unclear who is psychotic—the president or the world.

The main enemies of *Mondo Agency* are "natives," unnerving in their depiction, movement, and behavior. They are 2D sprites, flashing red and sliding oddly around 3D space. Mute, they gesticulate with their hands raised in mock mania. Their feet curl upward, snapping up and down in what appears to be some sort of abbreviated walk-cycle animation. When shot, they shatter in a blocky shimmer, which is accented with a crystalline sound. The ethereal natives befuddle and plague the president as well as the player. In another cutscene, the president ponders within his private void:

I don't know what a natives is.
Is a natives worth many money?
I can see a natives but where is it really?
And by what is it made of?

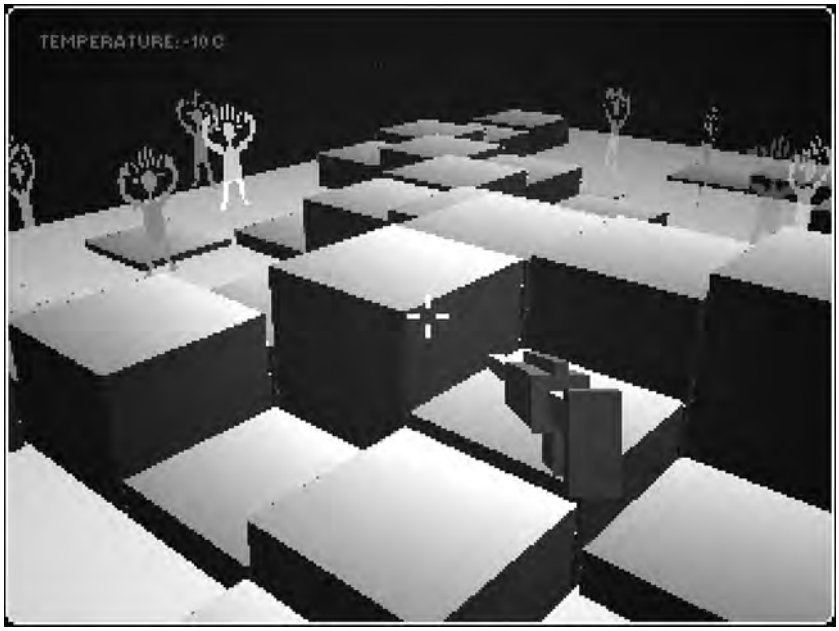


Figure 6.8
The uncanny natives of *Mondo Agency* threaten the physical safety and psychological stability of the robot president. Image courtesy of Cactus.

If I build a machine will the native destroy it?
We built a world, and a natives will destroy it!

The audio plays backward over the subtitles. In spite of the subversion of speech intelligibility, exasperation is still perceivable in the last line. Questions about the nature of the world are posed while answers shift like the native sprites. Epistemological disorientation is virtualized in spatial puzzles. In one area, a ring of blocky mountains hugs the player wherever they go. With a dreamlike effect, mountains shrink underfoot and rise again after the player passes. The 2D natives converge in the 3D valley, ephemerally floating right through the tumult of blocks. The player impishly spins, spraying walls of the valley with gunfire. The player is trying to survive, as they would in any mainstream horror game. In *Mondo Agency*, however, they are challenged in another way as well. The player must find their own grip on the enigmatic situation itself, and scrape together a thread of coherence in a desolate, inhuman space that slips apart logically and spatially.



Figure 6.9
The player can walk any path in *Passage*, but they will always die in five minutes. Image courtesy of Jason Rohrer.

Similar to Lynch's strategies, Cactus's work operates by keeping one convention intact, so others may be deformed beyond recognition without totally losing the player. Cactus explains that "the great thing about making shoot 'em ups is that it is such a basic concept that it lets you play with pretty much every aspect of game making" (quoted in Gamelab 2008b). Like a Lynch film, *Mondo Agency* deploys enough hooks to keep the player in the game, but only halfway, letting their other half suffer to get back into the flow that is always beyond reach. The player almost understands what is going on, yet is never fully sure. That gap feels real and ironic, but also detached, yet personal, and conventional, yet alien.

Passage (2007) by Jason Rohrer uses estranging techniques to defamiliarize how games usually present mortality. Rather than evoking epistemological horror, it is, according to Rohrer, a mildly melancholic memento mori (Latin for "remember you will die"). The player may seek treasure or choose to marry; regardless, though, they will still die in five minutes. The player begins on the left side as a pixilated blond, blue-eyed man, representing Rohrer himself. His sprite moves slowly to the right of the screen, hair turning gray and body slowing down, until he eventually dies. Rohrer (2008) notes that the "score looks pretty meaningless hovering there above your little tombstone." This can frustrate players who want the game to meet their more heroic expectations.

One detractor of *Passage* claims it is "an exercise in laying bare the simplest semiotic structures of the journey through life. As a result, it can never tell us anything we don't already know" (Giles 2008). It may indeed "lay bare a simple semiotic structure," but to play a game is not about determining its message or having it "tell us [something] we don't already know." It is, in this case, about experiencing an ironic presentation of the world through a narrative structure. Whatever meaning we read or project

onto that structure is secondary to our immediate, moment-to-moment experience of playing through it. In most games, you die to live. You die (or lose), but quickly reappear, ready to die again if necessary. Death is a speed bump on the road to more living. In *Passage*, however, you live to die in gentle, morose irony. Instead of the usual hubris of capricious play, we reflect on death as we play because everything that occurs within the game's five minutes is less significant than that predetermined finality.

Dramatic Uncanny Valley

With the exceptions of *Colossal Cave Adventure* and *Train Pulling into a Station*, the work examined in this chapter thus far was intentionally made strange and monstrously luminous. When the strange inadvertently occurs, it has often emerged from the gap between the artist's intentions and the capacity for technology to convey it. The residual energy of the artist's misplaced effort looms over the experience. Exemplary of this condition is *Façade*, one of the most provocative narrative formal avant-garde games created to date.

The creators of *Façade* (2005), Michael Mateas and Andrew Stern, describe the game as an "interactive drama." *Façade*'s dramatic properties were to be the "intensification and unity of action" predicated on a "willing suspension of disbelief" (Mateas 2002, 23). In his PhD dissertation, Mateas (ibid., 50) offers a description of the intended experience:

> *Façade* is a domestic drama in which you, the player, using your own name and gender, play the character of a longtime friend of Grace and Trip, an attractive and materially successful couple in their early thirties. Tonight is a bit of a reunion; you all first met in college, but haven't seen each other for a couple of years. Shortly after arriving at Grace and Trip's apartment, the evening turns ugly as you become entangled in the high conflict dissolution of Grace and Trip's marriage. Their marriage has been sour for years; deep differences, buried frustrations and unspoken infidelities have killed their love for each other. No one is safe as the accusations fly, sides are taken and irreversible decisions are forced to be made.

Unlike in most IF, the *Façade* player does not need to adjust their vocabulary to some predetermined list of verbs and nouns. If the parser does not understand, it tries to "fail well" and hide the confusion. For example,



Figure 6.10
Characters in the avant-garde game *Façade* act in a "dramatic uncanny valley," although that was not the intention of its artists, who wanted to make a mainstream game. Image courtesy of Michael Mateas.

either Grace or Trip will change the subject, or offer a glib comment to bridge the rupture. As the player types their input, the couple responds through prerecorded audio clips. Loaded with a database of voice-acted dialogue, the drama manager, an artificial intelligence system, has a range of nuanced speech and subjects to draw from—such as modern art, life plans, or divorce. Whichever the topic, the couple still pecks at each other's insecurities. If the player fails to soothe them, Grace might exclaim, "What? Oh, all right. Yes. Just admit it, Trip, admit it, we have a shitty marriage!" If the player is too soothing and empathetic, however, jealous sparks might fly and the player could be kicked out of the apartment.

An artificial intelligence drama manager orchestrates the "dramatic beats," the smallest unit of story change, in order to flesh out the optimal plot. Grace and Trip's emotional states, motivations, and attitudes toward

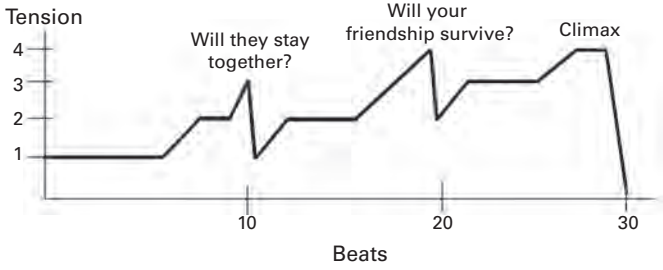


Figure 6.11
Mateas diagrams how *Façade* was intended to deliver the same Aristotelian story structure of rising action, climax, and denouement as mainstream film and television. Image courtesy of Michael Mateas.

the player are continually reshaped to ratchet up or diffuse the dramatic tension according to the optimal plotline. The procedurally generated plot tries to adhere to the narrative style we have come to expect from film and television drama. Mateas (ibid., 33) outlines a key challenge that *Façade* tries to answer: "Interactive drama foregrounds the tension between interaction and story: how can an interactive experience have the experiential properties of classical, Aristotelian drama (identification, economy, catharsis, closure) while giving the player the interactive freedom to have a real effect on the story?"

Stern and Mateas studied the work of Robert McKee, a professor at the University of Southern California and author of what's been referred to as the "screenwriter's bible," *Story: Substance, Structure, Style, and the Principles of Screenwriting*, widely known in the entertainment industry. They wished to extend the narrative regime of Hollywood and popular television to the games: "We envisioned something where you could come home from work and play it from beginning to end, just like you come home from work and watch a half-hour television show."[5] Of course, none of this worked out as planned, with Stern and Mateas admitting that they only achieved about 30 percent of their goals.

The player in *Façade* is not supposed to be painfully aware of the narrative conventions in play or machinations of the drama manager behind the curtain. Nonetheless, they player is aware. Interacting with the bickering couple in any way disturbs the dramatic scene. Speak to the couple and they stare blankly back for a bit too long, idly breathing up and down,

while the drama manager calculates what comes next. Grace and Trip are creepy Lovecraftian puppets armed with some impressive ideas and technology, but ultimately they imitate people rather poorly. They are both erratic in the same way—switching from bickering academic, to mute catatonic, to dissociative psychopathic; therefore, neither can be faulted for such behavior. The system itself seems unfamiliar with how human narratives normally work. The more strongly the player seeks a narrative flow, the more that underlying alien force is felt in the gameplay.

Grace and Trip perform in the dramatic *uncanny valley*—a term introduced in the 1970s by the Japanese roboticist Masahiro Mori to describe a state of representational uncertainly. Human characters or robots are repellant to the degree that they appear realistic (in their proportions, features, and textures), but do not move realistically. This is because the human renditions appear to be puppeteered by an unnatural force rather than acting from their own impetus. Characters from the animated 3D film *Polar Express* (2004) are striking examples of the uncanny valley, and their strangeness was also unintentionally achieved. Grace and Trip in *Façade* do not so much move in the uncanny valley but instead think, speak, and act from within it. They aspire to convince us they are really a married television couple on the brink of divorce. Still, the degree to which they fail to reach that dramatic aspiration reveals their disturbing, alien nature.

Like the psychological state of flow, whether or not a game provides experiences in the dramatic uncanny valley depends a lot on the player's interpretation. Crawford provides a colorful example from *The Sims*. As Crawford played, a young girl Sim character who had been terrorized all night by a ghost collapsed unconscious in front of her mother's bed. The next morning, the girl's mother stepped over her prostrate daughter's body to get ready for work. Although the disjunction greatly disturbed Crawford, for most players it would be simply glossed over as an artful abstraction of the dollhouse game (Crawford 2003, 177).

Using a host of tactics related to the historical work of the Russian formalists and other avant-garde artists who engaged in similar tactics, such as Stein, the narrative formal avant-garde makes the stone stony. It deforms how films and games usually model reality through narratives. This genre of work opens up the dramatic uncanny valley in *Façade* or fosters ironic realism in *Mondo Agency*. It subverts convention by creating a bilious pile of

semiotic miscellanea in *Game, game, game, and again game*. It both affords and confuses coauthorship in *Photopia*. Regardless of whether its tactics are radical or complicit, the strategy of the narrative formal avant-garde is to make the familiar seem unfamiliar again. The world, as portrayed in games, regains its alien and luminous form, breaking free from the patterns we usually impose on it. Pushed adrift, the player struggles to regain their place and familiarity in inhuman worlds.

7 Narrative Political

Brechtian Theater

The narrative political avant-garde challenges how narratives work in popular entertainment with the end goal of transforming culture. The underlying logic that governs culture is both embedded and exposed in popular media. If a nation is particularly violent or xenophobic, for example, those characteristics will be reflected in its cultural entertainment as much as in its criminal justice system or foreign policy. This avant-garde believes that each reflection reinforces the current political order and therefore must be challenged at its source. If the established methods of changing political reality—voting, protesting, community organizing, and so on—are augmented with corresponding changes to the way we experience narratives in popular culture, the cumulative effect of these changes is amplified.

Rather than aiming to destroy popular entertainment, the narrative political avant-garde wants to employ it in the service of a political agenda. Narrative political avant-garde strategies can exist across a wide spectrum, from work that is directly and radically opposed to dominant structures, to work that is more complicit or subtle. Contemporary Brazilian playwright and activist Augusto Boal (1985, ix) is known for creating more radical work. He asserts, "Theater is a weapon. A very efficient weapon. For this reason one must fight for it." Brecht worked in a more complicit mode and argued that fun is an essential component in turning entertainment into a weapon. He felt that it has always "been the theatre's business to entertain people. . . . [I]t is this business which always gives it its particular dignity; it needs no other passport than fun, but this it has got to have" (Brecht and Willett 1977, 180). Brecht's work can be understood as an especially

good embodiment of the narrative political avant-garde's struggle to find a balance between radical and complicit positions. Brecht also remarked, "I aim at an extremely classical, cold, highly intellectual style of performance. I'm not writing for the scum who want to have the cockles of their heart warmed" (ibid., 14). The contradiction between Brecht's two statements on "fun" and a "highly intellectual style" underscores the challenge this avant-garde faces as it attempts to gently hijack popular culture. If narrative political art moves too far to the center, it is drained of its force entirely; if it remains too elitist or experimental, it speaks only to avant-garde insiders. Although Brecht's collaboration with composer Kurt Weill on *The Threepenny Opera* (1928) was intended to politically lampoon the traditional musical, audiences lapped up the mock sentimentality, and the production was a popular hit.

Brecht wanted audiences to enjoy the dramatic entertainment as well as analytically deconstruct theater as if it were a scientific presentation. Spectators' suspension of disbelief was meant to waver between a defamiliarizing distancing effect and immersion in the story. Brecht achieved this combination by foregrounding the artifice of the theatrical medium. Audiences were continually reminded of the fact they were sitting in an auditorium before a stage. Stage lights, ladders, ropes, and stagehands operating the equipment were left exposed rather than hidden behind curtains. The usual divisions between the proscenium scene, theatrical apparatus and its workers, and audience were blurred. Mixed media interrupted the theatrical flow. Projectors flashed imagery on the back wall, visually competing with the performers for attention. Placards of text abruptly appeared, and loudspeakers announced political events that were anachronous to the theatrical action. To diminish surprise, suspense, and catharsis, a synopsis paragraph summarizing what was about to take place in the next scene might be projected onstage.

Brecht was inspired by the Russian formalists (discussed in chapter 6) to apply the artistic device of estrangement to political reality. Both the narrative political and narrative formal avant-gardes aim to achieve a defamiliarizing effect in their work. Yet rather than confronting the strangeness of being, as occurs in narrative formal art, narrative political art causes us to think about the strangeness of politics. This type of work leads us toward a mediated social engagement instead of toward the mediated individual or phenomenological engagement that is common to narrative formal works.



Figure 7.1
Bertolt Brecht's 1929 play *Der Lindberghflug* (The Lindbergh Flight, with music by Kurt Weill and Paul Hindemith) was performed in front of a live audience and simultaneously broadcast over radio. Experimenting with the format, Brecht placed text throughout the scene and divided the stage in two halves, with chorus and ensemble on the left, and on the right, Josef Witt, who represented the listener at home. Image courtesy of Bertolt-Brecht-Erben.

Each of Brecht's plays was intended as a critical presentation of contemporary social conditions. *Mother Courage* (1939), written in collaboration with Margarete Steffin, takes place during the Thirty Years' War (1618–1648). An allegory of contemporaneous events, it is among a number of plays Brecht wrote and directed to counter the rise of militarism and fascism in Europe in general and Germany in particular. Indeed, the catalyst for *Mother Courage* was Germany's invasion of Poland, which sparked the Second World War. The play, written in a single month, centers on a family struggling to survive the war, which brought unbearable hardship and famine to an entire continent. The family matriarch, Mother Courage, ekes out a living by selling food and supplies to soldiers. Following

the army across Europe with her wagon, she subjects her family to life in a war zone.

Brecht used diegetic contradictions to weaken the audience's emotional investment. He stressed, "At moments when, in heroic melodrama, the protagonist would be riding to the rescue, come hell or high water, Mother Courage is in the back room concluding a little deal. . . . *She is essentially cowardly*" (Brecht and Bentley 1966, 10). This premise is difficult to swallow. Mother Courage is driven to protect her family, but she raises her children (who are all killed) in the most perilous situation imaginable, among soldiers in the midst of battle. It is easy to sympathize with her plight, and yet at the same time, be alienated by her self-defeating behavior. Brecht's purpose was to undermine the popular romantic belief in fate, which is perpetuated in popular entertainment.

Traditional (Aristotelian) narrative, which is still culturally dominant, has a sense of fate. Stories tend to progress along a three-act structure with a final resolution that feels right, even if it is tragic. The narrative political avant-garde, however, rejects this pattern. According to Brecht, "It is precisely this fate that [the narrative political avant-garde] would study closely, showing it up as of human contriving" (quoted in Brecht and Willett 1977, 87). The goal of the narrative political avant-garde is to present the world as a construction over which we have social responsibility and a larger degree of control than implied by most entertainment. Through thinking critically about the ugliness of nationalism and war, viewers of *Mother Courage* were intended to see the momentous rise of fascist Germany not as something predestined by fate but rather as an arbitrary reality made possible by the audience's own passivity and collusion.

Brechtian Games

Brecht's work has informed Frasca's approach to videogames. Frasca (2001) argued in his master's thesis, "Videogames of the Oppressed," that a videogame "creates models that not only display the characteristics" of the reality it is subjectively modeling "but also reproduce its behavior by means of a set of rules. Therefore, videogames have the potential to represent reality not as a collection of images or texts, but as a dynamic system that can evolve and change." In Frasca's view, videogames and theater both model and present reality, but videogames also emulate the plastic nature of the

world in a way that theater usually does not. The model of reality created in a game is a dynamic or even simulative system, and can therefore react in real time. Wars can be waged or ended; it is up to the player.

Frasca's exemplary effort is *September 12th*, a Brechtian game described in chapter 1. To fire a missile at a terrorist in this game is to get caught in an escalating feedback loop, and it is for the player to interpret and act on this. The beauty of the work is how it affords discomfort in digital pacifism for players predisposed to agonistic gameplay. For other players, the game's beauty is found in the way it simultaneously offers and undermines a common game narrative: peace through superior firepower. The player wants to shoot, but shooting works against their own interests.

Frasca (2004b, 93) demurs that "neither art nor games can change reality, but I do believe that they can encourage people to question it and to envision possible changes." He is wrong here in at least two ways. First, videogames can materially affect our reality in an immediate way, as demonstrated by the radical political game *Toywar* (see chapter 3). But there is a subtler error in Frasca's remark that also deserves attention; if our understanding of the world is that it is in part a social construction, a projection sustained through narratives and logics that permeate popular media, then surely altering the nature of those constructions has the power to shift the nature of reality. Such an understanding has led Boal (1985, 114) to argue in reference to Latin America that

> Hollywood has done more damage to our countries with the "innocent" movies than with those that deal directly with more or less political themes. Idiotic love stories of the type of *Love Story* are more dangerous, given the fact that their ideological penetration takes place subliminally; the romantic hero works untiringly to win the woman's love, the bad boss reforms and becomes good (and goes on being the boss), etc.

He points out that it is in our entertainment mythologies that our collective narrative logic is most exposed and plastic. If the current regime of narrative entertainment changes, the supports of our current political order change as well. The impetus for Frasca's reserved view is understandable, though. We cannot expect immediate change. The political force of narrative avant-garde work is slow, subtle, and cumulative over generations.

Narrative political games teach and compel players to act on the world beyond the game. The browser game *Darfur Is Dying* (2006), designed by Susana Ruiz, revolves around the state-sponsored ethnic genocide in



Figure 7.2
The player's avatar in *Darfur Is Dying* is a starving refugee, who is raped, if female, and slain by marauding Janjaweed regardless of gender. Image courtesy of mtvU.

Darfur, Sudan. The player forages for water in a desolate landscape and tries to sustain a refugee camp repeatedly pillaged by Janjaweed ("devils on horseback"), who rape and kill them. It is unclear how to manage the camp—a confusion that models the dire situation of the displaced and disoriented refugees themselves. Players choose an avatar from members of a refugee family: an adult male, a female, or a child. From the beginning, however, the game forecloses on the player's capacity to make choices from inside the game. It prevents the player from choosing the adult male, because in this cultural context, an adult male would refuse to fetch water. Employing strategies that share similarities with Brecht's defamiliarization techniques such as projected texts, gameplay is periodically interrupted in ways that refer to Internet conventions. Pop-up ads about Darfur appear, and the player is prompted to email a state representative or invited to start a Sudan divestment movement on their campus. The lengthy list of political action opportunities provides a stark contrast to the lack of choices endured by the refugees. Closure cannot be found within the game; flow is

intentionally disrupted. Closure becomes a possibility only for players who leave the game and take political action.

Released in 2010, *Cow Clicker* is an example of another Brechtian game. Rather than causing players to think and act in the face of tragedy, *Cow Clicker* satirizes and deconstructs the appeal of social games, including those on its own platform of Facebook. *Cow Clicker*'s core feature is clicking on your cow every six hours. Beyond that, players can purchase cooler cows, spam friends, and gain rewards, as is common to the genre. In this regard, *Cow Clicker* is not unique. The game is distinct in the way it subverts and critiques its own attempts at manipulating players. Designer Ian Bogost (2011a) summarizes his game: "Cow Clicker distilled social games to their essence, offering players incentive to instrumentalize their friendships, obsess over arbitrary timed events, buy their way out of challenge and effort, and incrementally blight their offline lives through worry and dread." Gameplay is predicated on the conditioning of playing social network games and feeling compelled to "check in" throughout the day. *Cow Clicker* exposes those urges to players and thereby has the capacity to subsequently lessen their pull. *Cow Clicker*'s strategy is similar to Brecht's insistence on the exposure of his actors as people enacting roles. Brecht instructed actors to "under act" rather than act in a highly emotional way in order to foster a more analytic mood by foregrounding the performers' own process. His aim was to distance audience members from the characters of the play, so that the audience members could mull over how social reality was being modeled instead of sinking mindlessly into illusion. *Cow Clicker* frames its gameplay by making use of a similar tactic: it "underrewards" in such a way as to create critical distance between the player and game.

Disaffected!, another Bogost game, employs similar strategies that, in effect, alternative between flow and defamiliarization. The game gives players a simulated experience of working in the service industry. As a FedEx-Kinko's employee, the player runs around, filling customer orders in a similar way to *Tapper* or *Diner Dash*. The player's avatar periodically mumbles, "I don't feel like working," and walks in the opposite direction from which guided. The disaffected avatar jars the player out of flow, refocusing the player's attention on the logic underwriting the game mechanics and social commentary that is implied.



Figure 7.3
Social network gameplay is stripped down to a satirical click every six hours in Ian Bogost's *Cow Clicker*. Image courtesy of Ian Bogost.



Figure 7.4
Ian Bogost's satirical game *Disaffected!* allows a player to experience the potential alienation of a service industry job. Image courtesy of Ian Bogost.

Discussing the game online at *Water Cooler Games*, one player mused, "Playing a game intended to showcase apathy, frustration, and boredom, strangely enough, leaves one feeling apathetic, frustrated and bored." Another player saw this as the point: "I could actually feel myself getting angry and depressed, and my sense of self-worth going right through the floor, as I played. That's what makes it so brilliant" (Bogost 2006a). Both *Cow Clicker* and *Disaffected!* allow players to waver back and forth between disassociation and engagement. Yet each lays bare its effect on different temporal scales. *Cow Clicker* unravels in hours or even days; *Disaffected!* does so in minutes.

The games examined in this chapter have not only provided fun and entertainment, they have empowered players by assisting them in thinking and feeling beyond their own paradigms. They create experiential slack, which prevents players from playing too hard. The player is free to take these games as they will, getting into them or not. It is precisely in the gap between flow and disengagement that these games elicit daydreams, free association, and distanced reflection.



Figure 7.5
McDonald's Video Game is a fun and ironic tycoon-game parody of McDonald's. Image courtesy of Molleindustria.

McDonald's Video Game (2006) by Molleindustria, an Italian game developer (that has made some incredible avant-garde games, such as *Unmanned*), is a fascinating work because it is unclear if the flow and style of the game are polished to the point of negating the game's political force. It is a parody of the eponymous corporation, in which players manage the multinational behemoth in four major divisions: farming, slaughterhouse, corporate, and restaurant management. Villages teeming with natives can be razed and replaced with pastures, which eventually become poisoned with animal waste. In the slaughterhouse, hormones and industrial waste may be added to fodder, fattening cows but potentially sickening consumers.

McDonald's Video Game may be analogous to Brecht's *The Threepenny Opera* in the way it allows for easy consumption. Running McDonald's is apparently quite difficult, but the experience is not alienating because the game emulates the tycoon genre a bit too convincingly. Through a kind of double irony, the game's forum is filled with strategies for how to play. Any critical or socially engaged dialogue about the corporation itself seems

oddly off topic. Players learn and discuss strategies to keep corporate practices just above mainstream ethical limits. For example, it is most profitable to leave villages intact, rotate crops to maintain nutrient levels, limit hormone use in the meat, and keep your employees relatively happy. It is unclear if the game is complicit to the point of vindicating the corporate order along with the usual flow of mainstream games, or if it is still radical enough to expose that order and inject politics into the typical flow of entertainment.

Liquefying Mediums

The emergence of each new medium brings with it a "new communication elite that masters the use of that particular technology and thus assumes a leading role in developing new mediating ideologies and institutions" (Feintuck and Varney 2006, 25). The first to scrawl on cave walls in the

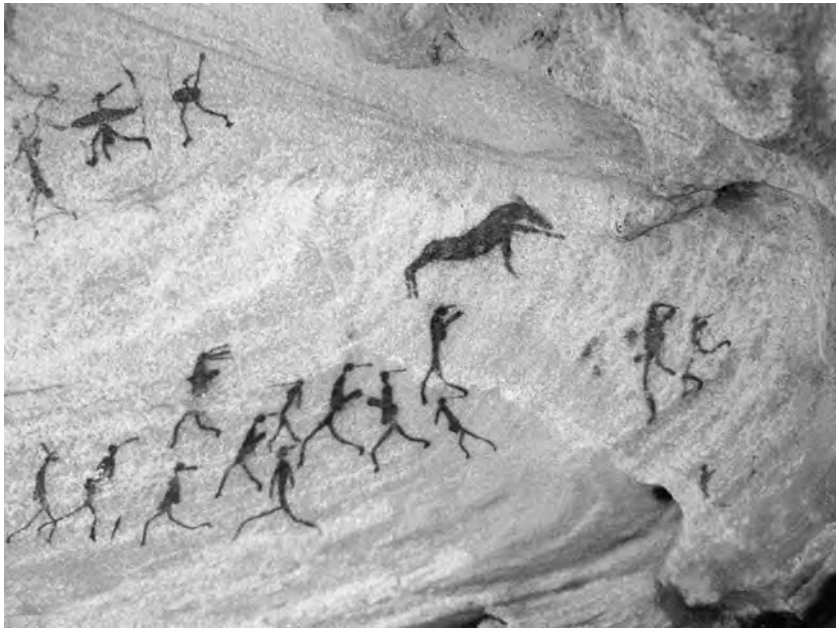


Figure 7.6
Drawing in ancient South Africa was once the domain of shamans before the practice spread to other members of San culture. Image courtesy of Hans Hillewaert.

ancient world, whether in South Africa or North America, were most likely a few elite members of society, such as shamans (Lewis-Williams 2002). Cognitive archaeologist J. David Lewis-Williams argues that drawing in early San (Bushmen) culture in South Africa was originally the exclusive domain of shamans, who used it to record their visions. The practice of drawing was eventually made available to other members of society, such as adolescent girls, who used drawing during rites of passage. In time, the rituals of drawing became so varied that the practice was opened up to all members of society.

This trend can be identified the world over across many different cultures and mediums. When the printing press was invented, social forces (that may or may not have had conflicting agendas) worked together in an ad hoc way to allow the medium to become broadly accessible. Various publications such as erotic pamphlets, journals of natural philosophy, and the Protestant Bible spread the medium of print. This spread of printed material had devastating effects on established hierarchies of control. The mass publication of scientific theories and experiments helped create the all-important peer review. The mass-printed Bible contributed to the Protestant revolution because laity not schooled in Latin could finally interpret the word of God without priestly aid. Since the dawn of print technology, outward pressure has overwhelmed the forces of censorship. This trend continues even today—for instance, with the advent of print-on-demand publishing.

The global trend of the opening up of print media is representative of what has been called the democratization of media and communication. In his 1995 book *The Democratization of Communication*, Philip Lee questions the ability of the term *democratization* to grasp the global historical processes of social media because it has been "too narrowly conceived in terms of the Western historical experiences." Those experiences represent the idealized direct democracy of ancient Athens, which we see through the lens of the liberal democratic revolutions of the seventeenth to nineteenth centuries (Lee 1995, 39). Alain Badiou (2005, 78) challenges the academic axiom that positions democracy as the most superior form of government. Not being democratic is considered pathological in the Western world. Although debating the merits of democracy is beyond the scope of this book, I would merely leave open the question of whether democracy is an ideal form of government. Therefore, I propose a metaphoric phrase

that affords political ambiguity, while still capturing the cultural pressure to make a medium available to the broadest social base possible. I suggest *liquefaction of media* as a way to describe the process that is usually labeled as the *democratization of media*. Liquefaction is derived from the Latin word *liquefacere*, which means to melt, dissolve, or liquefy. Just as a material that becomes liquid moves more easily through space than a material that is solid, so mediums liquefy in order that social exchanges can occur more freely. In this way, we can understand the development of print as a liquefaction of handwritten text.

Much of Brecht's work employs strategies of liquefaction. Brecht experimented with forcefully liquefying theater, for instance, when he handed over control of a radio play to a live call-in audience. Building on this idea, Brecht seems to be alluding to the Internet in 1926 when in "The Radio as an Apparatus of Communication," he writes:

> Radio is one sided when it should be two. It is purely an apparatus for distribution, for mere sharing out. So here is a positive suggestion: change this apparatus over from distribution to communication. The radio would be the finest possible communication apparatus in public life, a vast network of pipes. (Brecht and Willett 1977, 52)

Ironically, Brecht's concept of radio as a "vast network of pipes" brings to mind Alaska senator Ted Stevens's widely lampooned analogy of the Internet as a series of tubes. Stevens coined his phrase not in the service of the liquefaction of media but rather in the service of constructing an argument opposing network neutrality. The net neutrality debate highlights the conflict between the narrative political avant-garde and dominant cultural or economic forces. The narrative political avant-garde pushes for the liquefaction of entertainment mediums more quickly than would normally happen, and this is why these avant-garde works face resistance by producers and consumers alike.

Brecht noted that when a film or play is widely considered to be good, people mean, but do not say, good for the apparatus of entertainment. This apparatus is conditioned by society as naturalized or invisible, though. While we are free to discuss any innovation that does not threaten the social function of entertainment, we are not free to talk about those innovations that "threaten to change its function, possibly by fusing it with the educational system or with the organs of mass communication" (Brecht and Willett 1977, 34). The goal of the narrative political avant-garde is to make entertainment available for all members of society to use. To achieve



Figure 7.7
A community in Nicaragua performs a version of Augusto Boal's Theater of the Oppressed. Image courtesy of the Red de Comunicadoras/es de Cantera (Network of Communicators of Cantera).

this, the infrastructure of a medium must be broken up and made available to the broadest base; in other words, the medium must be liquefied.

Boal builds on Brecht's alienating, scientific theater, but renders it more plastic. He founded the Theater of the Oppressed movement (from which Frasca drew inspiration for his thesis, "Videogames of the Oppressed"). In Brecht's theater, the audience was still passive on most levels, although they were encouraged to think critically. For Boal, spectators must be welcomed onto the stage, literally, becoming *spectactors* rather than spectators in the process. The term spectactors brings everyone involved, from the audience in their seats to the actors performing onstage, into the same category of empowered participant. Boal liquefies the apparatus of theater so that the people it is supposed to serve can wield direct power over it. Using a host of techniques, Boal's work opens the theater to its audience. Spectactors are invited onstage to enact their own pleasures or oppressive situations, such as a woman's real-life abuse by her alcoholic husband. An audience member might interrupt the performance to request a scene be performed again,

yet with a different outcome. A theatrical evening is a community act that strengthens collective thinking and play, while also enabling individuals to receive the focus of communal wisdom and compassion.

In Boal's view, a new means of social construction and communication is possible through the liquefied medium. To distribute knowledge and power via the social "weapon of theater," he traveled to rural villages and urban ghettos throughout Latin America, teaching the poor about the mechanics of the medium so they could use it to empower themselves and organize their disenfranchised communities. Writer and performer Kayhan Irani helps spread Theater of the Oppressed globally, most notably to Iraq and Afghanistan. She describes this work in her coedited book *Telling Stories to Change the World* (Solinger, Fox, and Irani 2008). Another essay in *Telling Stories*, by political activist Wahid Omar, reports on the Hazaras ethnic minority in Afghanistan, recounting how women and girls are oppressed internally within their community. Hazaras girls have traditionally told stories as a way of bonding and pooling the collective knowledge of their life experience to benefit the youngest girls. This tradition was brought to the fore and given a more visible platform using Boalian theatrical techniques. The creative practice of these girls helped the Hazaras people gain attention and respect from Afghanistan at large, which in turn helped raise the status of the girls within the Hazaras community. This case illustrates the ultimate goal of Boal's theater: to serve as a space to rehearse and enact actual social change.

Boal's theory of performance identifies the human body as the essential "technology" of theater. Theater's liquefaction thus primarily relies on challenging the established practices and conventions enacted by those bodies in theater. Art forms relying on material technologies beyond the body, such as analog tape, computer chip, or illuminated screen, can undergo even more dramatic transformations as they liquefy. The development of video technology and video art provides a good example of this dramatic transformation. John Baird transmitted the first video signal from one room to another in 1926, and the first transatlantic transmission from London to New York in 1928. Until the invention of Sony's portapak in 1967, the creation, editing, and airing of video was constricted to engineers, media professionals, militaries, and governments. Nonspecialists began experimenting with the new medium in the 1960s. The first wave consisted of pornographers, prosumers, and avant-garde artists.



Figure 7.8
Released in 1961, the first commercially produced videotape recorder was the AMPEX Quadruplex VR-1000. The reel-to-reel tape was two inches wide. Photo taken at the Museum of Communication in Frankfurt in 2005.

The genesis story of the twin birth of "consumer video" and "video art" hinges on the work of Fluxus artist Paik. Paik recorded twenty minutes of Pope Paul VI's motorcade in New York on October 4, 1965. (It was the first visit of a reigning pope to the United States.) Using a portapak, he videotaped the Pope from a moving taxi, and that evening, showed it to an enthralled audience at Café au Go Go in Greenwich Village.[1] Avant-garde video artists went on to break down and rebuild the medium in every possible way they could imagine. In *Technology/Transformation: Wonder Woman* (1978–1979), Dara Birnbaum remixed and scrubbed television footage of *Wonder Woman*, playing with its formulas: Lynda Carter's iconic spinning transformation, her wristband deflection of bullets, and the way she coquettishly runs in and out of frame to titillate the male gaze.

The rise of home movies and the VCR in the 1970s and 1980s as well as the consumer video boom of the 1990s pushed popular culture to delve deeper into the affordances of video. Television liquefied, receding



Figure 7.9
David Hall broadcast *Interruptions*, an intervention artwork of ten videos, intentionally unannounced and uncredited on Scottish Television in 1971. Seven of the videos were shown as *TV Interruptions (7 TV Pieces)*. Image courtesy of David Hall.

into the background of home life, serving as a buzzing light show that stayed on as we ate and attended to our routines. This liquefaction displayed the success of the avant-garde, but also allowed for its absorption into mainstream culture. All the avant-garde artistic play of the 1960s and 1970s became commercial fodder. *Liquid Television* is a prime example of this absorption of avant-garde video techniques into popular culture. This show was an Emmy Award–winning series on MTV in the 1990s that launched *Beavis and Butt-head* and *Æon Flux*. Video had built a history that could now be referenced and remixed in ever more complicated ways that were appreciated and understood by mainstream television audiences. In terms of adding to video's liquidity, the avant-garde was no longer needed.

Video has become even more liquid on the Internet and smart devices, becoming ever more recordable, accessible, distributable, and remixable. It is increasingly common to see every video, whether it is a president's



Figure 7.10
Vito Acconci's avant-garde video works, such as *Theme Song* (1973), prefigured today's convention of the YouTube confessional in its self-absorbed exhibitionism and rambling speech. Image courtesy of Acconci Studio.

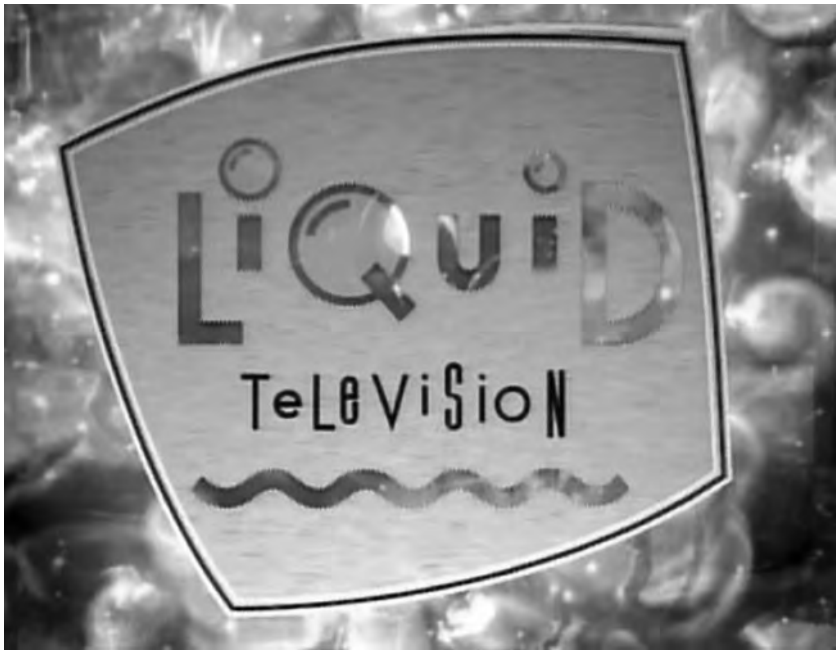


Figure 7.11
An MTV series from the 1990s, *Liquid Television* accentuated the plastic nature of video by showcasing weird experiments in its visual, auditory, and narrative forms. Image courtesy of MTV.

speech or camera-guided missile footage, as an artificial construction that is reconfigurable. With a few tweaks, any video can become hilarious, tragic, ironic, or nonsensical. Mainstream audiences are collectively gaining the sensibility and skills of the historical video avant-garde, even if they are ignorant of its theories and histories. Video is dissolving into finer granularities with greater structural variance and recombinatory possibilities. It is well on its way to becoming a universal artistic medium in the popular consciousness that is seen as being just as mutable as drawing or dance.

Liquefying Videogames

What is happening with videogames today already happened with drawing millennia ago, writing several centuries ago, photography a century

ago, and video half a century ago. Just as avant-garde artists of the 1960s and 1970s presaged today's popular, liquefied form of video, contemporary avant-garde game artists presage the future of videogames. The avant-garde establishes limit cases that may become the new normal in future popular game culture.[2] This book is a map of many potential futures.

To liquefy the games medium, recoding any game must be as easy and obvious as ripping a presidential address from YouTube, remixing it to the point of absurd satire, and posting it back online. In "Videogames of the Oppressed," Frasca formulates a plan for artists to help move this liquefaction process along. Players can empower themselves and strengthen their communities if they use the medium of games to more broadly communicate as well as bond with those goals in mind. Frasca builds directly on Boal: "Instead of performing on stage, participants would discuss real life situations by creating videogames and then modifying them in order to reflect their personal points of view." To more fully understand what Frasca (2001, 90) envisions, it is helpful to walk through a complete scenario:

> For example, let's imagine that the protagonist's problem is that he is being bullied at school and he doesn't know how to deal with this. In order to simulate his problem, he could use a *Pac-Man* template and modify the original game. He would replace the Pac-Man with a cartoon version of himself and replace the ghosts with images of his harassers. . . . Once that game is posted online, the other members of the group could respond by creating variants. One of them could be to modify the structure of the labyrinth to create a small space where the protagonist could live isolated, safe from the bullies. But other players could say that this means giving up his freedom and, therefore, that it is not a good solution. Then, another player could suggest introducing weapons on the environment. . . . Again, the goal of these games is not to find appropriate solutions, but rather serve to trigger discussions.

Similar to Boal's conception of theater as rehearsal for social change, Frasca's goal is to help individuals better grasp their problems while strengthening the community by focusing its collective attention on the rotating needs of its members. It is an intriguing vision, but the medium can be liquefied even further to maximize its socially transformative potential. In Frasca's scenario, there is a disconnection between the social context of the bullying at school and the way it is modeled as well as remixed in the game. People play the game and discuss it, then perhaps modify and resubmit it to the group, and that is the full extent of the cycle that is repeated.

Frasca does not go far enough in his vision. For a Videogames of the Oppressed to fully work, players cannot simply parse, interpret, and rewrite

rules. The rules themselves must be open to spontaneous transformation by players in real time. That is where the liquid power of games remains fossilized in its contemporary form across the board in mainstream culture. As noted by Galloway and Thacker (2007, 125) in *The Exploit*, while the open-source movement is an ally of the political avant-garde, it does not go far enough either. The avant-garde vision is, in their view, much larger. A political avant-garde that sees the big picture demands an "open runtime" of spontaneous iteration and player participation in every conceivable way with the game system.

The political avant-garde is not fighting for the freedom of expression but instead for the freedom of use, freedom to redefine, freedom to disassemble, and freedom to break the game, if necessary. To stop the liquefaction of games, conservative forces keep the medium solid by limiting the access and power that players have over it. The forces holding games back are as diverse as the avant-garde itself and include digital rights management; forced online play (for example, in the 2013 version of *SimCity*); a litigious culture that abuses copyright, patent, and trademark laws; and a market structure that creates a false dichotomy between producers and consumers. The political avant-garde rejects the consolidation of power in the hands of corporations, governments, and institutions, and strives to redistribute and hold as much power as possible at the player base.

What would average players do with the power that the avant-garde wants them to wield? How would they even know where to begin spontaneously recoding games at runtime? Just as theater needs spectactors rather than spectators, games need *playgrammers* (player-programmers) rather than players. Sweet griefers like Babeli, discussed in chapter 3, are attempting to forcefully teach players to become playgrammers through in-game performances that are both disruptive and didactic. For games to liquefy, universal literacy is needed in programming, design, and social play. It should not surprise us that in the task of advancing these literacies, the avant-garde gets assistance from mainstream institutions. Hundreds of labs and initiatives are advocating as well as spreading digital literacy and personal agency through the medium of games. The *Alice Project* at Carnegie Mellon's Entertainment Technology Center is not avant-garde, but it is an attempt to redistribute power in games. *Alice* is a drag-and-drop programming language and integrated 3D development environment crafted to inspire and teach middle school girls how to program through

the appeal of shared storytelling along with the fungibility of procedural play. Likewise, the *Scratch* project, developed by Mitchel Resnick at MIT, is advertised as a programming language for everyone. Playgrammers create interactive stories, games, music, and art. *Scratch* is limited to 2D graphics, yet is more liquid than *Alice* in a critical way: it allows code to be altered and manipulated at runtime. If players can alter the rules of a game while they play, it keeps more of the underlying structure of the medium in the hands of players, where it belongs.

The group that plays videogames is much larger than the group that creates them. Games are currently a one-to-many medium, just as photography and video were once the specialties of the scientists and engineers who invented them. Today the trend is shifting due to a confluence of factors that go beyond the avant-garde and back into the heart of the mainstream market. Game portals and online communities such as Kongregate.com, described by its founder as "videogames meet YouTube," empower members to create, upload, and share games. Other portals go further by facilitating and encouraging people to download and modify games uploaded by others, such as Electronic Arts' *Sims Carnival* (now closed due to financial cutbacks). Frasca advised game critics to welcome *Sims Carnival* as philanthropic. The "Game Creator" component of *Sims Carnival* was an easy-to-learn application allowing the creator to choose the level of depth at which they engaged the code. Those unfamiliar with programming could invoke a help wizard to select a genre, add or remove items or actions associated with that genre, and publish the game to the site. While projects like Kongregate, *Sims Carnival*, *Scratch*, and *Alice* are not avant-garde, that does not mean artists cannot learn from them or use them as a means to avant-garde ends.

The narrative political avant-garde has always been partially embedded in either popular culture (such as Brecht's work) or popular folk culture (such as Boal's work); it has, at least, always been eager to gain popular appeal. Brecht was aware of a dilemma that the narrative political avant-garde faced: if it is successful, it is no longer needed. Yet that remains the goal. The political avant-garde is driven to negate the need for its own existence. Meanwhile, contemporary specialists see the twilight of their reign over games on the horizon.

At the 2008 Game Developer's Conference, Rod Humble gave a lecture titled "The Emergent Gamer," in which he joked, "Professional game

design is an anomaly. Enjoy your jobs while you can . . . before the people take over!" (quoted in Diamante 2008). Frasca suggests this transition will appear less violent than intimated by Humble because it is not a zero-sum situation. There will simply be more people making games. He speculates that in order for a Videogames of the Oppressed to fully emerge, the movement needs a multitude of amateur auteurs. Game culture needs as many visionary creators as possible to work independently of the industry and its dominant market forces. Frasca (2004a) explains that a narrative political avant-garde will not become a mainstream social force "until major games are developed by biased authors that understand that fun is not the only thing that can be conveyed through this medium." Anna Anthropy (2012) has developed this idea the furthest. In her book *Rise of the Videogame Zinesters: How Freaks, Normals, Amateurs, Artists, Dreamers, Drop-outs, Queers, Housewives, and People Like You Are Taking Back an Art Form*, Anthropy asserts that countless "small, interesting, personal experiences by hobbyist authors" are necessary to mitigate widespread ignorance that limits who has the right to create games and why (quoted in Schulz 2012). To inspire the broadest possible player base to rise as playgrammers and amateur artists, a wildly diverse set of artists must first blaze many thousands of trails.

8 Conclusion

Call for Diversity

Brecht (1966) lamented, "Pity the nation that needs heroes." We should pity a game culture that needs an avant-garde. Galloway (2006, 126), a supporter of the videogame avant-garde, writes that the "movement should aspire to a similar goal [it had historically], redefining play itself and thereby realizing its true potential as a political and cultural avant-garde." He ends his book *Gaming: Essays on Algorithmic Culture* by stating that he awaits the end of the videogame avant-garde, echoing the 1965 claim of Jean-Luc Godard, who wrote, "I await the end of Cinema with optimism" (quoted in Milne 1972, 210). If the avant-garde succeeds, it becomes obsolete. When the average person has the knowledge, interest, tools, community, and skills to make any game we have examined, from *Untitled Game* to *Toywar*, the videogame avant-garde will be dead. Breaking and remixing game materials, sensations, and conventions will be as normal as they are in the liquid mediums of drawing, photography, or video. Art events and communities that promote the videogame avant-garde have been working toward that goal since the late 1990s. Anne-Marie Schleiner's curated exhibition in 1999, *Cracking the Maze: Game Plug-ins and Patches as Hacker Art*, Walter Langelaar's *DADAMACHINIMA* series in the 2000s, and the *Babycastles* game and art collective currently active in New York are a few examples.

This book is not a complete summary of the game avant-garde. It is a map of some avant-garde approaches to games as well as a preview of what we may see more of in the future as avant-garde strategies are appropriated by mainstream game culture. Each chapter has represented a facet of

a composite view. The avant-garde leads or protests the current state of games, and it does so in many ways, just as it historically led or protested mainstream art and culture in many ways. Within the avant-garde spectrum, there are a variety of roles to play for artists, critics, activists, educators, and storytellers. Videogames are a global medium played by hundreds of millions of people, largely dominated by corporate and government forces, and comprised of software, hardware, and network technologies in continual flux. The videogame avant-garde must be exceptionally plastic, numerous, and productive if it is to be collectively effective. The strategy of the videogame avant-garde will take many decades to unfold and can only be advanced in an ad hoc way by many thousands of people—people who may agree or disagree with one another, or most likely, are unaware of each other's work. As argued in chapter 7, videogames are in the process of liquefying, due in part to the diverse range of avant-garde forces that are breaking apart and using the medium in a multitude of ways.

This dynamic range of forces will be instrumental in the success of the avant-garde videogame movement. For this reason, we need an open theory of the avant-garde that welcomes diversity. This is a view championed by many, as discussed in the introduction (i.e., Hale, Harding, Drucker, and Foster). The avant-garde is important because it advances and redefines art, and it is responsible for constantly rediscovering how videogames can be art. Contemporary theories of art games should not repeat the same mistakes historically made by art critics and popular culture alike, such as reducing art to one type or another (e.g., expressive, rhetorical, and aesthetic). Unless we accept fundamental differences and contradictions in how we frame the genre of games, we will only illuminate one particular kind of art game. Understanding the value of games as art is predicated on embracing artistic diversity and ontological breadth.

While games are a medium of expression, it is crucial to understand them in a larger sense. Videogames are one of the most highly versatile, contemporary, and relevant mediums for authors to express their creative voices. As art and a political force, however, videogames are also more than a medium of expression. Expression has been the paradigm that delineates our understanding of videogames as art in both mainstream culture (insofar as games are even accepted as art in mainstream culture) and academia. That paradigm needs to be challenged, not because it is baseless, but so that alternate paradigms can coexist alongside it. Certain videogame

avant-gardes fall from our view when we advance a singular unitary perspective on art. We can see examples of this in some theorists' work, which provides us with useful and productive frameworks that nevertheless fall short in terms of inclusivity.

Mary Flanagan's *Critical Play* offers an illustration, which while groundbreaking theoretical work, is not adequately open to diversity. Flanagan begins by contending that "*Critical Play* is the first book to examine alternative games, and use such games as models to propose a theory of avant-garde game design." Even though she is focused on the avant-garde, Flanagan goes on to accept the idea that art is primarily concerned with expression: "*Critical Play* is built on the premise that, as with other media, games carry beliefs within their representation systems and mechanics. Artists using games as a *medium of expression*." Flanagan (2009, 1) emphasizes "medium of expression," which positions ideas as primary and mediums as secondary.

In such a framework, an artwork is a vehicle for an artist's idea. This is just one among many useful ways to consider game art. It makes sense to engage *September 12th* as an elegant model of Frasca's take on the war on terror, for instance. Yet when we constrain art to expression alone, we are bound within a hierarchy that places materials, sensations, and conventions in the service of ideas. Art as expression adopts a binary understanding of the term medium as both divisible from and subservient to an already-created "idea" of the author that is simply awaiting material delivery. The hierarchy is so rooted in contemporary thought that it provides the foundation of US copyright law: "Copyright protection subsists, in accordance with this title, in original works of authorship fixed in any tangible medium of expression."[1] The problem with basing a theory of art games on mainstream rather than historical, subcultural, or diverse definitions of art is that the avant-garde challenges mainstream definitions.

Bogost's *Persuasive Games* offers another example of a key theoretical work that nevertheless is not as open to diversity as it might be. In *Persuasive Games*, Bogost asserts that videogames are art because they can model rhetorical arguments: "All kinds of videogames, from mass-market commercial products to obscure art objects, possess the power to mount equally meaningful expression." Bogost (2007, ix) goes on to maintain that the fundamental quality of videogames arises from the medium's procedurality: "This power lies in the very way videogames mount claims through

procedural rhetorics." His explication of procedural rhetoric is worth reviewing:

> Procedural rhetoric is a general name for the practice of authoring arguments through processes. Following the classical model, procedural rhetoric entails persuasion—to change opinion or action. Following the contemporary model, procedural rhetoric entails expression—to convey ideas effectively. Procedural rhetoric is a subdomain of procedural authorship; its arguments are made not through the construction of words and images, but through the authorship of rules of behavior, the construction of dynamic models. In computation these rules are authored in code, through the practice of programming. (Ibid., 28–29)

Similar to Flanagan's view of games as vehicles for expression, Bogost qualifies videogames as art due to games' ability to express the rhetorical arguments of their authors through the games' procedures. It can be productive to understand some games from the perspective of expression or procedural rhetoric. *Untitled Game* by Jodi, for one, can be read as a critical statement or artistic expression. The main point to underscore is that any game or artifact can be read that way, or in any way we like. Nevertheless, if our goal is to cultivate the richest experiences and most comprehensive understanding of videogame art, then we should illuminate the most prominent and divergent features of works and events, and neither seek to constrain all game art to a single vantage point nor fold all game art into the dominant paradigm of mainstream culture. If we allow works and events to speak for themselves, then we may arrive at a more varied, open, and diverse understanding of art games. Returning again to Jodi's *Untitled Game* as an illustration, by taking a more diverse or open approach to understanding the game, we can see it as noteworthy in the way it renders tangible the underlying form of first-person shooter games, such as the genre's rituals, rules, and player expectations. If anything, it strips away expression or rhetorical argument to foreground the genre and engine's raw formal structure, thereby making that available to play.

Expression should be one foundational frame among many that we use to experience and think about videogame art. If we are talking about the broader purpose and potential of games as art, however, we must accept the fact that expression contradicts other key avant-garde frameworks. If this diversity is ignored, we repeat the same mistake art critics have made historically of collapsing the avant-garde into a single favored historical frame. Each of the formal chapters in this book (chapters 2, 4, and 6) has foregrounded alternate means of framing games as art, such as through the

medium's aesthetics, cybernetics, narrative, or experiential uncanniness. Many formal examples, such as *Façade*, were successful avant-garde works in spite of the best efforts and expressed intent of the artists.

In suggesting this opening of the ways in which we examine art games, this book follows the path laid by many who have come before in the discipline of art history and theory. Defining art as expression has been resisted by a multitude of artists and critics over the past century. Susan Sontag (2001) famously argued "against interpretation," rejecting the idea that art should be reduced to a vehicle of expression. Greenberg (1940) stated that painting should not become a "stooge of literature," limited to semiotic readings and literary criticism. From a formal perspective, paintings and games generate a multitude of frameworks for enjoyment, sensation, edification, and evaluation; the interpretation of expressions is only one of them.

In addition to the view of games along the formal line of expression, another commonly held restrictive perspective placed on the avant-garde is to regard it only along political lines. This stance is often found in academia. For such critics, games are art because they can deliver critical political expressions. Half of this book is dedicated to illuminating the political paradigms of avant-garde games. While politics does define much of the videogame avant-garde, it does not define all of it. Furthermore, when the avant-garde engages in politics, it does not generally advance expression but bottom-up power, utopia, anarchy, or liquidity instead. In *Critical Play*, Flanagan (2009, 11–12) frames the avant-garde in a political dimension entirely: "With the exception of purely aesthetic movements (abstract expressionism comes to mind), most twentieth-century art movements fostered interventionist activities and strategies, particularly those identified as the avant-garde." While Flanagan dismisses the aesthetic avant-garde as an exception, we must remember the aesthetic comprises one entire branch of the formal avant-garde. Works created in this mode are significant and numerous, and too important to be ignored. Furthermore, Flanagan's description of the avant-garde itself as entirely "interventionist"—or in other words, political—is a mischaracterization because it does not acknowledge these other facets. Looking to art history and theory again, Greenberg's (1939) seminal essay on the avant-garde, "Avant-garde and Kitsch," argues that the radical formal avant-garde is specifically not concerned with social issues but rather with aesthetics—art for its own sake. Videogames, too, can be played for their own sake. If every avant-garde

is evaluated for its political force, the abundance of formal and narrative avant-garde work is negated.

It should be noted as well that within the realm of politics, there is a tendency to restrict critical inquiry to work that falls within the progressive lens. This can lead critics to overlook radical political artists who adopt fascistic, militaristic, anarchistic, or wastefully celebratory worldviews—the futurists, Black Panther Party, Patriotic Nigras, Babeli, or GoonSwarm Alliance, to name a few. We must be uncomfortably inclusive and supportive of diversity when we discuss art games, especially in reference to the avant-garde. That is the only way to appreciate the stunning breadth of art games.

While Bogost and Flanagan frame videogame art as expressive, Galloway focuses on other formal properties. A considerate supporter of a radical formal avant-garde, Galloway nonetheless falters at a crucial point where games outstrip the established theories of art.[2] In *Gaming: Essays on Algorithmic Culture,* Galloway writes that the kind of avant-garde games created by Jodi and Condon serve "to hinder gameplay, not advance it. It eclipses the game as a game and rewrites it as a sort of primitive animation lacking any of the virtues of game design." Galloway (2006, 125) continues that we "need an avant-garde of video gaming not just in visual form but also in actional form. We need radical gameplay, not just radical graphics." His admonishment of Jodi's and Condon's works as "just radical graphics" betrays a lack of deep understanding about them. Such games expand the medium into new territory, beyond the bounds of serious inquiry as seen by academics such as Galloway. Galloway's shortsightedness on this point indicates the need for us to derive new theories that attend to the diversity of breakthroughs in art games.

Formal videogames by Jodi and Condon do advance gameplay, but they do so in fundamentally challenging, radical ways. The formal structures that facilitate flow have been exposed and defamiliarized. Works like *Untitled Game* are immanently playable as videogames, but the onerous challenge of these games is to rediscover how to play them as games. These games are difficult in ways similar to Manet and Pollock paintings, which challenged viewers to rediscover the medium of painting by figuring out how to view them as painting. The ways in which these paintings broke down space and liberally played with conventions were initially seen as evidence of poor craftsmanship. Viewers had to work through the unusual, difficult forms to reconceptualize the medium of painting.

Not All That's "Good" Is Avant-garde

The avant-garde does not have the final word on what to play, enjoy, support, or value in games. Just as we cannot reduce the avant-garde to a unified formal, political, or narrative framework, we cannot reduce all that is good or worthy of attention in games to a set of avant-garde frameworks. Citing historical feminism as an example, we can see that mainstream and avant-garde forces can be complementary. People who sometimes create avant-garde work are not therefore bound to create only avant-garde work. For instance, a radical political avant-garde artist might choose to take a break from radical politics to advocate for more venture capital and government grants for women and minority entrepreneurs. Or a person might support Jenkins's defense of games in his testimony before Congress and at the same time find value in the work of the Patriotic Nigras. Similarly, enjoying a mainstream franchise like *BioShock* does not preclude players from appreciating avant-garde games such as *Proteus*, *Dear Esther*, or *Panoramical*. In fact, the more a player engages the former, the easier it is to value the latter. To equate all that is good in games with the avant-garde is absurd. The game *flOw* by thatgamecompany is worthy of study and play, but it is not avant-garde because it facilitates flow in a straightforward way by design. Yet *flOw* helped launch thatgamecompany's popular success and set the benchmark for recent graduates wishing to form their own company. It is easy to be conflicted; *flOw* is culturally enriching because it opens up the market to more independent games, but it is culturally restrictive because it perpetuates the hegemonic flow ideal in the guise of something new. The avant-garde does not need to be a call to rigidity. We can appreciate both the avant-garde's multiplicity of strategies as well as the variety of work in mainstream games.

Cultivating a more diverse and accessible game culture requires strategies reaching far beyond the avant-garde. One clear strategy is to make games more representative of the diversity within game culture itself. In particular, there is an unbelievable amount of work to be done regarding women in game culture, and the avant-garde can only have so much impact. Normalizing women and acceptance of all genders in game culture—opening up more roles for women in both games and game companies—requires an active commitment from as many people as possible, in as many positions as possible. What game designers Brenda Laurel and Sheri Graner Ray have

been saying for years about women in games should surely be universally common sense by now, but it is not. The invisible hand of the market needs intervention and rehabilitation, according to Ray:

> The game industry has long been looking for the "silver bullet" that one magic title that all women will play. They thought they had it with the "pink" Barbie games. Then they thought they had it with the Sims games. Currently they think they have it with the "casual" online games. Each of these categories of games has made money, but each time it results in the same thing, the entire market of "women" is re-categorized as one genre. . . . There is no, one monolithic audience called "Women" who all want exactly the same thing in games. It actually is one million markets . . . each one with its own tastes and wants in entertainment. The only thing these markets share in common is a particular chromosomal make-up! (quoted in Bateman 2009)

From a radical political perspective, Ray could be condemned for being too incremental and complicit: she is basically saying that we need more games for women, while implying that we do not need a complete reboot of the conventional and technical systems in which mainstream culture limits plus regulates games. Recalling Hale's proclamation that feminism requires radical diversity within its own movement to be fully effective, Ray is wise to advocate for change complicit with mainstream game culture. Widespread, moderate changes that raise the cultural status and agency of women in games are as laudable and historical as any avant-garde effort. Feminism, along with every other battle for equality in games, needs much more than the avant-garde.

Instead of seeing the entire videogame avant-garde as a singular force, we must split our perspective across a range of contradictory views that are formal, political, radical, complicit, and narrative. Collectively, the avant-garde liquefies games. It breaks apart and diversifies what games are as well as can do. That is the cultural contribution of the avant-garde as a whole. To see this effort as fundamentally political is as self-defeating as seeing it as fundamentally formal. Each artist and player is multifaceted, as is the medium of games at large. By accepting each avant-garde strategy as a viable approach to understanding and creating games as art, a richer set of game experiences and purposes are plausible. By accepting the fundamental diversity in games, we support the medium's development and appreciate its plasticity, and this subsequently enables us to become more plastic as players or playgrammers, and more present as human beings.

Notes

1 Videogames as Avant-garde Art

1. The next few sentences are argued at greater length in Lister et al. 2009, 270.

2. PopCap, the developer of *Heavy Weapon*, is famous for its *Bejeweled* series, which sold more than twenty-five million copies from 2001 to 2008. See Ward 2008.

3. Gonzalo Frasca, *September 12th* (2003).

4. Flow, as a media concept, dates at least back to Raymond Williams's observation that television maintains a flow within and between programs.

2 Radical Formal

1. Critical theorist Fredric Jameson (1991, 67) describes an art medium similarly, "The word *medium* . . . now conjoins three relatively distinct signals: that of an artistic mode or specific form of aesthetic production, that of a specific technology, generally organized around a central apparatus or machine; and that, finally, of a social institution."

2. The loaded term *realism* is often used to describe this style of representation. The realism of the Renaissance is doubly relevant because the game industry has been following an analogous program for decades. The ghostly grid that merely guided the drawing of perspective is now the emblematic feature of computer graphics, applications like Maya, and game engines like Unreal.

3. Standing to the side warps the effect. In contrast, during the Middle Ages, a viewer could stand to the side of a painting and not have the same sense that their viewing position was wrong.

4. Noah Falstein (2005) first fleshed out the idea in game design terms that there must be an irregularity to the flow line.

5. In the 1980s, Jameson (1991, 16) noted that "our daily life, our psychic experience, our cultural languages, are today dominated by categories of space rather than

by categories of time." Time was the dominant cultural category of the nineteenth century and space was the dominant cultural category of the twentieth century.

6. Jodi published http://wwwwwwwww.jodi.org on returning to the Netherlands from California's Silicon Valley in 1993 at the start of the dot-com boom. For context, this was a year before Netscape, the first commercial Web browser, became widely available. Jodi uploaded an ASCII image of a hydrogen bomb onto the Web page where the HTML code should be. When a Web browser tried to load the page, it displayed as a garble of text blocks and flashing links. But if the user viewed the page source and HTML code directly, they could see the hydrogen bomb drawn out as an ASCII image. Under normal circumstances, the browser parses the HTML code and constructs human-readable Web pages. At Jodi.org the behind the scenes of these operations, their hidden forms and quirks, suddenly emerged on the surface of the screen.

7. Gamelab (2008a) announced, "With the recent launch of Arcadia Remix, we've retired this original version of the game. But it lives on in our game-playing hearts." It is regrettable that when it existed, Gamelab decommissioned what was clearly a more formal, experimental work.

3 Radical Political

1. "Much of the public activity of the Black Panthers was built around highly dramatic, stylized confrontations, often involving guns and the police. These are among the main actions that earned them notoriety. This theatricality was in many ways the most important cultural contribution of the Panthers, but it was also their greatest political limitation" (Reed 2005, 41–42).

2. According to animal behaviorist Gordon Burghardt (2006, 244), "Play may have been involved in the origin or elaboration of parental behavior." Birds fiddle and fuss with their offspring, trying this or that with their beaks, talons, breasts, and wings. The behavior "isn't energetically costly" but instead generates novel "adaptive repertoires," such as new grooming tricks and communication techniques.

4 Complicit Formal

1. See the Getty archives, http://blogs.getty.edu/pacificstandardtime/explore-the-era/archives/i29.

2. It is worth noting that although affordance mining may be used to play with technology beyond its established instrumental uses, it can also be used to instrumentalize and capitalize on technology in novel ways. Gunpei Yokoi invented Nintendo's Game & Watch and the Game Boy through a creative form of affordance mining. While riding the train in 1979, he witnessed a bored businessman playing with an LCD calculator by pressing the buttons. Yokoi came up with the idea of

"lateral thinking of withered technology." The notion was to develop game devices with cheap, existing technology rather than cutting-edge, expensive technology (Crigger 2007).

3. *Bishop's Game* was inspired by a scene in the film *Alien*, where the android, Bishop, pins a man's hand down and serially stabbed all the spaces between their own fingers at superhuman speed.

5 Complicit Political

1. For the sake of brevity, I'm including big games, pervasive games, immersive games, urban games, and chaotic fiction under the term ARG.

2. The original website has been removed, but it is archived: http://web.archive.org/web/20010410223227/http://www.familychan.org/evanchanpage.html.

3. The *Gonzo Gamers* included Alex Dahm and my students, David Finseth, Jorge Murillo, Mark Nauta, and Ricky Roberson.

4. "Literally, *Band of Brothers* is no more. They got a spy into the executor corp at director level, kicked out every corp, stole all the assets they could lay their hands on, and altered standings so that everyone will start shooting everyone else. And then they closed the alliance, and created a new corporation called *Band of Brothers* with the same corp ticker, so they can't even have the old alliance name back" (Gauger 2009).

6 Narrative Formal

1. See Boris Eikhenbaum's "Problems of Cine-Stylistics."

2. See *The Pervert's Guide to Cinema*, a 2006 documentary by Sophie Fiennes starring Žižek.

3. Charlie Kaufman pushed this technique even further in *Synecdoche, New York* (2008). Philip Seymour Hoffman's moving performance anchors the extensive metanarrative in this film.

4. This quote is specifically referring to the film *Twin Peaks: Fire Walk with Me* (1992).

5. Mateas quoted by Jonathan Rauch in "Sex, Lies, and Videogames" for *The Atlantic*, http://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2006/11/sex-lies-and-videogames/305293.

7 Narrative Political

1. This story requires Paik to have gotten hold of a prototype before Sony officially released the portapak in 1967, which is what Shigeko Kubota, Paik's wife, asserts.

Complicating the genesis story further is the fact that Andy Warhol was also shooting and screening videos in 1965.

2. Henry Jenkins's (2006b) concept of *convergence culture* can help measure this progress.

8 Conclusion

1. "Copyright protection subsists, in accordance with this title, in original works of authorship fixed in any tangible medium of expression, now known or later developed, from which they can be perceived, reproduced, or otherwise communicated, either directly or with the aid of a machine or device. . . . In no case does copyright protection for an original work of authorship extend to any idea, procedure, process, system, method of operation, concept, principle, or discovery, regardless of the form in which it is described, explained, illustrated, or embodied in such work" (quoted in "Copyright Law of the United States of America and Related Laws Contained in *Title 17 of the United States Code*," http://www.law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/17/102).

2. It is also worth noting that Galloway (2006) couches the entire videogame avant-garde in political terms, calling all of it "counter-gaming," although his evaluative method is grounded in formal analysis.

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